The Last of Us

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at http://archiveofourown.org/works/32228323.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
Graphic Depictions Of Violence

Categories:
F/F, F/M

Fandoms:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018), The Iliad - Homer, The Song of Achilles - Madeline Miller

Relationships:
Adora/Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Catra (She-Ra), Adora & Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow/Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow & Glimmer (She-Ra), Mermista/Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Catra & Scorpia (She-Ra)

Characters:
Mara (She-Ra), Adora (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra), Glimmer (She-Ra), Bow (She-Ra), Netossa (She-Ra), Spinnerella (She-Ra), Mermista (She-Ra), Sea Hawk (She-Ra), Scorpia (She-Ra), Zeus (Ancient Greek Religion & Lore), Hermes (Song of Achilles), Apollo (Ancient Greek Religion & Lore), Angella (She-Ra), He-Man | Adam, King Randor, Shadow Weaver | Light Spinner (She-Ra)

Additional Tags:
Historical AU, Ancient Greece AU, Gods and Goddesses AU, Angst and Hurt/Comfort, Angst with a Happy Ending, Hurt/Comfort, Friends to Lovers, Implied/Referenced Child Abuse, Blood and Violence, Adora is in Love with Catra (She-Ra), Catra (She-Ra) Needs a Hug, Princess Adora (She-Ra), glimmer and Adora are sisters, Light Hope is Chiron, Scorpia is a demigod, mermista is Helen of Troy, mermista is a demigod, Good Parent Angella (She-Ra), angella is a goddess, Minor Netossa/Spinnerella (She-Ra), spinnerella is a demigod, Adora is Achilles, Adora (She-Ra) Needs a Hug

Language:
English

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Part 1 of They Both Die In The End

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Published: 2022-11-13 Words: 53,504 Chapters: 15/15

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The Last of Us

by UnderTheMoonlitDay

Summary

Updated November 13, 2022:

This story is now marked as completed! It is set up as a prequel for the real story which will be published later as I write more content for it!

A woman stolen from her husband. A prophecy about the best of the Etherians. A legendary war…

Adora always knew her life hung in a balance. She had heard prophecies hung over her like storm clouds. But when a young, banished magicat appears in her life, suddenly those prophecies don't matter anymore

OR

The Trojan War (prequel) story no one asked for, where Adora is Achilles (but not a dick) and Catra is Patroclus

Notes

Hello beautiful people!

I've been obsessed about the Trojan War and Greek mythology for awhile now, so when I read The Song of Achilles, I needed to write something with She-Ra in it. Thus, this story is born! I have two chapters and the prologue complete so far, and I'm gonna keep working away at it! I'll try to update every week but deadlines and I don't mix!

Currently the chapters are set to ? but the more I write and get an idea of where the story is going, that will change. Thanks for stopping by! Without further adieu, enjoy!

See the end of the work for more notes

Prologue: The Blood in Our Veins

Sing, muses, of brave Randor and his demigod children, of Adora and Adam destined to fight, of Adora and her lover, Catra, and the war of legendary proportions…

Mortals were not invited to Olympus often. That is what King Randor of Eternia was thinking as he made his way to the craggy peak of the mountain, and stared up at the home of the gods. They were watching him. From a palace built of mighty thunderheads and marble, Zeus sat impassively, his sky blue eyes giving nothing away. *At least they aren't thunderclouds,* his mind murmured.

The other Olympians were staring at him as well, and he fought the urge to shrink under their gaze like a chastised child. He was not a small man. In fact, he was quite large, with the blood of Heracles adding strength to his muscles. He was the king of a small and humble kingdom on the far reaches of Etheria. He always valued his relationship with the gods above all else in his life, and tried to rule as fairly as possible. In short, he had no idea why he was summoned to Olympus.

"Randor, son of Miro," Zeus said in a voice of crackling lightning and pounding rain. "Blood of my blood. I welcome you to the halls of your gods."

"My thanks, great god," he replied, bowing deeply. "I am honoured to be asked here, though I know not the reason."

He heard a noise, like the shifting of fabric as someone settles in a chair, and suddenly a massive hand was on his shoulder. He glanced up, startled, and found Zeus in all ten feet of his glory standing over him. His face was like a clear day, camaraderie clear beneath the curls of his thick, black beard.

"Son of my blood have no fear. We see how you worship us, and we have invited you here as a reward!"

He tried to hide his suspicions but the gods must've seen something on his face. They laughed lightly.

"He does not believe you, father," Apollo said, his dark golden eyes twinkling in amusement. "He will need to be convinced."

"That's not—" but before Randor could finish the sentence, Zeus was waving his hand.

The gods parted and a woman walked through, her blond hair and blue eyes glowing with godly light. Her skin was the deep shade of hammered bronze and she stood easily eight feet tall. A minor goddess, not one of the Olympians but still powerful.

"I present to you She-Ra, goddess of war," intoned the King of the gods. Randor bowed his head low. She-Ra said nothing, her face a mask of indifference. "She is to be your wife."

“My wife?” His head shot up in alarm. He was an older king, truly, though the grey had not touched his deep red hair or beard yet. He had never taken a wife, as he had no time to court any of the women that his courtiers suggested or threw at his feet. He glanced at the goddess and found her scowling fiercely. It was not something she wanted. “Does the goddess agree to this?” He would not take an unwilling wife.

“Nonsense,” growled Zeus, the clouds of annoyance flickering over his powerful face. “For your homage to us and your unerring faith, we give you this goddess. She will marry you, it has been decided by the pantheon.”

“I will not!” She hissed, unsheathing the sword that lay at her waist. “I would rather fight him to the death than marry!”

“Virgin goddesses,” snorted some god in the crowd. “Think they are so *above* everyone else.”

“Do you wish to face my wrath, Mara?” Zeus rounded on her, standing to his full height. Thunder grumbled across the sky and his eyes turned white as lightning flickered in his hair. He used a lesser known name for the goddess, one that caused her to wince, though she boldly drew herself up in Zeus’ face.

“May I propose a wager?” Randor found himself speaking. He clamped his jaws shut but now all the gods’ eyes were on him, predatory interest alight in all of them. “Perhaps the lady and I may duel? Should she win, she may take my life and my kingdom. Should I win, I take her hand in marriage.”

She-Ra's eyes went round in shock. "I do not kill mortals needlessly, nor will I marry you!" She snarled like a wolf.

"That's only if you win that you would kill me, my lady." He smiled jovially at her and the gathering of gods murmured of his boldness. "And should you marry, I would only have you for a year. One year is the blink of an eye in your immortal life. Should it be so horrible? Once the year is up you may do as you please, it shall not cause me any harm." The goddess frowned, her immortal face one of confusion. In all her long life, had anyone shown her any such kindness before? He turned back to Zeus, whose eyes were now the dark grey of a winter storm. Randor bowed lowly. "Does this please you, mighty King of the Gods?"

The god chuffed like a lion and waved his hand. "So be it. The duel will commence at midday."

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When midday rolled around in a little over an hour after Randor spoke with the gods, he found himself in an amphitheatre, surrounded on all sides by gods, Titans, nymphs and satyrs. Zeus and the other Olympians sat in a special, boxed off area while the others gods and goddesses mingled with the other spirits who dwelt on Olympus.

"Are you sure this is what you want, mortal?" Someone asked behind him. He turned ad found She-Ra—Mara—standing behind

him, dressed in a winged helmet, a golden cuirass, golden gauntlets and winged sandals. She looked completely in her element, though her eyes were wary. “There is a good chance you may not see your family again after today.”

“What family?” He responded. He was dressed in a heavy wool tunic, with a bronze breastplate and supple leather sandals. It wasn’t the most protective equipment but it had served him well in the wars and adventures he had had growing up. He picked up his ash wood spear and examined the iron tip carefully. “The only family I knew died years ago. I have no wife or heirs of my own. Should I die, then my name will be sung for eons in wonder, for I died facing a goddess. I am not ashamed by my wager.”

The goddess blinked slowly, and a grudging type of respect flickered briefly in her blue-grey eyes. Before more could be said between the two of them, a roar went up through the crowd as Zeus stood from where he sat on his throne.

“Randor, son of Miro, has challenged She-Ra, Mara, daughter of Zeus to a duel! Should he win, he shall have her hand in marriage, with She-Ra unable to challenge for one year. Should She-Ra win, she shall have the kingdom of Eternia, and Randor’s life should she wish it. The duel will be until first blood. These terms are binding as the word and will of the gods. This has been agreed upon by the Olympians and I swear on the River Styx that these terms will be followed through!”

There was a rumble in the air. Randor could feel the oath spoken by Zeus tightening around his heart and knew that he would die if he tried anything out of what they agreed. He nodded

apprehensively as the god signalled to begin, and he looked at his opponent.

He barely had time to use his spear to deflect her blow as she swiped her sword at him. His arms rang with the effort and panic flared behind his eyes.

What was I thinking? She is a goddess of war! How am I going to beat her? Despite his brave words, he feared his imminent death, and the stories the gods would tell of this for eons to come. Of brave, foolish Randor who looked a gift horse in the mouth and questioned the will of the gods, and died for his idiocy. Again, She-Ra slammed her sword against the shaft of his spear. Wood chipped from it with cracks that made his heart leap in fear.

Control your fear, spoke the voice of his father in his head. *You have the blood of gods and heroes in you, the strongest warrior to ever live. Harness their power and fight!*

She-Ra was relentless. She came at him like a bull in a red fury, slashing and hacking in a raw and gruesome kind of beauty. She twirled and came at him at every angle. Finally, he dropped the two halves of his spear and twisted himself, coming up as the goddess turned with his own bronze sword raised. Within a few moments, he had sweat stinging his eyes. He had no idea how she hadn't hit him yet. He was giving ground more than he was gaining it, and hadn't the chance to go on the offensive yet.

"Are you sure this is what you want mortal?" She hissed in his ear as bronze and steel clanged with a harsh twang. "Are you certain

this is worth fighting for?”

His limbs were leaden. He did not know how much time had passed, nor could he hear the wailing crowd. He was locked in a deadly dance with the spirit of war herself and his strength was reaching it’s limit. He panted heavily. She struck him in the chest with the pommel of her sword, denting the metal to his body. He coughed but ducked as that steel tip came down to strike him. It just missed his skin but sliced the buckles off his breastplate. He slipped out of the now useless armour and continued to duck and weave as she hacked. Right when he felt like he was going to faint, he felt it.

There, deep in his gut, was the stirring of a power long dormant. The well of strength and energy he did not know resided in him flooded his limbs and gave him a second wind. He flew back to his feet and suddenly, he was on the offensive. Hack after sloppy hack was bounced off that impossibly beautiful sword, but now She-Ra’s eyes were lit in a kind of excitement. Never before had someone fought back! This would be interesting.

The fight lasted all day and into the night. They seemed evenly matched with the trickle of immortal strength that found its way into Randor’s muscles, but one of them was going to win soon. He could feel the fatigue in his arms like a deadweight. Even She-Ra was panting, though no sweat yet marred her perfect skin.

It was a lucky hit. He had slipped on the now slick sand and as he went down, he thrust outwards with his sword. It was not enough to even be considered a wound, but still, She-Ra winced and glanced down at her thigh. There was a small scratch, and as they

stared at it, a drop of golden ichor welled and fell to the ground, mixing with Randor's sweat.

The moment it did, Apollo sat up straighter, his eyes blank and faraway. Zeus noticed too, his all-knowing gaze always landing on his son as he went through a vision, twitching and muttering silently with lips moving. As he came down from the vision, he turned to his father with eyes of liquid bronze, his prophet's eyes.

"There will be twins," he rasped. "Twins who hold the power of life and death in their hands. One shall die with the blood of the other on its hands. Both will be more powerful than their father, with strength and prowess in battle. Their strength will be enough to challenge even the gods themselves."

Zeus was nothing if not a paranoid god. His face paled as he looked down at the two beings in the arena. This could be very dangerous indeed. He stroked his beard thoughtfully.

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Randor and Mara held up their end of the deal and were married shortly after their fight. Mara's eyes were dulled with defeat although she did her best to not allow her miserableness to interfere with her new husband's life. She transformed herself into a more mortal friendly appearance. Her bright, blonde hair became brown and her figure shrank until she was only a head shorter than her husband instead of towering over him.

She never helped him with the ruling, only wandering the orchards and grounds of Grayskull, where they lived. Randor proved to be a gentle lover, and for that she tolerated lying with him, though both knew she only did so as she was bound to him for a year. When she became pregnant despite the odds, she wept. She only grew more apprehensive as she learned they were twins, having heard the prophecy Apollo spoke at their wedding.

Randor, on the other hand, was over the moon. He had forgotten the prophecy and instead just saw the future for his kingdom. Hopefully both would be boys and he could teach them the ways of combat and court, so they could rule together. But if both were girls, then he could marry them off to trusted princes across the land and their husbands could rule together.

The children arrived a few days before Mara's sentence was up. She was giddy and restless and hadn't noticed the signs of labor until they nearly bowled her over. It was a long and hard affair, which lasted almost three days.

The first of the twins was a male, golden and glowing with the light of his mother. He was robust, with a strong set of lungs and a full head of deep, red-gold hair. He would be powerful indeed. His eyes were all his father's, dark and kind even at birth. Randor held him aloft and laughed in joy, pronouncing him then and there as Adam, son of Randor and heir to Grayskull and all of the united lands of Eternia.

The second twin was a slight and petite female, giving way to her brother's glory even in the womb. She was smaller than him and more fragile. The god aura was still present, though with her it was much less noticeable. Mara could still sense power in her

daughter, but it wasn't overwhelming. She was made nothing like her father. Her body was the same shape as Mara's mortal disguise; she would be tall and slim when she grew. She had a few wisps of white-blonde hair, a shade or two off from her immortal mother's true hair colour, and when she opened her eyes, Mara's icy heart melted. Her eyes were her mother's, pale grey-blue and sharp as a hawk's. She held her daughter close and murmured to her while Randor doted on his son. He could not think of a name for her, so for the last few days that Mara was in Grayskull, her daughter lay unnamed, forgotten by the nurses and her father alike in the beauty and charm of her brother.

"I must leave," Mara announced on the day she was to leave. She knew she did not need to offer an explanation, but Randor had been good to her this past year. "This world was not meant to have a goddess as a mortal's queen for long. It is time I return to my family."

Randor peeled his eyes off of charming little Adam and looked mournfully at his wife. In truth, he had appreciated her company this past year. She had lit up the kingdom with her grace and had given him twins in return.

"At least let me give you something of me so that you may remember me in Olympus." He set down their son and picked up his daughter, cradling her close to him. She may not be as awe-inspiring as her brother, but he still loved her. She was his blood, after all. Tears welled in his eyes as he held her out to her mother. "Please, take our daughter with you. You have seen how us mortals are captivated with her brother, and how she is forgotten in his shadow. Take her with you, so that she may dine and rule with the Olympians as a goddess in her own right."

Mara blinked down at the infant, who was watching her with unfocused, serious eyes. She could leave, forget it all ever happened and start again as a detached and impersonal goddess, but in truth, she loved her children, and couldn't bear to leave them behind. She hesitantly accepted the swaddled baby in her arms, cradling her close to her chest as she transformed back into her true form. Adam cried out for fright, and Randor shielded his eyes, but her daughter just blinked slowly and put a tiny hand on her mother's large face.

She let out a watery laugh, kissed her son gently, and then was gone, bounding through the land as only a goddess could, her precious child pressed close to her chest. As the summit of Olympus came into view, so did her brother, Hermes.

The god of messages held out a hand to stop her from speeding past him.

"Hello, sister," he greeted her. "Have you returned from your stay with the mortals?"

"Yes," she sighed, feeling more at home then she had in a year. "It is good to be home."

"What is that, in your arms?"

“My daughter. She has no name, I was hoping our father Zeus might be able to name her something worthy of her god status.”

The trickster god snorted. “God status? Sister, she is mortal.”

“The blood of She-Ra flows through her,” Mara snapped, a hand over the baby’s ears as if to prevent her from hearing. “That makes her a god in her own right.”

“The blood of the mortal also flows here. Father has decreed that neither of your children may enter Olympus. You must return her to her father, or else leave her somewhere for the wolves and lions to find her.”

She snarled so fiercely that her daughter whimpered. Hermes held up his hands.

“He is worried about the prophecy. Do you really want to test Zeus and his wrath? Do you not remember the Titans? Prometheus? You know how Zeus can be about slights against him. I wasn’t even supposed to warn you, but I do for the love I bear you. Leave the child. Come home with me.”

He held out a hand and Mara stared, grief-stricken at her daughter. How could she defy the will of the King of the Gods? But how could she leave her daughter to die on the mountain side? She cradled her daughter close and hummed softly to soothe the frightened baby. She turned her back on Olympus.

When she returned hours later, she was bereft of her child and her eyes were dulled. “It is done,” she muttered to Hermes, who still waited.

“Excellent. Come home, sister. We miss you.”

As he made his way through the streets of Olympus, Mara paused and turned back to the wilderness of the mountain side, where the moon was rising. “Farewell, Adora.”

***

Far below her, on a mountain slope near Bright Moon, a baby was crying. Angella, Selenae, the Titan goddess of the moon, looked down at her with a frown. She was bare, with nothing but the tip of a spear resting against her pale skin. The poor thing was wailing, starving and angry at the parent who left her on a goat path.

She took pity on the scrap, and landed nearby, folding her wings and approaching slowly. She picked up the spear first and immediately was overcome with a vision. A blur of images and a voice saying, *Adora, daughter of Mara.*

Angella blinked in shock and looked down again at the small child. She could see her sister’s pale blue eyes, the familiar rage in that

face, and her blonde hair. There was no doubt. She scooped up the infant and looked towards the distant castle near the sea. She and Micah had been trying for ages to have a child of their own. Was her sister's child adopted as her own good enough?

As she held the child, she reached out and grabbed a small fistful of Angella's hair in her fury. Her heart melted at the innocent girl. If she did not take her, she would die. She used a fold in her dress to bundle the small babe into her arms, and then lifted herself into the sky to take off for home.

And that is where our story begins…

Chapter 1: Banish These Fears

Chapter Notes

> Happy Thursday everyone! I have to update earlier than Sunday because I won't be within internet and I didn't want anyone to wait longer than necessary! Catra and Adora meet in this chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The first time Catra had met her, she was nine years old and had just arrived in Bright Moon. She was supposed to be presented to King Micah and Queen Angella and beg them forgiveness for what she had done, but the guard had said that they were away on business. Which left the heir to greet the exiled royal herself. She was led to a room in the hallway of the royal sleeping quarters. It was fairly large, with a waterfall in one corner and a canopy bed dominating the centre of the room. Adora, the princess Shadow Weaver always wanted Catra to be like, sat in a corner, playing with figurines alongside a younger girl with glittery pink hair. When the little magicat was escorted into the room, both girls looked up from where they were playing.

"Who is she?" The blonde one asked the guard on Catra's right, a serious look in her eye that did not match the childhood roundness of her body.

"She doesn't look like much," sniffed the other girl, her nose tilted up. Catra immediately didn't like her.

"An exile from the Fright Zone," the guard told the princess. "She just arrived."

Those serious, winter-sky blue eyes met Catra's gold-and-blue ones. "What's your name?"

"Catra, your highness," she replied, ears back and head bowed. She tried to keep her tail from quivering as both the royals studied her.

"We haven't had a magicat here before," said the other girl, her sparkly dark coloured eyes gleaming as if a chef had just presented her with a new recipe to try. Catra couldn't control the small snarl that formed on her face. The guards tensed beside her, but seemed more amused than anything.

"I don't like being talked about," she growled warningly. Adora, to her surprise, let out a small giggle, the serious frown smoothening on her face. Once again, she was a child like Catra, not the unreachable royal she had been moments before.

"I am Adora, and this is Glimmer. Don't mind her, she wakes up and chooses violence everyday." The girl named Glimmer mocked a gasp and tackled Adora. They both descended into a playful tussle, giggling the whole time. After a moment, Adora pushed Glimmer away and sat up straighter, turning her eyes back onto Catra.

"The guards can take you to the Barracks! That's where all the exiles go. Netossa said she already took your things there! Dinner is in two hours! The guards come to get us when Daddy and

Mommy—er I mean King Micah and Queen Angella—are gone. Until then, my castle is yours.” She spread her arms and bowed towards Catra, who returned the favour awkwardly. She didn’t understand. Didn’t the royal want to know what had happened to her? What kind of exile she had in her kingdom? But the girl was already playing with her toys again with her sister, and the guards were escorting Catra out of the room.

She was led away from the royal family’s halls, down the stairs to the main floor, where they walked through the cathedral-like throne room and took a passage on the right of the main doors down a warm and softly lit hall. They passed the guardhouse, the kitchens, and the servants’ quarters. The halls and floor of the palace so far had been cobbled sandstone with plush rugs on the floor and torch braziers to keep the hallway soft and welcoming. The further they went, the more worn out it looked. The walls were rougher, scratched and cracked in places, and the floor became well-worn, grooved trails pounded into it from generations of feet stepping on it. They came to a stop just as Catra was beginning to think they were secretly going to throw her out of the palace. The place they had stopped was in front of a wooden wall with a big, oak door. It looked like this ancient structure had been eaten by the stone walls; where sandstone met timber it melded smoothly. There was a bronze knocker on the door, and one of the guards knocked three times with it.

Catra pricked her ears, allowing the noise from the other side of the door reach her. She almost reeled backwards as the motion amplified all the sounds in the air. There were children on the other side of the door! The sound of raucous laughter, the clatter of wooden swords and the endless chatter swirled around her ears. She was almost surprised the guards didn’t appear to hear anything.

"You may want to knock again," she mumbled. She fanned back her ears, turning off the sensitive nerves that allowed her to hear so well, so she was back to a relatively regular level of hearing for most humanoids. She was taught that this was proper etiquette, to dull her hearing to a regular level so she could not eavesdrop on the inner workings of a person through their heartbeat. Even though she had picked up the slightest double-tap from Shadow Weaver's heartbeat that showed she was lying as she said it.

Both of the guards regarded her oddly for a moment, so she rolled her eyes and motioned to her ears. Understanding dawned swiftly on their faces and they knocked again, this time louder. It did the trick. The chatter, which was muffled to regular ears, ceased on the other side. The door open and the girl took a step back, trying to keep her fur flat. No wonder Adora didn't ask what Catra's crime was. Inside the wooden room were about twenty children, all exiles from other kingdoms, around what looked like a large sleeping hall. They were mostly sitting or standing in small groups, but there was a group of three with wooden swords sparring in the middle of the room, where a space had been cleared of beds. Everyone was staring at her, so Catra steeled herself and lifted her chin. *I will not be weak*.

The girl who opened the door was a teenager, probably fifteen or sixteen, and Catra had to tilt her head back to fully see her. Her hair was snowy white, contrasting with her dark skin. She had sharp, fierce features and she quirked an eyebrow at her.

"So you're the new one," she observed, not surprised. She nodded to the guards and motioned Catra in. "I've got this from here. Your stuff is already here, Spinny and I got you a bunk all set up. I'm Netossa."

“Catra,” she responded, trying to make her voice sound less squeaky and young. She looked around as she followed Netossa. Most of the beds were bunk beds, and most of the kids were older than her, between the ages of ten and sixteen. It was clear that Netossa was a leader of sorts for them. They all watched her and Catra pass, most dipping their heads or making a hand motion of respect before turning back to their activities, satisfying their curiosity with a glance at the new kid for now.

“Welcome to your new home, Catra. We all end up at Bright Moon for a reason; you’re not the only lost, exiled or outcast child here. We won’t ask you what you did, but you can share if you want to.”

The girl grunted, eyes darting around, looking for ways of escape if she needed. Netossa must’ve saw it on her face, because her rough features softened a little. “It doesn’t matter what you did before. We are a family here, as beloved by King Micah and Queen Angella as either of their children.”

Then why are we tucked away between the servants and the horses? Catra thought bitterly. She didn’t voice her thoughts, just flattened her ears further and tried to stop her tail from lashing. She didn’t want another family. She just wanted to go home and make Shadow Weaver proud.

The older girl drew them to a stop in the far corner of the room, where stone and wood walls met seamlessly. “Here we are! We heard you were a magicat, so we gave you the top bunk for some extra privacy.”

“Thanks.” She blinked in surprised at the hospitality in Netossa’s words and actions. No one had done anything like that for her before. The teen nodded and her eyes wandered to a violet haired girl around the same age a little ways off. She caught Netossa’s eye and waved, a light blush on her cheeks. Catra tried not to, but could hear the other girl’s heart quicken.

“Why don’t you get settled in, Catra? The guards will come get us for dinner, and then after I will take you on a tour of the palace.”

“Okay.” Netossa was already walking away before the word had even left Catra’s mouth, and she found herself alone for the first time since she arrived in Bright Moon. She gulped as instantly, a wave of homesickness and guilt flooded her mind.

She shook her head as her thoughts tried to overtake her, then she climbed her way to her bed, not bothering to use the ladder. She relished in the feeling of her muscles stretching, giving her strength as she pushed and pulled her way to the top bunk.

Her bed was plain, a thick grey blanket over a white sheet, a slightly lumpy pillow and a firm mattress. Her one luxury was that there was a narrow window built into the stone wall at the foot of her bed. It was small, but if she was to open it, she would be able to squeeze her way out. It was something to note if she ever needed a fast escape. Her belongings (a spare change of clothes and the headpiece she had stolen from Shadow Weaver on the way out the door) were tucked neatly on the deep window sill. She didn’t really have anything to “settle in” to, so she laid out her

clothes the way she liked, and tucked her legs under herself to watch the other kids around her.

Netossa was sitting on the bottom bunk of a nearby bed, her arm around the purple haired girl and her eyes were soft. They were playing a game with wooden dice and a couple of the older children. The sparring kids were back at it, another hybrid—Catra was mildly surprised, though he was the more common reptile hybrid rather than another magicat—and a girl with dusty brown braids seemed to be ganging up on a runty blonde boy. One of them distracted him while the other would hit him with the flat of their sword when he tried to defend himself from the distracter. He looked like he was on the verge of tears, but he was determined and not giving up.

When he finally landed a hit on the big green reptilian, all three of them cheered and threw down their swords. The lizard-boy lifted the smaller boy up and paraded him around the room while everyone cheered.

Catra curled her lip and pressed herself deeper into the bed, trying not to be seen. Back in the Fright Zone, weakness like his would've been trained out at a much younger age. There would've been no celebration. She still remembered the day she landed her first hit. And the beating that followed. She had just turned seven and had figured out how her claws worked. It took two weeks for her recover after that training session. She couldn't see how praising this weakness was useful at all. Hers had taught her how to hit harder and dodge better, once she had recovered.

The celebration was still going on when another knock came at the door, and a guard appeared. Catra cringed, knowing he was

about to be punished for slacking off and having fun. She turned her back so she wouldn't have to see the punishment that was sure to come, but instead, the guard only announced "Dinner time!" which was met with more whoops and shouts.

Catra's jaw dropped in shock. He wasn't going to get reprimanded?! What was the guard thinking?

"Catra? You awake?" A voice called. She turned and found Netossa smiling up at her. "Hey! It's dinner time! You coming?"

She nodded and slid off the bed, landing lightly on her feet beside the teenager. She followed the flow of children out of the room, the Barracks Adora had called it, down the maze of halls towards an informal dining hall.

"The King and Queen are still away, so the princesses will join us in the servants' kitchen. It's warmer and cozier there," Netossa explained.

"Is that boy not going to be punished for his weakness?" Catra blurted out, pointing at the blonde boy skipping happily with his two friends in front of them.

Netossa fixed Catra with a funny look. "Who, Kyle? Why would he get punished? He kept fighting and even landed a hit on Rogelio. That was the first time he was able to do so without them going easy on him."

"In the Fright Zone, he would've been beat until he could stop *all* the blows," she said, a hint of a growl in her voice. Netossa was silent, her expression unreadable as she observed Catra.

Finally, after Catra looked away, Netossa said in a strange, strangled tone, "I don't know how things were done in the Fright Zone, but here in Bright Moon, bravery and the courage to keep going are rewarded, not punished!" She walked away faster than Catra could keep up with, and disappeared into the mass of children.

The feline hung back, feeling like she had swallowed a swarm of bees that were churning in her stomach.

***

The servant dining hall *was* cozy. It was a long, wood planked room off the back of the palace. It had a low, slanted ceiling, so low that the taller guards and servants had to duck under the threshold when they entered. It was built that way to keep the heat in during the cold Etherian winter nights, and the thinly paned windows had perpetual steam from the massive kitchen just beyond pumping out food and heat all day everyday.

It was so humid in fact, that as soon as Catra walked in, her fur clumped together into tufts and her breaths felt hot, wet and like she was getting more water than air into her lungs. She almost panicked, letting out a small cough, but a guard pushed open a

door on the far side of the room, letting in bright light from outside along with the fresh crisp smells and cooler air from the outdoors. She caught a glimpse of the stables, heard the whinnies and snorts of horses nearby, and for a moment she debated darting out the door.

There were several tables scattered throughout the hall, and Catra picked the one with the least amount of seats the furthest away from the hot kitchen and closest to the fresh air outside. It helped keep her fur flat and her nerves calm as she felt the cool breath of spring against her back.

"Is this seat taken?" Someone asked, jolting Catra from her thoughts. She blinked in surprise and looked up at someone she had mistaken for a guard. The girl was huge, tall with a broad frame already swelling with muscle, despite her youthful face and voice. She wore black and red armour, the sigil of a House Catra remembered learning about but could not remember, and a scorpion's tail sprouted from the base of her spine. The other girl smiled expectantly, her black eyes gleaming with a friendly light. Catra shook her head to unfreeze herself. She didn't want to get on this girl's bad side.

"Oh, thanks!" The girl said, sitting down in the chair with such a force that she slammed her spiky shoulder plate right into Catra's cheek. She bit back a hiss of annoyance and slid her chair back a fraction. "Man, I am. *Starving*! I wonder what's on the menu tonight? Do you have a favourite food? Mine is..." and on she jabbered like a songbird.

She rambled on ceaselessly, despite Catra's flattened ears and twitching tail. The feline had stopped paying attention until a large

pincer poked her. She yelped in a very undignified manner and nearly leapt out of her seat. She thought the girl had regular hands! What were those! The pincer retreated, and when Catra glanced at the girl, she found her hurriedly burying the hurt in her eyes under a crooked smile.

"Ah... sorry, about that. Sometimes I forget not everyone is used to seeing something like me! Don't worry, though! I don't pinch or sting—" she motioned to her tail—"unless threatened. Who are you, by the way? I'm Scorpia!"

"Catra," she replied curtly, letting her fur lie flat. She didn't come here to make friends, but she didn't come here to make enemies either. Besides, something about that name rung a bell. Where had she heard it before? She wracked her brain, remembered where she had heard it before, and then hesitantly flared her nostrils to take in Scorpia's scent. She mostly smelled like whatever she had done that day, dirt, sweat, the iron tang of swords and blades, the smoky smell of fire and heat, but beneath it—

Catra had met a demigod once. She had been brought (dragged) out of the Fright Zone to meet a girl relatively close to her age, a couple years older than her, in the kingdom of Salineas. Shadow Weaver had offered Catra as a suitor for the girl, Mermista, daughter of the sea god Oceanus. She was rumoured to be the most beautiful mortal in Etheria, but Catra hadn't seen what the big deal was. All she really remembered of Mermista now was the frost and star scent than blended with her natural sea-salt scent.

Scorpia had the same, mingled star-and-frost smell amongst her own scent.

"You're a demigod," Catra breathed, eyes flying wide. Her brain clicked into place where she had heard the name and her stomach dropped. "Oh gods, you're that Scorpia!" Scorpia who had finished eight of twelve labours even though she was only fourteen to please her mother and raise her to godhood. She was the only demigod besides Heracles to finish so many of her labours at such a young age.

"Hmm? Oh, yeah," she fiddled with her pincers sheepishly, a blush dusting her cheeks. "Yeah, I guess I am. My mother is Nyx, goddess of the night. Well, she's one of my mothers anyways." She looked so lonely, so small for such a large presence, that Catra felt a dash of pity despite herself. But then Scorpia's black eyes flashed to Catra and she hit her emotions behind a mask of indifference. "Does that matter?"

Does it matter? Scorpia, probably the most powerful demigod in the world right now, was asking her if it bothered her about her parentage? Catra regarded the girl in front of her, took in the loneliness she saw, and knew that Scorpia was similar to her, never adding up to enough in her immortal mother's eyes to be worthy of her affection, always needing to change something about herself to make her proud. The feline stared down at her claws, the same ones that ripped flesh and blood only a few days ago, and she shuddered. She was fairly certain Scorpia hadn't killed anyone like she had. She wrapped her tail tighter around her leg and looked down at the table in front of her.

"No, it doesn't," she murmured softly. *Not when your mother is worse than any god.* She didn't say that bit out loud, but she didn't need to. There was silence in the conversation for the first

time since Scorpia sat down. Catra glanced up and found the older girl's eyes wet and shiny, and a small, watery smile lit her face bright. Catra stiffened and lifted her lip, showing off the fang that was just starting to grow in. "Don't look at me like that!" She hissed, harder this time. "It's not like we are friends or anything!" She hardly needed any friends. Besides, who would want to befriend her after learning what she had done? And how could she really trust someone if she couldn't even share her secret?

Scorpia opened her mouth to say something, but before she could, the doors at the front of the room opened and everyone stood. The princesses had arrived. The blonde one, Adora, led the way in, smiling a gap-toothed cheeky grin at some of the guards and children. Glitter, or Sparkles, or whatever her name was followed close behind, and a boy in a white tunic that didn't cover his midriff was a step behind the young princess, a gold, elaborate bow in his hand that dwarfed him. He looked vaguely uncomfortable, but his eyes were trained on the pink haired princess and he had a determined lift to his chin.

"What's up with him?" Catra murmured to Scorpia, who ducked her head a bit to hear Catra,

"That's Bow," she explained as the princesses and Bow sat at a table on the other side of the room. Immediately, everyone in the room relaxed, most sitting back down, while a couple made their way over to the princesses' table and sat down beside the girls. Some gave Bow a pat or a grin or a wave, but most ignored him. "He's one of us! A refugee from Thaymor, I think. He made his way here with his family a year ago, and his fathers asked the king to ward him with the other children."

“Why is he with the princesses then? Is he in trouble?”

“Actually, the opposite! Earlier this year, Queen Angella announced that both the princesses are old enough to choose a companion. They’re like personal guards, sworn to protect whichever princess picks them, but also to be their friend and have their back no matter what! Those three have been thick as thieves since Bow got here, so it wasn’t really a surprise when Glimmer chose him immediately.”

“Who has Adora chosen?” Catra found herself asking, eyeing up the kids around the blonde. Both Netossa and her purple haired friend were at the table, along with the three sparring kids, though the girl with the braids seemed to be the most interested in getting her attention. I bet it was her.

“Adora hasn’t chosen yet, but everyone thinks either Netossa or Lonnie will be chosen.” Catra felt eyes on her and turned her head, twitching an ear, and found the older princess watching her with keen eyes. “Hey, she’s looking right at you! You should go talk to her!”

In response, Catra curled her lip and turned away with a scowl. “No, I don’t belong in the princess party.” *They wouldn’t want me ruining their spotlight anyways.*

Before more could be said, servants began piling out of the kitchen with platters of food. The feast had begun. Adora’s eyes flicked away briefly, but the whole time, Catra was scrutinized under the winter stare of the blonde haired princess.

Chapter End Notes

Feel free to leave comments and kudos, they boost my ego!
Next chapter will be up next Sunday hopefully! Enjoy!

Chapter 2: Of Goddesses and Mortals

Chapter Summary

> CONTENT WARNING: This chapter features a graphic depiction of violence and gore. Please be warned now and proceed with caution if uncomfortable. It is around the beginning of the chapter, and takes part in the nightmare. You can skip it if it helps!

Chapter Notes

> Hope everyone had a good week and a half! I certainly did: I went up to my trailer last weekend and spent about 5 days up there enjoying nature! I actually wrote 2 chapters while I was disconnected from the internet, so I am currently writing Chapter 5 as we speak!
>
> This chapter is a bit shorter, and a bit of world building in this chapter, so bear with me!
>
> Thanks!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

As it turned out, Scorpia wasn't the only demigod who called Bright Moon home. Throughout her first week at Bright Moon, Catra was learning. She learned fairly early on that Spinnerella, the purple haired lover of Netossa, was also a demigod. She was the daughter of the west wind, Zephyr, and as such she could harness the winds. Catra made sure to stay on her good side. Whenever the princesses passed her in the halls, or she saw them at dinner, she thought she caught the godscent, but whenever she tried to explore it further, all she could smell was such a jumble of smell-noise that she could not decipher anything. It was slightly disturbing not knowing what the royals' true scents were, but she figured someone had disguised their scents so they would not be identified by Etheria's many hybrids. *Smart*, she admitted grudgingly.

She also learned that the majority of those who aged out joined the Bright Moon army as soldiers. That was also smart of the King and Queen, to raise an army from a young age and form a loyal, indebted base of footmen who were trained by the best and would defend their adopted family with their lives. Catra had already seen two cadets age out in the week, trade their plain leather and iron armour for the gilded steel plating that was the Bright Moon uniform, and join the soldiers she saw regularly patrolling the palace and yards. She couldn't imagine the scorn she would receive from Shadow Weaver should she decide to follow in their footsteps. She was only in Bright Moon to atone for her actions. Once she was sixteen and free of the smudge on her honour, she would return home to the Fright Zone and prove her loyalty to Shadow Weaver once and for all.

The day the King and Queen returned, Catra knew before anyone told her. She woke up with a jolt before the sun, all of her fur on end like she was about to be struck by lightning. She looked around quickly, trying to place the feeling, when her light-sensitive eyes registered something glowing outside. It was still nighttime, the darkest hour when the moon had set but the sun had yet to rise, so it couldn't have been natural. She blinked blearily and crawled into the large windowsill to peer out into the night.

Two strangers, a male and a female, stood outside the stables, speaking with Juliet, the head of the guard. Even though they wore plain, dirt covered travel clothing in Bright Moon colours, Catra knew they were nobility based on Juliet's demure body language—head down, back slightly bent. Most surprising was the fact that the woman was glowing, a soft silver aura surrounding her body.

She must have shifted, or made some sort of noise, or maybe the glowing woman just had superb senses, because suddenly she was staring at Catra. Her gaze was scrutinizing, as though she were picking out all of her faults. Afraid, Catra scrambled back into the bed, under her blanket, and squeezed her eyes shut tight. She prayed for sleep, and sleep mercifully came peacefully.

The dream she had was anything but peaceful.

She was back in the Fright Zone. The guard stood in front of her, screaming in the unknown tongue of the dead. She fanned her ears back, muting the spectre in front of her. It was bad luck for the living to speak to the dead, lest she damn her own soul to depart before it's time. But this guard was not happy. She pushed Catra hard in the chest. She was used to this. Her mentors growing up hit her harder, but this guard in particular loved to bully her. She knew without listening to the guard that she was getting Catra in trouble for perching along the roof again. She remembered this day clearly.

The guards and other noble born children loved to pick on Catra. She was small, weak-looking, unassuming. Her ears and eyes were too large for her body and gave her an innocent, doe-eyed look that made her an easy target. Normally she took it without any fuss. But not that day. Shadow Weaver had already lashed her, both figuratively with her words, and physically with the whip she hid in the folds of her robes. She was lazy, arrogant, self-centred. She scoffed at the rules Shadow Weaver taught her, and she suffered for it.

The guard pushed her again, forcing her back a step. Her stinging back hit the wall and she let out a hiss. The guard's garbled words

became watery laughter. She whispered one word, one word that hit Catra harder than any punch or lash. “Pathetic.”

For a moment, she heard the word as clear as the moment it was spoken. Then, there was blood in her ears and her claws slid out. Catra wasn’t sure what happened next. She remembered lashing out, the feeling of flesh and softness under her claws, chunks getting stuck under their black beds. She remembered the coppery tang of blood, and then the guard staggered back. She would have been fine if she had fallen forward.

Everyone would say that Catra killed her. They would say she was so enraged that she clawed the guard’s face so hard her eye fell out and Catra’s claws touched brain. But that was not the truth.

The guard staggered back, her hand covering her bleeding eye. She forgot there was stairs behind her. There was a rack of weapons on the landing below. The guard had been toting them back to the armoury when she had stopped to scold Catra. There had been a halberd amongst the weapons. When she’d set the rack down, the weapon fell in such a way that the blade faced upwards. The guard fell on it was a soft, squishy *thunk*.

Horror seized Catra’s gut, and she tried not to throw up. This was where reality became fantasy. The guard stood up, axe still buried in her head, and glared at Catra with her bloody eyes. The gaping, bloody hole where her left eye had once been seemed to scream, *You did this.*

Catra ran away.

She woke once more with a startled gasp, a sweaty sheen on her body. The other kids were already up and functioning. Scorpia, from the bunk below her, fixed her with a concerned look. “Are you okay there, buddy?”

“I’m fine,” she gasped out. But she was not fine. The ghost of the guard she had killed haunted her dreams now. And there was nothing she could do about it. She was going to get her silent revenge from beyond the grave.

She had almost forgotten about the strangers from the yard, after her nightmare. Even so, she heard the excited whispering of the nursemaids and servants. The memory of their return hit her shortly after, and she was not surprised when Juliet approached her where she sat with Scorpia at breakfast.

“The Queen requests your presence,” the guard said, with barely concealed distain. Scorpia startled with an undignified yelp from where she was dozing into her breakfast of hard, cooked oats in boiled water, and hurriedly saluted to the captain of the guard. The captain only had eyes for Catra. After a tense moment of Catra continuing to lazily stir her oats while staring balefully at the captain, she added, “Immediately.”

There was another heartbeat of silence, before she sighed and stood from her comfy chair. Not answering once could be excused. Twice was rebellion that would not be tolerated. She liked to toe the line between laziness and disobedience, but she would not veer even a toe off of it in either direction. Besides, if Sparkles’

mother was as impatient as the unruly violet haired girl was turning out to be, it wasn't good to keep her waiting.

"Lead on," was all she said to Juliet once she was standing. The guard scoffed and led the way out of the dining hall. Everyone's eyes were on Catra. Her ears twitched self-consciously, but she lifted her chin and rolled her shoulders back. No one would see her nervous.

She was led out of the royal dining hall—where Scorpia and she had sat at the very far end of the exceptionally long, solid wood table to avoid the others vying for the attentions of the princesses—past the throne room, into a wing of the castle Catra had never seen before. This wing had been strictly off-limits this whole week, with guards standing at attention at the entrance. She tensed and glanced around warily.

"I thought we were going to the throne room?" She asked, her voice sounding shaky and squeaky even to her own ears.

"Her Majesty requested a private audience in her small council chamber."

Catra's mind went blank with panic. Was the small council chamber similar to Shadow Weaver's Black Garnet chamber? Would she be whipped and punished for her insolence this last week? Would she be executed for her crime in the Fright Zone? She gulped and clenched her fists to stop them shaking, not noticing her claws bite into her skin. To try to calm her mind, she took in her surroundings. They were in the wing of the castle

where only the most important—and private—events occurred. It was here where the princesses trained privately and were tutored daily, here where the Spymaster's underlings could enter and leave the secret tunnels that peppered Bright Moon's halls, here where foreign rulers in disguise, army generals and other prestigious guests stayed out of sight and hidden from the rest of the castle. And here where the King and Queen did their private bidding.

Catra soon began to notice that the twists and turns of the corridors were becoming familiar. There was a cracked cobblestone on the floor that looked like a lightning bolt, in that window there a giant spider in the middle of its web, working on it's latest prey. She knew then that Juliet was taking her in double-backs and circles. It was a tactic to make sure those being led could not find their way back out unescorted. It would not work on a magicat who was raised by a woman more terrifying than any of the gods, but her foreboding grew nonetheless.

Finally, they stopped at one of the many unassuming oak doors that lined the hall. Juliet knocked once and a lightly accented voice bade them to enter.

The chamber appeared brightly lit, though the chandelier and the three braziers at each door were cold and black; no fire had graced this room all week. Instead, the light trickled in from the window on the far wall and seemed to bounce off the woman in the centre of the room, making her appear like she was glowing.

"I present Catra, former princess of the Fright Zone," Juliet intoned, bowing low. She turned back to Catra and motioned to

the impossibly tall woman in the room. “Bow to Her Royal Highness, Queen Angella of Bright Moon.”

For once, Catra did as she was told, bowing stiffly and holding it. Her whole body shook and trembled. If these were the final moments in her life, she would not make them shorter by snubbing the Queen.

She could feel Angella’s eyes studying her in the moments where her head was bowed low. The scrutiny felt like it went in forever, and Catra was struggling at keeping her tail from twitching restlessly, when Angella finally said softly, “Rise. Juliet, please guard the door.”

As Catra straightened, she saw Juliet look like she was about to protest. Then, she snapped her jaw shut, bowed to the Queen, and left the room. Once the only armed person had left, Catra let out a small sigh of relief and relaxed.

She observed the Queen as she continued to study Catra with the same rapt interest that Glimmer had on Catra’s first day. Aside from being impossibly tall, she was also impossibly beautiful. Her rosy skin had a silvery aura to it, and sparkles seemed to gleam in her hair, which was the colour of the dawn just before the sun broke the crest of the horizon. Her sharp, intelligent eyes were the colour of the richest wine, and the feline realized with a jolt that she had seen those eyes somewhere before. And it wasn’t just one the round, mischievous face of Glimmer, though the two were nearly mirror images of each other.

“I’ve heard a lot about you, Catra,” the Queen spoke first, making her way towards the window. With her back turned, she tried to inhale the Queen’s scent. Instead, she was bombarded by such a cacophony of smell-noise that crammed their way into her nostrils that she nearly sneezed. Angella’s scent was also blocked. How interesting. “We’ve never had a magicat here in Bright Moon before. It is such a rare treat that my daughters have really seemed to take a curiosity to you.”

Catra nearly snorted at the thought , but covered it with a cough. Angella glanced at her sharply and she ducked her head. The woman pressed on. “You will have to excuse the scent block on my family. I can tell you’re trying to figure out who we are, but with the nature of your banishment, I needed to make sure you could be trusted before I allowed you to our scents.”

She bowed her head lower as her ear twitched, the gesture genuine shame. “I regret my actions that day, Your Majesty,” she murmured as formerly as her wavering voice could let her. She was surprised by how much she meant it. She wasn’t really in the business of being forthcoming or honest with those she had just met. “I promise you that no harm will come to you or your family, not by my doing.”

She glanced up and found those depthless eyes on her again. She felt like a mouse being observed by a cat. It was nerve-wracking not knowing if she was to live or not. Finally, Angella looked away. “When Shadow Weaver sent word of your banishment, she advised that you be put down on sight.”

Catra blinked, barely comprehending the Queen. A wave of betrayal, followed by a stronger one of bitter disappointment

rushed over her. *Of course Shadow Weaver would want me dead*, she mused sourly. *She just wanted to do it the cheap way. Send me all the way to Bright Moon to be murdered in another kingdom and be their responsibility, not hers.* She knew how much a lavish funeral for a royal in the Fright Zone would cost, and she knew that Shadow Weaver wouldn't waste money on her lowly ward. The force of her thoughts threatened to bowl her over, but she merely staggered back a step before righting herself and staring mutely at the floor. The Queen continued.

"However, my daughter, Adora, saw something in you the day you arrived." Shock and surprise ripped through Catra's woes. The *heir to Bright Moon?* What did she do to impress her? She blinked up at Angella and found soft sympathy, an emotion she had never seen before, in her dark violet eyes. "Violence is not our way, here in Bright Moon. We will fight to defend ourselves, make no mistake, but you, Catra, are not going to die here." She leaned closer to the girl. "There is still time to do good."

She nearly collapsed in relief. She was embarrassed when her breath—one she didn't know she had been holding—left her chest in a ragged sob. Queen Angella waved her hand and suddenly the room... *changed*.

The glow around Angella intensified to the point where Catra had to screw shut her sensitive eyes. When she opened them, translucent wings spread delicately from Angella's shoulders. They were dipped ever so gracefully, the primary feathers on the edges of her wingtips brushed the floor. The sparkles in her hair twinkled like stars, and her eyes gleamed dark with primordial knowledge.

Catra's fur stood on end like she had been electrified. Even without taking in Angella's scent, she knew who she was. Still, she took a drag of the undisguised scent warily. The icy, burning smell of stars and frost nearly sent her to her knees. No other scents mingled with the divine, making the godscent that clung to Scorpia, Spinnerella and Mermista seem washed out and faded in comparison. Angella was a goddess. Not just any goddess, but one of the race of gods who ruled the balances of nature; the elder gods. Angella was Selenae, the titan goddess of the moon.

That would explain how Glimmer always seemed to appear in places where she wasn't before. Catra dropped onto one knee, her tail wrapped around herself. "Selenae," she whispered. "Blessed goddess."

"Please don't call me that," Angella, *Selenae*, said, a bit of her divine aura fading. "My daughters do not know the truth."

"But... why tell me, then?" She asked, unable to keep her silence as she should in the presence of a goddess.

"You would've found out anyway. Magicats do have the most powerful senses of all Etherians, after all." The goddess smiled gently, and the little feline felt like she was basking in a moonbeam. "It's not fair of us to mask ourselves from you forever. And from what I've heard, you are quite clever."

She beamed in pride at Angella's words and a soft chuckle left the goddess' mouth. "Run along now. And Catra? Please don't

mention this conversation to Adora or Glimmer. I will tell them when the time is right.”

She nodded. The door opened, and Juliet reappeared as Catra was bowing once more to the Queen. She was led out of the hall silently.

Chapter End Notes

> We finally get to know what Catra did to get banished! Is this what you guys thought was her crime?
>
> Hope you enjoyed! As always, please leave a comment and a kudos if you feel like it! I enjoy hearing what everyone is thinking! Next chapter will be up on Sunday, July 17th! Thanks guys!

Chapter 3: The First of the Prophecy

Chapter Summary

> Catra's nosy, Glimmer is a little shit and there's a prophet in the castle

Chapter Notes

> Hi all! Hope everyone had a good week! It's blazing hot where I am so I've been spending lots of time in my pool! How did everyone enjoy that last chapter? Did anyone see that coming?

See the end of the chapter for more notes

The days turn to weeks, then to months. Spring gave way to summer, and soon the whole of Bright Moon was in a drowsy, easy kind of life for awhile. It was common to see the nobles and royals lounging on the grounds, just enjoying their easy lives. Catra's life was set to a similar pace. She woke at the crack of dawn, trying to beat the heat and enjoy a couple of minutes alone among the snores and deep breathing of the other twenty kids surrounding her.

After breakfast, which was served usually an hour after she awoke, the blademaster took them down to the large, meandering river on the very edge of the castle grounds. There was a large floodplain of hard, white sand on one bank that served as the training area, and it was here that the blademaster taught them to use swords and spears. It was large enough to fit twenty sparring kids easily enough, and the sand served as a cushion for when they were inevitably knocked down.

At first, only Scorpia sparred with Catra, who put the minimal amount of energy into the fight. She was only used to hand to-hand combat, so she was clumsy to start with a sword and hopeless with the spear, but Scorpia was a patient teacher. She would pause in the middle of a fight and point out Catra's posture and what she was doing good and what she needed to improve. She would demonstrate the proper way to hold the weapon and allow Catra to hit her with the weapons to get a feel for what was proper.

At the start, Catra was awkward and Scorpia fought slowly, though it was clear she was holding back. She ended the sessions with more bruises than most of the others in those early days, but her excuse was that the Fright Zone soldiers used mostly hand-to-hand combat where her claws were her best asset (she still trained privately in the times when she should've been sleeping to keep those skills sharp).

Eventually, the spear became an extension of her body. Her form grew leaner and more wiry as the training went on, and Scorpia's steps grew graceful and smooth. Her clumsy humanness wore off in battles, and it became clear why she had completed most of her labours at fourteen. In time, Catra was able to keep up with her, and some days even beat her.

It was days like those that she began to be noticed. Netossa and some others began to flock to her secluded corner of the dining hall, wanting to talk with her and Scorpia about their prowess in fighting. It helped her bond more with the taller girl, as both of them felt awkward and tongue-tied as the others questioned them. Somehow, without Catra noticing it, Scorpia had wormed her way into her heart as her first true friend.

It wasn’t just the other strays who noticed, either. Everyday, Catra felt a winter-blue stare on her fur. Adora was watching her closely now, though she had no idea why. Every time she met the girl’s stare, a keen interest was soon covered by a blank mask and the blonde would go back to chatting with Glimmer and Bow.

After training, the day was theirs to do as they would. Scorpia and Catra mostly just explored the walls and into the sprawling forest north of the castle. The guards didn’t mind as long as they were back by sundown, and didn’t go into the Whispering Woods to the south. The gods had cursed the woods to be ever-changing, without any hope of navigating it. Only those led by the gods, or the immortals themselves, could travers those treacherous, restless woods.

It was not uncommon for them to spot the royal sisters on the days that they ventured out beyond the walls. The girls and the boy named Bow were always playing nearby, and more often than not, Catra noticed Adora’s eyes on them when she should have been hiding, or playing tag with the others.

One day, when Catra and her friend had passed the giant oak tree that Adora and Glimmer were trying to climb, the girl noticed another figure near them, standing on the ground near Bow. She was cloaked in a blue hood, but Catra glimpsed brown hair as the woman moved. She was talking to Adora in a gravely voice which was clearly faked.

“If you may spare some bread for me, young princess, I will tell you a prophecy.” Catra’s interests, and her ears, perked

immediately. Those who promised prophecies were high standing citizens who could afford to go to the Oracles of Mystacor to get one right from the mouth of Apollo himself. They were very rare in Etheria, and Catra had seen the consequences of those who claimed to be one of them, but who clearly was not.

It was clear that Adora and Glimmer were also interested, though Adora managed to hide her reaction a fraction better than Glimmer. Instead of screaming for glee and nearly falling out of the tree like her sister, Adora managed a grave nod and motioned for the stranger to follow them back to the castle.

"Wildcat?" Scorpia called, using the nickname she decided to use on Catra because of how often she hissed and growled at the demigod. "Are you coming?" They were following the trail a noble had advised them to check out. It was long and winded up into the hills away from the castle, making for a sticky trek in the humidity, but there was said to be a beautiful set of rapids and waterfalls which were good for swimming in at the end of the trail. Most of the older kids in the Baracks had been there at least once, but the feline still wanted to see them for herself.

She took a last glance at the royals and their guest before shrugging and turning towards the rapids. They were almost there, anyway. By the time they were done swimming and walking back, the woman would have probably been fed and watered, and they would be just in time to hear the prophecy.

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By the time they got back, most of the others had also heard of the prophet in their midst, and headed to the dining hall to meet her. With her hood down, she looked way younger than her voice implied. In fact, she looked only a couple years older than Scorpia, an adult grown but still young. Her eyes were tired and her long brown hair was braided over one shoulder. A beautiful golden diadem that marked her as a noble-born was braided into her hair. Indeed, she was just finishing up her meal as Catra and Scorpia fell in.

The doors were shut after they returned, marking that they were the last ones. Almost as soon as they were seated, the woman glanced up and turned to look at Adora.

"Young Adora of Bright Moon, the gods have given you a choice." She spoke at a low murmur, indecipherable until Catra pricked her ears and narrowed her eyes in concentration.

"What is she saying?" Scorpia asked, leaning close to Catra. The girl hissed and shooed her friend away.

"Your life is in your own hands. You will be a hero if you choose it, but it will cut your life short by several decades."

"And if I choose not to be?" Adora's voice was as quiet and smooth as the woman's. It did not waver in fear.

“You will live long, but be as insignificant as dust in the wind.” The stranger was blunt, unemotional. Both sisters flinched from the words, and some of the excited gleam in Glimmer’s eyes disappeared.

“How will I know what to choose?” Adora asked. The stranger paused, then reached down to the floor and pulled a sword out of the folds of her cloak. Everyone gasped in awe at the regal sight. The pommel was solid gold, inlaid with a sea blue gemstone. The blade itself was rare iron, polished and gleaming. The edges were deadly and sharp. Adora accepted the sword solemnly, and even though it was almost as tall as she was, she held it as though it was the lightest thing on earth. She didn’t even stagger under it’s weight, nor did her hands shake. There was a faint glow about her as she held it. She looked ready to face any army, even though she was only nine years of age. Catra had no doubt she could win many battles with that sword.

“The time will come when a great army calls for you to wield this sword,” the stranger said, her voice dipping into something almost gentle. “Listen to your heart and it will guide your feet.”

For some reason, her eyes slid across the room and landed on Catra’s. And she knew this woman knew more than she was letting on. She scowled at her in return. The woman then lifted her voice so the whole room could hear her.

“Behold, the sword of She-Ra! The one who wields it, wields the power of the goddess of war!” Just as she was saying it, the door cracked open and Angella slipped into the room, a frown forming on her face as soon as she saw the visitor.

“Thank you, honoured guest” Adora said to the stranger. She frowned thoughtfully. “What did you say your name was again?” As was the way of Xenia, the relationship between a host and a guest, the host was not allowed to question their guest until after they had fed themselves.

The guest smiled. “You may call me Mara.”

“Thank you, Mara,” Angella spoke up as she glided across the hall with all the grace of the goddess she was. Mara glanced up at Angella. Every eye in the hall followed her. The tension was thick in the air between the two women, and Catra got the feeling they knew each other. “Perhaps we may speak outside? I wish to know the guest in my halls more closely.” She shot her daughters a stern look. Adora shrank under the weight of it while Glimmer raised her chin defiantly.

“Of course,” Mara replied, standing and following Angella out of the dining hall.

Catra, being the curious and slightly nosy child that she was, lifted her ears and swivelled them behind her in the direction of Mara and Angella. As she focused on the Queen’s low, smooth voice, all other noise fell away and their conversation came into clarity.

“… Are you doing here, Mara?” She hissed. “She is *my* daughter, and you think you can just show up unannounced in my halls after

nine years, and give her a sword of great power like it is nothing? You had your chance."

"Relax, Angella," came an equally low voice, velvet smooth and slightly rumbly, not like the fake voice she had been using. "She is nine years old and you haven't even told her the prophecy yet?"

"I was waiting for the right time." *What prophecy? The one Mara just told Adora?* Catra wondered to herself. She ignored the thought and concentrated harder as the two adults continued to move away and out of ear shot.

"Well, I've learned that the right time may never come. Sometimes, you just got to do it. And don't throw accusations at me. You have no idea of the circumstances."

"Of course I don't! You left her on the mountain side with nothing but a spear to claim her as…"

They drifted out of range and Catra was jolted back into the dining room. She fanned her ears back to cut out the excess noise again and blinked a couple of times. She was starting to see there was more happening beneath the surface of Bright Moon.

That was the last time any of them saw the stranger Mara for quite some time. The prophecy whispered to Adora hadn't been heard by many and by that night, rumours were running rampant. Already, several kids had asked Catra what she had heard, since it

was no secret she had superb hearing. She had refused to say, since it wasn't her business, and she wandered the corridors alone that night to avoid the main buzz of the Barracks.

She was glad she did, as she almost ran into Angella, Glimmer and Adora on an evening stroll through the halls as well. Hearing and smelling the royal family, Catra leapt into the shadowy folds of a corner and froze in place, fanning her ears to hear better as the goddess and her daughters wandered by and out of her sight.

"Adora, must you carry that sword everywhere? It's almost as tall as you are. Why don't you let your father hold onto it until you're a little older."

"I don't want to." Catra's ears lifted in interest. She never heard Adora disagree with what her parents were saying. "It sings to me."

There was a long pause in which the magicat thought she should probably disappear, but as she made her way out from around the corner, she almost walked right into Angella. Glimmer's eyes found her and they narrowed, but Catra silently shook her head and put her finger to her lips. She wasn't supposed to be out of the Barracks this late at night. The Queen and Adora hadn't noticed Catra. They were both stuck in a battle of silent wills, staring at each other. Adora's gaze was as steely and resolved as her blade she wielded. After a moment, Angella sighed and motioned with her hand for the girls to keep walking.

“Fine. But I don’t want you training with it. You’ll dull the blade. And no sneaking off with it either! If you want to use it, you wait until your father shows you how.”

Adora and Glimmer exchanged glances and Catra knew neither was going to listen to their mother. Suddenly Glimmer stopped in place. “I think I forgot something,” she said, her voice steady. She was a deceivingly good liar for only being seven. Catra curled back into the shadows as Adora and Angella looked back at her. “I will be right back!”

Glimmer blinked out of sight in a flash of sparkles. Catra looked around for her, but hands suddenly grabbed her from behind and there was a flash of sparkles. Her stomach went sideways and her head spun, her arms and legs went numb and tingly, and then she was slamming into a hard wooden desk in a tutor room on the far side of the castle. She grabbed the desk as her stomach tried to roll its way out of her mouth.

“Why are you following us?” Came a curious voice, those hands leaving her shoulders. Catra hissed and whirled, her hackles raised and her claws unsheathed. Glimmer sat on top of the desk, her legs kicking out and her face a mask of wide-eyed innocence that the feline could see straight through.

“I just wanted to go for a walk,” Catra growled. She still didn’t like the younger princess too much. She was discovering over the months that Glimmer was clingy and nosy, always trying to figure out what the latest gossip was. “I didn’t mean to follow you, I just couldn’t risk going back the way I’d come, you all would have seen me and I’d get in trouble for not being in the Barracks.”

“Why aren’t you? Don’t you know what the guards would’ve done to you if they had found you?”

Catra glowered, but didn’t answer. Probably wasn’t much worse that what she would’ve gotten in the Fright Zone. She scratched her back, feeling the phantom sting of the whip against her shoulders. Glimmer gave her a petulant pout, and Catra knew she had to answer. She sighed through her teeth.

“I heard the prophecy the stranger gave Adora.” She motioned to her large ears. “Everyone wants to know what it was, but I don’t want to tell them.” *I shouldn’t have listened in*. “So, I decided to wander the halls until they’ve fallen asleep and then I will sneak back in and no one will know.”

Glimmer immediately looked bored. “Mama says that that wasn’t even a real prophecy. She said that the stranger was just spreading lies so she could have a bit to eat.”

“You don’t believe her?”

“Of course not! Adora’s the heir to Bright Moon. She will live till she’s like 300 and be remembered forever. We are the biggest and bestest kingdom in the world, and she’s the daughter of two sorcerers. That stranger had no idea who she was talking to.”

A sorceress. So that was what Angella told her children she was. Clever. The conversation Catra overheard between Mara and Angella suggested otherwise, but she didn't dare bring it up to Glimmer. Instead she just rolled her eyes.

"Come on," Glimmer exclaimed with a gleam in her eyes that Catra did not like. "I'll get you back to the Barracks without anyone noticing!"

Catra started to protest but the younger girl grabbed her without warning and her words turned into a shriek as that same, gut-wrenching feeling exploded through her. She landed and tumbled through the Barracks loudly, alerting everyone to her presence. Glimmer winked coyly and disappeared while twenty pairs of eyes stared at Catra in confusion.

"*Sparkles!*" She bellowed angrily. There were only guffaws of laughter that answered her. Face bright in embarrassment, the fuming magicat stalked her way to her bunk, her tail twitching uncontrollably. *I'm going to kill that princess,* she thought. *Only this time, it won't be a mistake.*

Chapter End Notes

As always, likes and comments fuel me! Adora and Catra will interact soon, I promise! It'll be worth the wait!

Chapter 4: I Just Want a Friend

Chapter Summary

Catra is scrappy, Adora is lonely. CW for a fight!

Chapter Notes

Hey all! Hope everyone's week is going good! It's my dog's birthday today! She is 2! I worked the night shift last night so there's going to be very little preamble. CW for a fight in this chapter and blood. Enjoy!

NOTE: I edited this chapter a bit to fit better with upcoming ones! Nothing major, just a bit of new details at the start!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

As summer began to wind down, and Spinnerella's father Zephyr began to bring them respite from the blazing heat, the drill sergeant's drills became tougher.

"C'mon, soldiers," he began saying. "You need to be better than this if you want to be Aristocycaon!"

"What is Aristocycaon, anyways?" Catra huffed one day as she took a break from fighting Netossa. She was sore, her hair was matted with sweat and dust, and she had a fat lip from the shaft of Netossa's spear.

"It means 'best of the Etherians'," Netossa replied in a wheeze. She was likewise drenched in sweat, her pale grey jerkin was hanging off one shoulder, and she was leaning heavily on her

spear after Catra delivered a hearty blow to her ribs. “Every year, King Micah allows his wards to compete in the events at the annual Games. The event with the highest honours is the pankration fight. They’re separated by lots and in the end, the winners of the lots face off against one another. The winner of all of the battles is crowned Aristocycaon and rewarded greatly. One year, a kid actually got to go home.”

Suddenly, Catra was interested. A chance to go home without having to wait seven long years? If only!

After that day, she began training harder. Scorpia was called away on hero’s work in some small kingdom far in the west called Eternia, so Catra had to spar with others. Most were no match for her, and she won fights with them easily, but there were some who proved to be a challenge.

Rogelio, the reptilian hybrid, was quick for his enormous size and a swat on the head from his sword or spear was enough to knock someone out. Even Catra saw stars if she was too slow. She used her smaller size to her advantage, darting around to the small of the back to deliver powerful blows to the place where his armour and scales were weakest. It worked every time.

Netossa was another formidable adversary, especially with her enchanted net that Entrapta, goddess of the forge, gifted her. It had the ability to change shapes and sizes to catch any opponent, and it *always* landed perfectly, unable to open except for the release word which only Netossa knew. Even without the net, the girl was strong and fast, with armour of polished silver. It wasn’t as thick or durable as iron or bronze plating, but it reflected the sunlight back to the attacker, momentarily blinding them. It was a

dirty trick that always left Catra's highly sensitive eyes smarting for days afterwards, but sometimes she was able to catch onto Netossa's attempt to angle the sun behind her, and was able to avoid the full blinding effect.

But her worst opponent was the girl with braids in her hair known as Lonnie. Through the rumours the other kids spread, Catra learned that she was from a small town on the edge of the Crimson Waste, where the citizens believed they could rule for themselves without the need of a king. Their king did not agree and a war broke out. The rebels lost and their leader and families were slain for their tyranny. Only the leader's daughter was shown mercy, and she was sent to Bright Moon to repent for her family's crimes. She was not a demigod, but she was born and bred to fight, and did so as though she had nothing left to lose. It made her reckless and dangerous, and their fights were hard and ugly. When she swung her sword, it was as though all the Furies and wraiths of Hades were behind the swing, and trying to land a blow on her was like trying to harness the wind. Catra would have appreciated her had she not been so smug and haughty, boasting about her skills to any who would listen.

"You might as well not fight," Lonnie sneered to Catra one day at lunch. It was a week before the event that King Micah had planned. She had just thoroughly beaten the pants off Catra, who was now trying to nurse her wounded pride in private. But it seems luck was not on her side. Lonnie was not alone, and had a group of admirers following her who all stared hungrily at her. Some wanted to be her, others wanted to be liked by her. Catra wanted to be left alone by her. Unfortunately, she went on. "After all, you're looking at the next Aristocycaon! Even King Micah thinks so."

Catra held her tongue. Lonnie had been trying to goad her into more fights all week. She wasn't going to give her one right now. Early on, she had learned that fighting among themselves outside of training was prohibited. It was so that kids from warring kingdoms wouldn't start a war in Bright Moon, but it was the only thing stopping her from smearing Lonnie's face onto the cobblestones right there and then.

Undeterred by her silence, the girl pressed on. "I thought you would be a challenge, based on all the rumours about you, but you're as meek as a mouse. No wonder your mother didn't want you."

Catra stood up to leave Lonnie bragging to her admirers. She wasn't going to fight her. Not until—

"Pathetic." It was whispered in her ear as she shoulder her way passed.

She. Saw. Red. The clay plate in her hands shattered into pieces as it dropped. She whirled, bristling. Her claws came out, but at the last minute, she curled her hand into a fist, biting into the flesh of her palm as she did so. Her punch connected with Lonnie's face. She'd caught the girl off guard, she wasn't actually expecting a reaction. Catra's senses came back to her as Lonnie's head flew back.

The whole dining hall went silent and still as everyone waited to see what Lonnie would do. She righted herself and spat blood

from her split lip onto the floor. The look in her pale green eyes was murderous as she spat, “You’re dead!” And leapt onto Catra.

The two rolled on the ground, both vainly trying to scrabble their way on top of the other. Lonnie booted Catra’s torso which caused the feline to curl in on herself and gave the bigger girl the advantage she needed. She straddled Catra’s chest and began laying punch after punch into her face, her nose, her eyes, her large, pointed ears were the targets. She blocked as many as she could, but Lonnie was relentless, raging and full of pent up frustration. After a couple moments, all Catra could see was the fist smashing into her face, all she could hear was the angry roar of her ears being assaulted, all she could smell was her own blood in her mouth and nostrils.

The hall was absolute chaos now. Other fights had broken out around them between those trying to get to the brawling girls and split them up, and those who wanted to see how the fight would end. In the midst of the melee, no one noticed Adora stand from her spot near the head of the table and slip out into the hallway beyond.

Catra was dizzy with the smell and taste of her own blood. Soon she would be at the mercy of her instincts. Her control was already slipping. One moment, it was Lonnie above her, the next it was the guard she had killed, then the tutors who used to beat her in her teachings, and finally, Shadow Weaver herself. Every figure whispered the same thing. “Pathetic. Pathetic. Pathetic.”

The red haze came over her once more, and she felt her claws slide out. She dug them into the soft, unprotected skin of the assailant’s side, and lifted her leg to boot them in the groin.

"I am not pathetic!" She roared. She twisted out from under them, then turned and pounced on top of them. *Oh, how the tables have turned.* With one hand, she pinned their flickering, changing hands above their head. With the other, she slashed their face with her claws. The figure let out a scream of agony. One moment, it was Shadow Weaver, grey talons curled in agony, her red mask shattered beside her, the next it was Lonnie. She blinked, and the figure solidified. Lonnie, screeching on the floor and covering her face with her hands while blood seeped from between her fingers.

Horror seized Catra at the same time massive, rough hands grabbed her by her tunic and the fold of skin between her shoulders that she hadn't grown into yet. She was hauled off of Lonnie and left dangling in the air limply, the sensitive nerve in her scruff engaging and forcing her still and silent while her emotions roiled within her. A man's face, one she'd never seen before, appeared in her vision, which was shadowy from swelling. Dark, long hair, wine dark eyes, a bare chested torso with swirling tattoos. A kind face, framed by a full, thick beard, usually with crinkles of kindness littered over but obscured from familiarity by the sharp, cruel edges of outrage. King Micah.

"What is going on here?" He booked like a thunderclap. She flinched and became aware of others around the edges of her vision flinching too. *Good. So he* is *roaring, my ears aren't that broken.* She stared at the king, unable to respond. But he wasn't finished yet. "You expect to come to *my* home acting like rabid dogs and think I will just turn a blind eye?"

Catra's stomach knotted in dread. She licked her iron-tasting lips and flattened her ears in apology. She was physically unable to speak when held this way—the nerve in her scruff set off a primal instinct for pure silence and complacency. It shut off many receptors for emotions, pain, and response systems, as young magicats used to be transported by their families like this in situations that required absolute silence. Shadow Weaver knew of this, and used this response as an opportunity to insult Catra without her being able to talk back.

From the ground, Lonnie moaned and answered verbally, "We were just practicing for the event." She removed her hands from her face, and Catra relaxed some. She hadn't scratched Lonnie's eye. There were three, moderately deep scratches and one deeper one along the side of her face from hairline to jaw. It just bled lots because it was a head injury. It would heal into a wicked scar, but it hadn't done damage to anything vital.

"The event?" Micah echoed incredulously. "After the way you two just fought, I don't even know if I want you to compete!"

He seemed to clue in in that moment that he still had a child dangling from his grasp. There was a flash of guilt in his eyes, and he set Catra down, taking his hand off the nerve. The moment the pressure was released, all her emotions came rushing back. Tears welled in her eyes and she tried to blink them away. It didn't work. She looked away from the king and found Adora standing beside him, a pitying look on her face.

The blonde took a step forward and that was enough to spur Catra into motion. She wrenched herself the rest of the way out of

the king’s grasp, and fled out of the dining hall. It the only sound in the stunned silence.

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Adora found her in a storeroom near Mommy’s wine cellars. She had no real reason to believe Catra would be there, but she had a feeling she would be, seeing as Adora had found her there before. Catra didn’t even know she had been followed that night. It was the night Scorpia had left for Eternia, and Adora knew how to be sneaky, so she followed the magicat after seeing her leave the dining hall in a hurry. It was this same storeroom where Adora had found Catra sitting on top of a barrel, bent double in shoulder-wracking sobs. That night, she had left the girl in her misery, but this night she couldn’t.

She had seen something cross Catra’s face. Some sheer, gut-ripping terror had possessed her and turned her into a creature more feline than human, who lashed out in her fear. Adora knew no one else saw it, but she wasn’t going to let Catra fall into despair on that night.

“Catra?” She called softly. There had been ragged breathing when she had entered the room, but now there was nothing, as if the whole space was holding it’s breath. It was this absence of ambient noise that cemented the certainty in Adora’s mind that the other girl was in there. “I know you’re in here. Come on out! I know you didn’t mean to hurt Lonnie.”

It had been a couple hours since the fight at lunch. Adora didn't mind Lonnie, she was a decent fighter and she knew her back would be protected with Lonnie behind her, but the closer it got to her father's event, the more and more the girl began to boast. Lots of servants and wards were, but Lonnie had the skill to back up her swagger, and that made her bold and cocky. Which was one of the reasons why Adora didn't want to choose her as her companion, no matter how much Daddy was pressing the matter. She was, after all, his favourite.

"I've already chosen, Daddy," she'd finally told him the night before. "I just haven't checked with them first. I want to do that before I announce it."

"You can hold your breath for a good long time, I will give you that," she continued to call to Catra. "But my mommy is a sorceress, so I am pretty sure I would beat you in a contest."

She didn't know why she said that. She had a bad habit of just blurting what she was thinking. Mommy said it was a gift from her father, although Adora had never seen Micah as anything but calm and thoughtful. So much unlike Glimmer. The comment seemed to work. There was a resigned sigh, a shuffle, and the girl stood up from behind the same barrels she had been crying on when Scorpia had left. She was barely tall enough to peer out, so only the tufts of her black, battered ears and half of her dilated, mesmerizing gold and-blue eyes poked out around the cloud of wild hair.

"Why are you here?" She asked, adding as an afterthought, "Your Highness."

“Oh gods, please just call me Adora.” She cringed at the use of her title. It was so suffocating. “And I come bearing gifts.”

She heaved the small basket that she’d dragged from her rooms into view. She saw the other girl focus on the steaming plate of chicken thighs drizzled in honeyed spices, completely ignoring the healing supplies also in the basket.

“Why?” She rasped. Her voice was a strange mix of squeaky and growly, and Adora wanted to hear more of it. “Don’t you know what I’ve done?”

“I do, and I don’t care. You skipped dinner and you’re hurt.” She placed the pharmica herbs, salves and tonics in front of her in a neat row, then placed the plate of meat if front of those. “And it’s chicken night. You *never* miss chicken night.”

Chicken was Catra’s favourite food that Adora had noticed, so she hoped to coax her out from behind the barrels. She turned around, digging out the tightly crumpled blanket from the bottom of the basket, rambling on.

“Although I don’t understand why you eat everything except the breast. Daddy says the breast is the best cut on the chicken. And you don’t even eat the field greens, cheese, or fruits that go with —” she heard a small noise, like Catra was readjusting, but when she turned back to her, her bruised face was inches from Adora’s.

Her eyes were huge and hungry, and she was practically drooling. "—it. Hello!"

"It's dark meat," Catra said, snatching the plate and moving a couple feet away. "The good bits."

She crouched on the balls of her feet, her tail wrapped possessively around the clay plate, and her wary eyes never leaving Adora, almost as though she thought she would take the food away. Adora didn't move. After a couple of moments, Adora needed to break the silence.

"What makes it the good bits?"

"It's where the juices and flavour are! And it's slimy goodness that falls right off the bone." She demonstrated, pulling at the chicken in her hand that indeed fell off the bone, grease and juices dripping between Catra's fingers.

"Now you're making me hungry again," The blonde laughed. She nearly jumped as one of the chicken thighs landed at her feet on the blanket. "What's this?"

"Food. You eat it, princess."

Adora rolled her eyes at Catra's sassy reply, and nudged it back to the girl. "But I got it for you."

Catra froze in her hurried eating and slowly took the food back. “I didn’t mean to displease you, Your—Adora.”

“What? No! I’m not displeased!” She hurried to say. “It’s just that… you’re hurt and I wanted to make you feel better! And I didn’t want you to be hungry—”

“Adora!” Catra clamped a hand over the rambling girl’s mouth to silence her word-vomit. Then she hastily removed it. “You’ve given me enough chicken to feed an entire army! I’m sure if you eat one piece, I won’t starve.”

There was an odd, rumbling noise in the other girl’s throat. Adora frowned. She’d never been good at making friends before, and never had to pursue someone to be friends. She had plenty of friends sure, her sister, Bow—who made friends as easily as smiling—the other noble-born children who just liked Adora for her prestigious title, and the wards who only wanted to be her sworn companion. But Catra showed such little interest in Adora that she *had* to be friends with her. So she watched her, and waited to gather her nerves until she was brave enough to approach her.

She had gone to Bow a couple of days before Scorpia had left. “How do I make friends?” She asked him.

He had smiled kindly up at her. “Be yourself.” He also mentioned that sometimes, people liked to be gifted things. So, she planned

and when the right time came, she took it. She had wanted to approach her the night Scorpia left, but afterwards the girl had made herself scarce. She was not popular amongst the other wards and she knew it, so she made herself small and disappeared.

The rumbling got louder at Adora's frown, and her eyes narrowed in suspicion. "Are you… mocking me?"

"I'm teasing you, dork!" She flicked Adora's frown with a giggle, but then her face twisted in pain from the nasty cut on her lip that was stretching as she smiled. Adora's frown smoothened into one of concern.

"Are you alright?"

"Don't be so serious." She used a hand to brush her own freckled cheek, where a bruise was blooming. Adora hurriedly opened the tin of salve she had.

"Here! Mommy uses it on me and Glimmer all the time when we get hurt. It'll be better by tomorrow!" The young blonde dipped her fingers into the ointment and brought them up to Catra's face, but the girl with the wild cedar hair pushed her away with a hiss.

"Why are you doing this?" Her pupils contracted with her own guarded suspicion.

“Because I can. And I want to.”

That shut Catra up. She took another morsel of food and chewed it slowly, while nodding at Adora to proceed. The princess’s heart warmed and she very gently applied the salve to all the cuts and bruises along her velvet soft ears and face. When she came to the nasty split along her lip, Adora wiped her hands on the blanket and grabbed another tin, this one full of bear grease, bound into an ointment with beeswax, lavender and honey. She ran her finger ever so gently along Catra’s wound, but to her surprise, once the wound was coated, her fingers paused on the wild girl’s soft lips. Even Catra seemed surprised. Her eyes had drifted shut during Adora’s soft tending of her wounds, but now they were wide open and staring very intently at the princess. There was a focused kind of attention, almost predatory, in her mismatched gaze. They were impossibly bright, and so close that Adora could see the yellow of Catra’s right eye was actually a mix of pale hazel, green and amber flecks.

The princess’s heart caught in her throat and she made a rasping sound before she pulled back, wringing her hands. She wasn’t sure how she felt, or if she even liked that feeling, but now she wanted to be Catra’s friend more than ever.

“I should go,” she said lamely, scrambling back and collecting her tins. “My mom will be looking for these.”

Catra nodded mutely. Her eyes looked dull now that Adora was away from her. She wanted to hear Catra talk again, so she said something impulsive.

“Train with me tomorrow? Meet me in the courtyard right after breakfast.” Her heart was racing. Bow had said to take risks when trying to make new friends. She hoped he was right. But then again, he didn’t say anything about potential friends teasing her, or having the softest lips ever. What if he was wrong?

Before she could over think her question (much) or start to ramble, Catra’s rugged face broke into a savage grin. “I’ll be there.”

Chapter End Notes

> There won’t be an update next week as I will be out of internet service and this is the last completed chapter I have written (at this moment. It will probably change soon) so enjoy this one! Next update will be August 8th, 2021, unless I finish the next chapter before I leave on Friday! Likes and comments make my day! Feel free to ask any questions!

Chapter 5: Strength of a Raging Fire

Chapter Summary

> Scorpia name drops some Greek heroes. Catra preforms parkour. Adora is a bean and we love her!

Chapter Notes

> Hi guys! Hope you all had a good two weeks! As promised, here is another chapter! I've changed a couple details in the last chapter because ya girl did some research about the olympics in honour of the summer events that just finished today, and now Micah runs the Ancient Greek Olympics haha!
>
> I am just starting my actual vacation now, so again, no update next week, but the next chapter will be up on August 22nd, 2021. I am currently a chapter ahead of posting, however if things change and another chapter is written before I leave on the 12th, I will post the next one to tide you's over until the 22nd.
>
> No real violence this chapter, just some training! Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

That night, Catra found herself desperately wishing Scorpia was there, so she could relay to her the events of the day and the conversation with the heir of Bright Moon. Would her friend have any advice?

She found herself thinking of the day that Scorpia had left. It had been a regular day until the evening, when Catra had returned from a walk alone along the river to find Scorpia's bunk bare and all of her belongings gone. She stared at it blankly until she heard Netossa.

“Didn’t you know she was leaving?” Her voice was soft in sympathy. Catra turned and found her curled up around a dozing Spinnerella on her bunk. She shook her head slowly. Netossa’s eyes were even softer than her words. “She left a couple of minutes ago, she’s going on some hero mission—”

Catra didn’t hear anything more. She ran after her friend as fast as she could. She had ease in following Scorpia’s scent, having spent months breathing it in in all kinds of conditions. She followed it out of the castle, past the guard quarters to the wall, where she took a short cut. She took the guard’s path up to the top of the wall instead of winding through the merchants and beggars in the courtyard in front of the palace. She knew Scorpia wouldn’t be able to just walk through and ignore everyone, she would stop and chat everywhere. That gave the young magicat time to reach the room on top of the gate, shuffle out the window and drop down just as Scorpia was walking under.

The drop caused her ankles to creak in protest and rattled her teeth, but Catra clenched them hard as she glared at her friend. To her credit, Scorpia looked incredibly surprised to see a nine year old drop twenty feet off the gate and still land on her feet without shattering her legs or crying out in pain, but Catra was too mad to feel proud about surprising her friend.

“You’re *leaving*?” She hissed, betrayal searing like a branding iron on her heart. “And you didn’t *tell* me?”

Scorpia’s gaze went soft as she took the pack off her back and lay it on the ground beside her. She smiled and Catra could see the

small trickle of guilt in her eye. “I figured you would catch up,” she said, kneeling in front of Catra so the two were on the same level and putting a hand on her shoulder. “I have to go, Wildcat. There’s a kingdom that needs my help. But don’t worry! It won’t take me too long and I will be back before you know it.”

Catra snarled and swiped Scorpia’s hand off of her, angry tears stinging her eyes. “So send an army in your place, you’re a *child*! Why do you have to leave? What is the issue that adults can’t handle?”

Scorpia shrugged helplessly. “I honestly don’t know. They’ve tried everything but now they need the help of the gods and, well, I am the best option since Heracles went to the Underworld. Besides.” She stood up and smiled confidently at Catra. “I’m fourteen now, I’m practically an adult! Other girls my age are getting married and starting families. Even Theseus fought the Minotaur when he was my age! And I have already been through most of my labours. I’m sure whatever this situation is, I will be fine.” Her smile turned encouraging and she gently ran her hand over Catra’s ear. She was the only person to ever touch her with that kind of affection, and normally, Catra would growl or hiss and swipe at her. But that day, she let her, even leaning into the touch to try to hide the tears in her eyes. “I’ll be back in a few weeks. You won’t even have time to miss me!”

That had been nearly two months ago, and there had been no word on whether or not Scorpia even made it. And Catra definitely missed her friend.

She tossed and turned all night, painfully aware of Scorpia’s empty bunk beneath her, and drowning in her thoughts that

drifted like tides between her friend and the heir of Bright Moon. Adora was an anomaly to her. One moment she was frowning seriously, an untouchable god in human form, the next she was *rambling*, a dorky nine year old wanting desperately for someone to like her. *And what was that thing she did to Catra's lips?*

Why did she want Catra to like her so much? She had her choice of people who would follow anywhere, why was Catra so special? She was no one, an exiled former princess who already had one kill under her belt, and no title for prestige. Hell, she barely had a likeable personality! And that stunt she pulled with Lonnie hadn't gained her any popularity.

And yet, she found herself the next day heading to the courtyard instead of following the other wards down to the river. As she arrived, Adora was in the middle of saying something to Bow and Glimmer.

"… May have invited someone to join us today."

Glimmer said, "Who?" At the same time that Bow looked behind Adora and saw Catra trying to blend into the shadow of the doorway, and said, "Hey Catra! Your face is looking a lot better today!"

Both princesses turned to look at her, one with surprise, the other with pleasure. Catra blushed, her ear twitching as she ran her hand over her face.

"Erm, thanks," she mumbled. Indeed, Angella's salve *had* healed her face. Her bruises were green or yellow, or gone completely, and her cuts had mostly closed, scabbed over and disappeared. Only the cut on her lip still hurt and bled a bit, but it was way more bearable than it had been the night before. *It'll probably leave a scar.* "What are we doing today?"

"Really, Adora?" Glimmer griped, crossing her arms and pouting. "This was supposed to be *our* thing. And now you've invited *Catra* of all people? She almost clawed out Lonnie's eye yesterday! And she's not a part of the Best Friends Squad!"

Before Catra could shoot back with the clever quip that was on the tip of her tongue, Adora spoke.

"I'm glad you could make it," she said to Catra, her eyes soft and limpid. Turning to her sister, she added, "Daddy has been trying to get me to find a friend for awhile now, and last night I made one! And you're right, Catra did almost claw Lonnie's eye. But she didn't. Dad would say that means she has really good control. Besides, I think this will be fun!"

Glimmer had the decency to look cowed, but she still whispered, "But Adora, Mama said not to let anyone we don't trust with our lives see us train." She fixed Catra with a wary glance and Catra sneered back at her, hearing the distrust plainly.

"Well she's not just *anyone*, she's Catra. And she's my friend!" She took a few steps behind her and looped her arm through Catra's, much to the shock of the shorter girl. "I don't think she's going to

hurt us. When did you start listening to Mommy anyways? You're always teleporting, it's not like it's a secret."

Catra was floored, and a touch confused. That was twice now that Adora stood up for her before she could come to her own defence. She had called her a friend. Had Lonnie hit her head hard enough for her to pass out and this was all a dream? The warm arm looped around hers squeezed lightly, and she accidentally jostled the cut on her lip, causing a flare of pain to go through her face. *Nope. Not a dream*.

"Are you alright, Catra?" Bow asked, startling her out of Adora's warmth. He was standing beside her while the royal siblings continued their quiet squabble. "You look a little dazed."

Glimmer's companion was different than Catra had pictured him. She's thought that beneath his white half tunic he would be plush and cushy, used to a luxurious palace lifestyle and not needing to lift a finger, but now upon closer inspection, she saw she was wrong. His exposed midriff showed a stomach taut and ribboned with the beginnings of muscle. His awkwardly large hands and bare feet were calloused and small cuts and marks riddled his legs and arms, which were long, knobbly and broad-framed, promising height when he grew into manhood.

She remembered Scorpia saying he was a refugee from Thaymor, a country that was always caught in different wars, which meant his family was most likely starving before they made the trek to Bright Moon. She's also heard a rumour that he was the youngest of thirteen brothers, which would have made food even harder to come by for his family. Despite all of the struggles he must've faced, his eyes were still kind and soft. Bow had seen probably

the worst of Etheria, and he still came out of it with his humanity and morality intact.

"I'm honestly just wondering how I got here," she replied, surprising herself with her candour. "Six months ago, I thought my life was over. And now the crowned princess of Bright Moon is calling me her friend."

Bow hummed sympathetically. "I get it. But life has a funny way of leading us exactly where we are meant to be. Everything happens for a reason."

Catra snorted bitterly. "Yeah, tell that to the family of the guard I —" It took a conscious effort to stop the words from leaving her mouth. She snapped her jaws shut and glared at Bow. "Let's just say this is weird."

Before either of them could say anything else, Adora and Glimmer seemed to have come to the end of their argument. Based on Glimmer's especially sulky expression, it was clear that Adora had won.

"Come on, guys!" The blonde announced with a sparkle in her eyes. "Let's go!"

They left the courtyard and made their way back into the private wing of the castle. Unlike Juliet, Adora led the way in a straight, confident line. They followed the outside wall of the palace, joking

and jostling each other the whole time, until they reached a door that led outside. It opened up into a clearing behind the walls of the palace. The clearing was covered in soft grasses mostly, with a small stream bordering it in on the far side. On the other side of the stream was the ever-changing Whispering Woods.

Catra stared out at the woods in awe. So many legends were told about the place she was staring at. Somewhere out there was Mount Dryl where it was said Light Hope, the immortal trainer of heroes, lived in her Crystal Tower. The same woods that Scorpia had disappeared into two months ago to make her way to Salineas instead of following the shore around. Catra turned her back with a flinch. *Scorpia is fine,* she told herself. *She will be back soon.*

On the other side of the clearing was a small outbuilding that Glimmer and Bow were rummaging through. At first, she thought it was a little gardening shed that the servants had forgot about, but then the two emerged with weapons and she realized it was an armoury. Glimmer had a staff of ash wood with a bronze tip, and Bow held onto an ornate, golden tipped bow with a goatskin grip.

"Is this going to get me kicked out?" She asked out loud. Not that she cared, really, but she was on sort of thin ice after her stunt yesterday. And she liked having a place where she could eat and rest in relative safety.

Glimmer rolled her eyes but Adora shook her head. "Our father made sure no one disturbs us while we are training. He doesn't want any of the adults to see what we can do. He says it'll put us in danger."

At first, Catra had no idea why they'd be in danger. Sure it was considered by a lot of the kingdoms of Etheria to be unorthodox to let females train for battle, but in Bright Moon, it was largely accepted. Besides, everyone in Etheria knew King Micah had no sons, so he was raising his daughters in a princely fashion. Even Catra knew that before she arrived. Shadow Weaver was constantly scorning the King of Bright Moon for his parenting techniques despite raising Catra in a similar fashion.

Then, Glimmer blinked out of sight and reappeared a heartbeat later on the other side of the clearing. And Catra remembered who their mother was.

"Well there's not many teleporting kids around," Catra quipped with a smirk. "But what is it you can do?"

Adora grinned fiendishly and brought the sword of She-Ra out from under a nearby log. Catra laughed in glee. "I knew you couldn't stay away from it."

Adora frowned before Glimmer explained that Catra had listened to their conversation with Angella the night that the sword had arrived to Adora. The blonde shrugged, running her hand over the blade. "Well, what the adults don't know won't kill them." Adora quipped back. "Besides, it's not like anyone can hurt me."

"What do you mean?"

“Watch this!” Adora hefted the giant sword effortlessly. Once again, that glow surrounded her like it had the night she was gifted it. She nodded to Bow with a smile on her face and readied the sword. Bow raised his bow and Catra frowned as she realized the arrows weren’t the blunted arrows normally used in training. If Adora got hit by an arrow, she would be wounded. She gulped, suddenly uneasy.

Before she could say anything, Glimmer disappeared with a sparkling sheen like stars on a moonless night, and Adora’s eyes followed her. Bow shot the arrow. Catra let out a yowl of surprise, but she did not need to worry.

It was said that a demigod showed their godly heritage differently. With Spinnerella, it was her ability to control the winds, like her father. Scorpia’s was her incredible strength and resilience, Glimmer’s was her ability to travel unseen through the air like her mother. And Adora’s lineage was clear through her speed.

Quicker than humanly possible, Adora whirled and brought the sword up as though it weighted no more than a feather. She brought it down in a savagely beautiful arc, slicing the arrow Bow shot at her in half. In the same motion, she turned on falcon-fast feet to where a pink shimmer was appearing, and by the time Glimmer had fully formed, Adora had dodged another arrow effortlessly, and slammed her sister away with the force of a thunderclap. Glimmer went sailing through the air like a straw doll and splashed into the stream.

Over and over Adora danced with the two of them. Catra was frozen in wonder as she watched. They went until Bow's quiver was arrowless, and Glimmer was letting out small huffs of pain every time she disappeared and reappeared. Finally, Bow dropped the bow, Adora the sword, and Glimmer fell on the ground like a sack of bricks.

Catra was speechless. She had never seen anyone, child or adult, move with as much liquid grace as Adora. And that sword! Holding onto it without moving, Adora looked small and awkward next to it, a gangly child playing at being a warrior, but while in motion, it was just another part of her, a raging beast with a thirst for blood. She met the blonde's eyes.

Bow and Glimmer were panting raggedly, sweat dulling their eyes and dampening their brows, but Adora still had the fire of battle in her winter gaze. Catra stepped forward, her chin jutting out boldly and her tail lashing.

"Fight me," she challenged. Adora snorted and Bow tried to protest, but Catra went to the weapon shed and pulled out two staffs. She tossed one to Adora, and was almost surprised as the girl fumbled with it and dropped it before picking it up quickly. *Maybe it's just the sword giving her a blessing from She-Ra. Maybe she isn't invincible without it.*

"You don't know what you are doing," Glimmer muttered, probably too low for a regular human to hear.

I am going to regret this. "Sure I do," Catra lied. She spun her staff around experimentally. *Lighter than a spear, but it should do.* "Adora's gonna fight me."

"Adora, you really don't have to! Remember what your parents said!" Bow cautioned. Adora just laughed as she spun her staff.

"Let her try!"

And that was all the protest from Glimmer and Bow. Adora and Catra circled one another, eyes locked. Both were grinning at the other, daring the other to take the first blow. In the end, it was Catra, taking a swipe with her staff. Adora ducked easily. She readjusted her hold and swung again, feigning one way and then actually striking the other way. It worked. She got a glancing blow off Adora's arm, but it was a hit!

It was her only hit. It gave her confidence, boldness to step into Adora's striking zone, and that was all she needed. In two blows Catra couldn't see, the staff was out of Catra's hands. She managed to duck and dodge a couple of Adora's blows, but she was so fast! In no time at all, Adora had hooked the staff behind Catra's legs and had her laid out flat on the ground, staff at Catra's neck.

"I told you!" Glimmer shouted. Enraged at the comment, Catra swiped the stick away from her neck and tossed dirt at Adora's face. She kicked the staff hard enough for it to leave her hands, and then she pounced on the blonde.

Adora twisted and turned, but Catra was part feline, and had the balance of one. Her demise came unexpectedly, as the ground suddenly tilted beneath her and she was being pinned down. Adora had done some sort of flip and managed to land on Catra, winding her a bit. She stared up at the blonde's amused gaze, her heart beating frantically.

Adora giggled and held out a hand. "That was really good for a first attempt! I can see why you're in the running for Aristocycaon!"

"Gods above, Adora," Catra panted out, accepting the proffered hand. "If you entered the competition, there would be none, you *are* Aristocycaon!"

"Daddy won't let us compete in pankration, or any of the fighting games. He doesn't want our talents known." She sighed wistfully as she hauled Catra to her feet so quickly that the two of them collided roughly. Adora kept them standing by wrapping Catra in a hug, accidentally trapping Catra's face against her shoulder. Catra took a deep breath, realizing that the scent block was gone. She released her quickly as a bell tolled in the distance. "Come on! We should go wash up for dinner."

With that, Glimmer, Bow and Adora walked back into the castle. Catra hung back, trying to process what she had smelled.

Adora was not like Glimmer. Glimmer’s scent reeked of the starlight side of the godscent, along with the smoky, electric tang of magic, but Adora’s scent was completely wrong for a child of the moon goddess and a sorcerer. The godscent on her was strong, more powerful than her sister’s, and it was more of the icy, dark side, mingled with the irony after-tones of blood. There was no trace of magic in her blood. She should have placed it sooner. A blonde haired, pale skinned girl with blue eyes among a family with wine-dark eyes, hair in the shades of night before the dawn, and olive-toned skin. Adora was not a child of Micah and Angella.

Chapter End Notes

> Kudos and comments fill my heart with joy! Let me know how you’re liking it!

Chapter 6: Olympic Level Fight Club

Chapter Summary

> Things get spicy. CW for fighting, mention of death, mention of sacrifice, blood and violence!

Chapter Notes

> Hello everyone! I am back to regular weekly updates for the time being! Hope everyone's still here with the couple of hiatus's I had. I've got two smaller chapters complete after this one so I'll be updating weekly once again! This chapter was written during the Olympics and I really wanted to get it out while they were still on but unfortunately I didn't get there in time. It was really fun to write so I hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra listened to the roar of the crowd from underneath the stadium. Her eyes were wide in fear, and her hands shook as they were bound.

"Easy, Catra," Netossa murmured as she wrapped linen strips around her claws. Her hands paused her work and she moved one up and drew it down her arm soothingly. "Remember what you have been taught, and everything will be okay."

The last week had been spent training on different sectors of the Games—discus and javelin throwing, foot races, horse races, and pankration. Catra's favourite. It was a mix of boxing and wrestling where most things were allowed.

The reason for her nerves was in a similar waiting area for competitors on the other side of the stadium. Lonnie. They had drawn lots to see who would fight who, and unfortunately, Catra had been pitted against Lonnie. They had avoided each other in training since the escapade in the dining hall, but Lonnie had been unstoppable in her practice fights. She had even broken a kid's leg only yesterday. And given their recent animosity, would Lonnie stop if Catra submitted?

Death was very rare in pankration, but it was not unheard of. A guard told her a story of a man who had been placed in a chokehold, and in his desperation to get out of it, he broke his opponent's toe. The opponent submitted in pain, but when they raised the man's hand in victory, he was dead. She hoped the same didn't happen to her.

Netossa snorted and tightened the bindings on Catra's hands. Normally, their hands were left free of any padding or coverings, but Catra was an exception to the tradition. Micah had decreed that an additional rule—to go along with the rules of no biting or gouging—was that no hybrid may use their claws. This was definitely an addition after the fight between Lonnie and Catra. Lonnie's face had healed face due to Angella's healing salves, but indeed a jagged scar ran down the side of her face, making her look all the more fierce.

"I still don't understand why you didn't enter the children's league," Netossa muttered. She disapproved immensely of a nine year old fighting those who were fourteen and older.

"Lonnie didn't, so why should I?" Catra protested. "Besides, I'd smoke any kid I was up against. The Fright Zone made sure I was

up to standards with those who are older than me."

"You're lucky you're fighting Lonnie. Anyone else would wipe the floor with your face." Catra hissed as Netossa pulled taut the linen.

"Remember, this isn't like training," she continued. "The fight doesn't stop once your back hits the ground. You'll need to make her submit, or you will have to submit, for the battle to be over. Do you understand?"

The girl nodded and tried to make her hands stop their shaking. She trained in the Fright Zone. She couldn't show weakness, couldn't back down. She knew the way this battle would end. Either Lonnie would submit or Catra would die. There was no way she could submit and still live with herself; Shadow Weaver had told her retreat was the worst kind of shame for any warrior. Netossa shook her shoulders gently.

"Focus, Little-fang," she murmured, using her own nickname for Catra. "Do you remember the signal for submission?"

Catra nodded and demonstrated, pointing her index finger straight at the sky like she was summoning Zeus and all his power. The older girl's eyes softened. "You'll be just fine. Try to leave her in one piece though, yeah?"

“No promises.” Normally this would’ve been followed by a sly smirk, but Catra didn’t have it in her. She was too nervous, too hyped up on adrenaline and fear to do anything but focus on the task at hand. Netossa fastened a heavy cloak onto Catra’s bare shoulders.

“This is just for show, remember. It’ll be removed before the fighting begins. And remember to play by the rules. There will be four guards posted as judges with striking sticks in the arena, in case either of you break the rules. They will not be easy on you just because you are young. At the end of the day, they are the ones who decide who wins the fight, so don’t do anything outlandishly dumb.”

She glanced at her back to check out the cloak. It was a grey wolf skin that had been oiled and polished to gleaming silver, and fastened with a silver brooch along her collarbone. It was a handsome thing that dwarfed her, and made her realize just how small she was in the grand scheme of things.

Beneath the cloak, she hardly wore anything. A simple shift of cloth to cover her chest, and a wrap of cloth around her waist. All the females were dressed the same, while the males wore nothing, or a wrap around their waists as well. Catra was glad she had at least some protection. Her body gleamed from the sanctified olive oil the priests had put on all of them before they drew their lots as they were praying to the gods for a good fight. She tried not to let herself be disgusted by the greasy feeling of her fur clumping together, and instead tried to think of it as protection against the dust which would cause her fur to mat.

It's not like the oil they use on the bulls and goats, she thought. *I'm not a purified sacrifice to Zeus. Don't be so morbid! All you're doing is wrestling with Lonnie. There's no need to be afraid.*

Her fear must've shown on her face, because Netossa gave her a quick tight hug. "You have nothing to worry about," she murmured, echoing Catra's thoughts. "You will be completely fine."

Before anymore could be said, the gate at the entrance to the stadium opened and two guards appeared. Outside, the crowd was roaring. Catra screwed her eyes shut to protect her from the dusty light.

"Go on!" Netossa gave her a nudge and Catra stumbled forward, not used to the weight of the cloak. She lifted her chin and walked out into the blinding sun as proudly as she could. The crowd got even louder.

On the far side of the stadium, another gate opened and Lonnie strutted out with a lion skin wrapped around her shoulders. Catra realized the significance of the cloaks as the two met in the centre.

Heracles and Theseus. Cousins by their immortal fathers, Zeus and Poseidon, heroes by all accounts, and the creators of pankration. Heracles was represented in the event by the lion skin, the physical evidence of his strength from wrestling the Nemean Lion, and Theseus was represented by the wolf skin, the

evidence of his smarts and his prize for wrestling the Minotaur to death.

Now in the games, the heroes were pitted against each other to see which would come out on top, the brains or the brawn.

One of the guards escorting Lonnie walked up to the pair of them, while two other guards removed the cloaks from their shoulders. "You were told the rules at the lot draw this morning, but I will quickly go over them again. There is to be no gouging of the eyes or groins. No biting of any kind, and no claws are to be used. Victory is determined by unconsciousness, or by submission. Do you agree to follow the rules and fight fairly?"

The two girls eyed each other warily before nodding their heads. "We do," Lonnie replied. Her voice quavered and Catra realized she was just as nervous for this fight as she was.

Somewhere far above them in the seating area, Adora was watching them, crowned with golden laurels. Her father had let her compete after all, in the footrace earlier in the day, and Adora had won. And that gave Catra the determination she needed to straighten her back and vow to herself not to give up. A horn blasted from the edge of the arena and the crowd quieted. The fight was on.

Catra and Lonnie circled each other, assessing the other for weak spots. Lonnie struck first, but Catra dodged easily. She retaliated with a jab towards the other girl. Lonnie caught her hand and threw her off. They had a brief struggle after Lonnie tried to

grapple Catra, but the magicat easily slipped out of it thanks to the olive oil coating her, and her cat like reflexes. Lonnie tried for a sliding kick to take her legs out from under her, but Catra leapt over it.

The human got into a groove. Punches, kicks and grapple attempts came with the famous Lonnie fury now. Catra didn't even have time to go on the offensive, she could only manage to duck, dodge and weave away from her.

But the hybrid did not panic. Instead of scrambling and wasting her energy avoiding all the blows, she strategically allowed her opponent to land a couple of hits to map the way the other girl's body worked without a weapon. She stole a quick glance up to where she knew Adora was watching with her family. She had learned that from her.

The princesses hadn't invited Catra to train with them again, but she hadn't had the time anyways. The day after she trained with Adora, King Micah brought in previous victors of his Games to train the wards in one of the seven events, and all were expected to participate. She had spent the week training with hardly any downtime. But now, Adora smiled at her at meal times.

A hearty blow to her cheekbone sent the thoughts rattling right out of her head. She stumbled back a step, and a foot struck her right in her gut, as quick as an adder. She grunted as Lonnie loomed over her, arms locked under her own.

"Are you actually going to fight me?" She hissed, her pale green eyes flashing. "Or are you just going to sit there daydreaming all day?"

Catra spat at her and surged upwards, dislodging her opponent and giving her room to place a roundhouse kick at her head.

"I'm just getting started," she growled. She aimed a slashing blow towards the girl but fell short; she had forgotten her claws were wrapped. A hard object came down on the back of her neck with a solid *whack* that stung.

She screeched and glared behind her at the guard, who raised his stick again. "No claws!" He snapped. She bared her teeth and he took a step towards her.

A Sparta kick to her side sent her flying with a gasp. Lonnie was back up and swinging, aiming punches at her ribs, sides and back, no longer going for her head.

She did her research too, Catra realized. While she had been on the defensive, Lonnie had been paying attention to what she protected most, and what she left exposed. She just needed an opportunity. It was time for the fight to truly begin.

The next time Lonnie came at her, Catra lowered her head and hunched her shoulders, charging her like a bull. She grabbed her around the middle and drove her into the nearest wall, where she

lay punch after wicked punch into her shoulders and ribs. Lonnie fought back hard, laying strong and precise blows into Catra's spine and shoulders. Then, the worst thing possible happened.

Lonnie kicked her way past Catra's leg block, and stomped as hard as she could on Catra's tail. She screamed, resisting the primal urge to sink her teeth into her attacker, as white hot pain raced up her spine from her sensitive appendage. Lonnie used the momentary pause to flip them, so Catra was against the wall and back on the defensive.

She tricked to block the powerful attacks on her torso, but as soon as her face was exposed, the assault switched targets from her ribs to her face, battering her sensitive eyes and ears. They were both slick with blood and panting at this point. Catra's legs were shaking and threatening to give out the more her head took a beating.

The real turning point came when Catra's legs gave out after a particularly brutal uppercut that left her half-blind and stunned. The maniacal screaming and cheering of the crowd crescendoed, melding into the roaring of blood in her ears as she slid down the rough-hewn sandstone wall, leaving red streaks as her back was cut open on the sharpness.

As soon as she started going down, Lonnie wrapped both hands around her throat and began to squeeze, cutting off all air in her already fried brain. Catra gasped and tried to fight it, but Lonnie was eleven and had two years worth of size and strength on Catra. She flopped around and twisted as best as she could without breaking her neck in her desperation for oxygen. She

squeezed her eyes shut and lifted her lip in a snarl. This was not how the fight would end!

The older girl placed a knee on Catra's chest and the other on her thigh, applying enough pressure that Catra felt her bones creak, on the edge of breaking. She screamed her frustration, but the only thing that managed to get past those unforgiving hands on her throat was a strangled sob. She tried to push Lonnie off of her, but her arms were deadweight from the lack of oxygen.

"Just submit!" Lonnie cried. She squeezed Catra's throat slightly harder. She opened her eyes and glared at the girl, surprised to find pure desperation in her eyes. "Please! I don't want to kill you!"

Catra's vision was a mess of black dots and red crackles from broken blood vessels. She must've been close to passing out or dying. She shook her head at Lonnie, but glanced behind her and found Adora right in her line of sight. The young royal was standing, her father restraining her, and she was reaching out towards the fight. At first, Catra dumbly thought that it was because she wanted to fight, but then a tiny voice reached her ears over the swelling chant of "Finish her!"

"Catra! Live!"

Somehow, those two words had enough draw on Catra to knock down the last defence of her pride. She met Lonnie's eyes through a haze of red. Blinked once. And raised her index finger, pointing at the sky like she was summoning Zeus and all his wrath.

Lonnie’s face broke into an expression of pure relief, respect and gratitude as a guard bellowed, “That’s the match! Lonnie wins by submission!”

The hands at her throat were released, and Catra retched and coughed violently. The judges lifted the older girl off her, and paraded her through the stadium while Catra just lay limp and still on the dusty arena floor, praying for an end to the world of pain she was in. Her whole body throbbed, and despite desperately needing air, she felt her throat closing, though whether it was from the swelling or her disappointment, she didn’t know.

Misery threatened to end her right there and then. She had failed. She hadn’t been able to beat Lonnie, hadn’t even been close. She was nothing, she was no good, she was—

“You’re alive!” Someone gasped from above her. Catra managed to open one of her eyes. Through the mess of swelling, and black and red lines in her vision, she could make out the familiar blue eyes of Adora, watery and relieved, as she stared at Catra. A golden aura seemed to surround her, and she was worried that meant she was dying, but then Adora leaned closer and she could make out the golden laurels in a wreath in her hair.

Catra let out a broken purr which was barely a rasp before she could stop herself. The next moment, someone else’s shadow appeared behind Adora. She was far too damaged to utter a cry of warning, but there was no need.

Netossa placed a warm, soothing hand on Catra's cheek. "You did good, kid," she murmured. "We're gonna take care of you now. Just rest. You did everything right. I'm proud of you."

The feline closed her eyes, and a broken moan managed to whine it's way from her throat. She felt strong arms pick her up, being careful not to jostle her overly sensitive body, and when she opened her eyes again, she found herself being cradled close to Netossa's chest while Adora trotted behind her.

***

The next time she woke up, the pain had subsided a little. There was a roaring in her ears, and someone was unwrapping the bindings around her claws. She was lying in a cot somewhere she didn't recognize right away, and it seemed to be night time. She blinked and turned to find Adora with an expression of concentration on her face as she carefully undid all of Netossa's hard work. Catra let out a small hiss as she accidentally jostled against one of her new bruises.

Adora looked up from her handiwork and smiled gently. "You're awake," she sighed, something like relief in her voice.

"Hey Adora," she rasped, her voice more growly and whispery than usual. She looked around the softly lit chamber. A bigger bed dominated most of the room, and the roaring she heard registered as a waterfall in the far corner of the room. The far side of the room was open to the elements, and the air tasted of rain and nighttime. "Where are we?"

“My personal chambers.” Catra felt her face heat up as the canopy bed and the waterfall registered in her mind from the first day she had arrived. Adora continued, “Netossa said you’d probably appreciate the quiet space to recover away from the other wards. They’ve been celebrating the Games all night.”

Catra nodded and flexed her other hand, which was already unwrapped.

“How do you feel?”

“Like I got dragged around by my neck,” she groaned. Her whole body throbbed, but it was centralized in her neck. Adora made a soft noise in her throat.

“My mom came by and gave you some stuff for the pain. She said you’d be very sleepy for awhile, but that it would fix you pretty fast.”

As if Adora’s words were magic, Catra’s jaws parted in a huge yawn and her eyelids seemed to grow heavy again.

“You should rest,” the princess murmured. “Things will be better when you wake.”

She nodded again, and was out cold.

***

The absence of pain, and someone shaking her shoulder gently, stirred her what felt like moments later. The room was still dark, although the sky outside the glassless windows along the far side of the room was grey with the coming dawn. Adora stood over her, looking wide awake and alert despite the early hour, and Glimmer stood behind her, looking much more haggard and sleepless.

"What's going on?" Catra wondered out loud, sitting up in bed. Her pain was gone, all her bruises and cuts faded or disappeared, but she still felt the fight in her bones and muscles, which smarted against sudden movements.

Grave, pale blue eyes met her gold-and-blue ones. "Scorpia has returned."

Chapter End Notes

I was doing some research about the Olympics and read about pankration so I had to include it! The name drops of Heracles and Theseus are part of the actual mythological beginnings of pankration, and the story of the dead victor is true! It was so cool to read about!

My motivation has kind of slowed with this fic. It's getting to the mid-way lull and I know I gotta punch through it but any love you can give for this fic is greatly appreciated and definitely helps with motivation! I may not always respond to

comments but I read each and every one! And share this story places! Bring more people in to read it haha I'd love to see it posted on Tumblr, but I'm not super Tumblr savvy so I don't normally post things myself. If you guys are enjoying it and want to share the love, feel free to tag me on Tumblr, @underthemoonlitday or ask questions! I'd love to geek out with all of you!

Next update will be August 29th! See you then!

Chapter 7: The Stirrings of War

Chapter Notes

SCORPIA'S BACK!!

Shoutout to all you wonderful people, you guys are awesome! I am so glad you guys are enjoying the story so far! I changed the chapter count! I've set it to 20 chapters for now, but that may change, depending on how these next few chapters go. I'm considering the next few chapters to be the "mid-way" point of the story with this chapter the last of "Part 1" of 3 "Parts" of the story! (The three ages that Adora and Catra will be in this story)

No content warnings for this one besides the overall themes of the story! Hope you enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

There was something about Adora's tone that jolted Catra immediately out of the bed. "What's happened to her?" She asked, her voice deadly calm.

"We don't know," Adora started, hands in a calming gesture. "Glimmer sensed her presence and teleported to her, but when she got there—"

Catra flattened her ears and hissed, cutting off Adora. She was familiar with death, it was a common trend in the Fright Zone with Shadow Weaver's hunger for power and domination causing several wars at the same time. Guards, friends, people Catra would come to think of as family, would disappear to the wars, never to come home living. She would see them lying still and cold on a pyre, with a coin over each eye for their soul to pay the

ferryman Charon, who would escort them to the underworld. She shuttered to think the same fate would become of Scorpia.

"You don't have to tiptoe around death, princess," she snapped sharply. "Shadow Weaver made sure I knew just fine what it was."

Adora looked taken aback as Glimmer glared fiercely right back at Catra. "She's not dead, you idiot," the younger girl shot back with a fierceness Catra hadn't seen before. "And show more respect! You're talking to the princesses of Bright Moon!"

The magicat was stunned into silence, her cheeks reddening and her ears flattening to her head more out of embarrassment than anything else. Adora shook out of her stunned silence and fixed Catra with a reproachful look.

"What I was *going* to say was that by the time we got there, our father was already speaking with her. She's banged up, but she's alive."

The relief that washed through Catra was almost embarrassing.

"I…" her words trailed off as she glanced from the princesses to the door and back to Adora. She had not been dismissed by the royals yet, but she also had to see Scorpia and make sure she was indeed alive. It might've been a trick. Adora held out her hand to Catra, her other hand holding Glimmer's.

“Do you trust me?”

Gold-and-blue eyes met pale blue ones as she nodded. She slipped her hand into Adora’s as Glimmer blinked them out of the room and into the castle. When her body re-solidified, Catra found herself back in the small chamber where she had met Queen Angella. Only this time, the goddess was not there. Instead, King Micah stood by a table in the centre, and Scorpia stood in front of him with her back to the two princesses and Catra. Catra wanted to rush to her friend and hug her, but Adora squeezed her hand tightly.

“Wait here,” she whispered, gently leading Catra into the shadowy corner. Catra, for once, listened with her eyes on the king. He was a kind and pious man, doing exactly what the gods asked of him, but he held Catra’s fate in his hands, and that scared her. She watched the young princesses approach their father.

“Adora! Good, I’m glad you girls are awake. This is important for when you are ruling.” Adora hugged his waist and he wrapped an arm around her, scooping up Glimmer in his other arm. He offered his daughters each a warm smile, then nodded to Scorpia. “You may report now.”

“I went to Eternia as planned,” she said, her voice hoarse and thick. “When I got there, the castle had not yet been overrun. We were able to hold them off for a couple of weeks, but the enemy force just kept growing. They call themselves the Horde and they act like one. There’s no organization beyond their leaders. No real attack patterns either. They just. Kept. Coming. When they

reached the castle, King Randor sent his father, Miro, and the prince away. But… he stayed behind. He *told* me to go with them." Her voice cracked, and Catra saw Scorpia's strong legs shaking. Her head was bowed now. "I couldn't leave Randor to face them on his own. I thought… I thought we had a chance, but I was wrong."

The tall girl turned her head to look out the window, and Catra covered her mouth to stop from crying out. Scorpia's white hair was shorter, charred black and burned to the scalp in some places. Fresh scars dappled her kind face, and jagged, thick scorch marks had burned their way through her protective shoulder plates, and along her pincers. It was a miracle she was still standing.

"Their leader is a son of Zeus. He calls himself Horde Prime, and he certainly is his father's son. There was fire everywhere. Randor stood for as long as he could, but… he fell when Prime breached the throne room.I don't know what became of him. I had to get out of there…"

Her voice trailed away as a tear fell from one, haunted obsidian eye. Micah set down Glimmer, his eyes soft in sympathy as he clasped one of her shoulders. "You don't have to continue, that is enough for now." His voice was fatherly, gentle even, but Scorpia shook her head.

"It's okay, there's… not much more to report on. I fought my way out of the castle and ran. I took this crazy path up through the Eternal Mountains, then doubled back to the sea in case anyone was following me. I don't know what happened to Prince Adam or Miro, but I hope they got out."

”Thank you for telling us what happened,” the king murmured. Catra saw his gaze fall on the map on the table behind him. He splayed his hands on the table as he stared down on it, then tapped a spot on the far left side. “Eternia is far enough east that we shouldn’t have to worry about an invasion anytime soon. However, if they are as powerful as you say, then we will keep an eye on them. I will send messengers out in the morning to inform our allies of the fall of Eternia and the new potential threat. Go now to find my wife, Angella. She will be able to patch you up.”

Scorpia bowed stiffly to the king, then limped out of the room, eyes fixed firmly on the ground in front of her. She didn’t even see Catra in the shadows.

The king spoke once the door had closed behind her. “I will miss Randor. He was a good friend of mine in my youth.” His words were addressed to no one, it would seem, as he stared blankly at the wall without seeing it. He shook himself and turned to face Adora and Glimmer once more.

“It’s situations like these, Adora,” he began, looking at his eldest daughter. “That make having a therapon essential.”

He used the formal word for the sworn companion of the royal. Not only would this person protect the royal, but they would also serve as their closest consultant in peaceful times.

“But—” Adora began, but Micah shook his head and tapped on the door. It swung open, and Lonnie appeared, looking more awake than Catra felt.

“I know I said I wouldn’t force it upon you, but Lonnie is this year’s Aristocycaon. As such, I have offered her the chance to become your therapon.”

Adora looked Lonnie over for a moment before she shook her head. “Father, I appreciate that you are trying to find me a therapon,” she began, slowly and formally. “But I have already chosen.”

The princess turned hopeful eyes to the corner where Catra was standing, and beckoned her out of the shadows. She hesitantly walked into view, looking over once timidly at the king before her eyes darted to Lonnie. The dusty haired girl showed no emotion on her face, though her eyebrow quirked up, the only sign of her surprise.

“Who is this?” The king asked. A serious frown turned his dark eyes to shadows between his bushy brows and his neatly kept beard. Catra was slightly surprised he didn’t remember her, seeing as he had dragged her off Lonnie just the other day, but then again, he did run a castle with plenty of wayward children in it.

“Catra, daughter of Shadow Weaver,” Adora pronounced. Catra turned stunned eyes onto the princess. Never in any conversation had Shadow Weaver’s name popped up in relation to her. She had

never told Adora that Shadow Weaver was her mother. Which meant—

"Ah yes, the one the drill sergeant wants whipped for fighting outside of lessons." He flashed a wry grin to Lonnie. "And you know of her crime?"

"I do," Adora answered seriously, but confidently. "She killed a guard."

"For nearly a year now, your mother and I have suggested companions for you. Why this one?"

"She's different. She surprises me." The princess shrugged. Catra's mouth went dry as she stared at her. There was no judgement on her face whatsoever.

"She should have this honour!" To everyone's surprise, it was Lonnie who spoke in Catra's defence. They all turned to look at her, and her face grew red, but she plowed on nonetheless. "She's an admirable adversary, and the toughest competition I have ever been up against. She would do better serving the princess. She wouldn't have submitted in the fight yesterday if Adora hadn't told her to live. I don't think there's anyone more deserving than Catra.

"And Catra? Is this something you would like as well?"

"I-I do!" She managed to stammer in her shock and nerves. She glanced at Lonnie's face but found only respect there. No hard feelings, no grudges. Turning to Adora, she found the blonde's face alight with pleasure.

"Then the issue is settled." Micah waved a hand, dismissing them all. "Adora, show Catra your rooms. A servant will gather her belongings and drop them off before this evening."

***

The first few days being Adora's companion were awkward to say the least. Every morning, both girls woke up, said only the briefest and clumsiest of greetings, then went about their day separately. Adora would go to her lessons with Glimmer and Bow, but Catra was never invited. She would go to her own lessons with Scorpia and the other wards.

The group opinion of Catra had changed. No longer was she ignored or challenged to brawls. Now the other kids looked at her with a mixture of respect and fear in their eyes. She was the reigning heir's chosen companion. To dishonour her would be to risk the wrath of Adora and the royal family. Only Scorpia and Netossa knew her well enough to keep sparring with her.

Something had changed with Scorpia. She never spoke of Eternia despite everyone's curiosity. The exuberant twinkle in her eye had shifted. She was still cheerful and as kind as ever, but now a soft

kind of reflection would come over her. She took things more seriously now. Scorpia was growing up.

Every day after dinner, Catra would poke her head into the Barracks to see if her belongings had been returned, if Adora had changed her mind. Each day her bed remained bare and void of any of her things.

The awkward dance that the two had constructed came to an abrupt stop a week after Adora had chosen her. She'd been asleep on her cot, or as close to sleep as she came these days. Since the Games, the nightmares of the guard she'd killed return stronger than ever. Most nights, she woke in a cold sweat, the pillow clamped between her teeth to prevent a scream, and watched Adora thrash and strike out in her sleep. Always fighting, even against her dreams.

But that night, it was gentle shaking that ripped her from her nightmare.

"Catra, wake up!" Adora was calling. Catra's eyes flew open, and it took her a few heartbeats to remember where she was. Her throat was raw, her breaths coming in great, heaving gasps. "It's okay," the princess continued. "You were just having a nightmare. You're safe now."

She helped Catra prop herself up, then ran a gentle hand over her back in a circular motion. Catra's breaths shuddered and she ran her hands over her face and through her hair.

“What were you dreaming about?”

She glared at Adora but found only concern and curiosity on her serious face. No sign of teasing or ill will. The magicat sighed and found herself hesitantly leaning on Adora.

“The guard,” she mumbled, breathing in Adora’s iron scent to ground herself. “I always dream about her.”

“Do you… want to talk about it?”

So Catra finally did. She told Adora all about the incident, every detail including Shadow Weaver’s disappointment as she had been hauled into the throne room for punishment.

“You didn’t lie?” Adora cut in. “Say you were defending yourself?”

The thought had never crossed Catra’s mind. Why hadn’t she thought of that? Instead, some demon had possessed her into thinking her ruler might even be proud of her. Maybe the disappointment in her face wasn’t because Catra had killed, but rather because she had not been cunning enough to think of a reason why.

“I guess a small part of me was glad to have Shadow Weaver’s attention for once. It never occurred to me to lie. She was always killing people who disagreed with her. I thought, if I could show her that I can do that too, she will make more time for me.”

“There are other ways to make people proud of you. Helping a friend out in, say, her fighting lessons is one way?”

Catra’s head shot up at the question. “You’re… inviting me along?”

The other girl laughed lightly. “You don’t need to wait for an invitation to join me, Catra. I thought you would’ve guessed you were always welcome after the first one! Is that why you haven’t come back?”

Her face flushed and she looked away again. “I thought I did something wrong. No one told me otherwise when I went with the other kids.”

“Oh gods, no! You did nothing wrong! You’re always welcome to come hang out with me and Glimmer and Bow. In fact, I’d really like it if you did!” She smiled lightly and then motioned for Catra to continue her story. “Then what happened after you went to the throne room?”

She sighed heavily and hunched up, pulling her knees to her chest and crossing her arms over them. “Nothing. She disowned me and sent me away.”

"She sent you *here*," Adora corrected her gently, putting a hand on her arm. "Was that so bad?"

Catra looked away from the blonde. "Not really," she begrudgingly admitted. She felt a smirk growing on her face. "I have this dorky blonde who won't leave me alone, but it can't be perfect." She nudged Adora's shoulder and she laughed.

"Oh sure, *I'm* the dork says the geek who can name every type of mouse in the kitchen without hesitation!"

The feline mocked a gasp and shoved her friend playfully. "You take that back! That was *one* time!"

"You gonna make me, geek?"

"Watch and learn, dummy!" She pounced on Adora, and the pair descended into wrestling, laughter ringing throughout the night-time halls.

Chapter End Notes

> This chapter and the next are both the shortest of the few I have written so depending on how much writing I get done early this week, there may be an earlier update before next Sunday. However, I'm not promising anything! (I like staying a couple chapters ahead of posting. That way if the interactions on this story go down I'm not completely

bummed out or feel pressured to get the chapter out before I’m happy with it)

Next update will be September 5th! See you then, if not sooner!

Chapter 8: Time Thief

Chapter Summary

The kiddos age up. Glimmer does parkour.

Chapter Notes

Hey guys! How's it going? Here we go with Part II of the story! Part III will come with the actual war itself. I'm posting on break at work today, so I don't have too much time. Enjoy the story!

If you haven't seen it already, I posted a one-shot based on the song Interlude IV by Zach Callison. Feel free to check it out!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

After that night, the two quickly became nearly inseparable. Catra tagged along to every lesson of Adora's, and they sat beside each other at every meal. Soon they were laughing at private jokes, and jostling each other or wrestling casually.

Catra, like Bow, was accepted into the family with open arms. Angella would light-heartedly scold their roughhousing, while Micah took to calling Catra Scops —"Owl"— for her large, sharp eyes, and began to teach both Adora and Catra new weapon-handling techniques.

Time seemed to pass in a blur of chasing Adora everywhere, and making up excuses when they got caught so that they wouldn't get in trouble. Catra blinked open her eyes one day to discover that she was now thirteen.

She lifted her head and yawned widely, baring her teeth like a cat, then uncurled from her tight ball. Beneath her, Adora shifted her legs. Catra looked up to where the girl was stirring, her golden hair unbound and tousled, and her pale blue eyes half-lidded still. It was Catra's favourite view in the world. The private moments when Adora was all hers.

Her heart thudded in her chest, and she glanced away, sitting up at the thought. Adora wasn't hers and would never be. *You shouldn't think like that,* she thought crossly to herself. *Adora will be married off to some prince from a far away land to rule over Bright Moon soon enough.*

Adora kicked her from under the blankets. "Y'know, you do still have your own bed. My legs are asleep."

"Would you rather you woke up on the floor with a bloody nose again?" Adora's sleep fighting had gotten so bad recently, that she'd fallen out of bed and gave herself a bloody nose. Twice. Catra had started sleeping at the foot of her bed to protect her from herself.

The princess pouted, then reached to the stand beside the bed. She pulled out a leather pouch from one of the drawers and tossed it to Catra, who caught it easily.

"What's this?" She asked.

“Happy birthday,” Adora mumbled into her pillow as she nuzzled herself back down under the covers. Catra blinked down at her with a trill of affection before pulling on the drawstrings. The pouch opened easily, and a necklace dropped out of the pouch. A gem of lapis lazuli hung on a simple thong of corded leather. The point of the gem was royal blue, flecked with white quartz, while the base was the colour of burnt gold; flashing brilliant pyrite and flakes of iridescent mica.

“Matches your eyes,” came Adora’s sleepy remark. Catra looked back at her, and found her pale gaze peeking at her from the corner of the pillow. “Do you like it?”

She slipped it over her head and lay down beside Adora, nuzzling her cheek in the way she knew the blonde loved, even if she didn’t understand why. “I love it, dummy.”

Adora pulled her down beside her for a hug, then settled her hand on Catra’s ribs, feeling the purr that rattled through her too quietly to hear. The blonde’s breath tickled Catra’s neck from where she nestled her head in the crook at her shoulder, but she didn’t push her away. Adora was the only person who could be this cuddly with Catra. If anyone else tried, even Scorpia, she would warn them away with a growl or a flash of claws.

“Let’s go back to sleep for a bit. We don’t have training today.”

Adora’s days were not as jam packed with lessons as Catra had once thought. Instead, she only had one formal swordsmanship tutor, Juliet, and a handful of court sessions she attended with one of Bright Moon’s lords every week. That left plenty of free time for the young royals and their companions to wreak havoc on the peaceful kingdom.

“Glimmer said Mermista and her husband were coming to court today,” Catra whispered, just as Adora’s breaths began evening out. That was the reason why Juliet couldn’t train with them that day. Mermista, who was known to be the fairest in all of their lands, had married a son of Atreus who ruled the ocean-side kingdom of Salineas. Salineas was backed by the might of Dryl and the Northern Reach, so should Bright Moon displease the king of Salineas, there would be an all-out war on their hands. “Do you wanna listen in on the council? Maybe try to get a glimpse of her face? You’d think that someone who is said to be the most beautiful person in the world would show it off now that she’s married.”

Adora’s eyes opened immediately with a grin on her face. Catra squirmed out of her hug and grabbed her arm. “Let’s go!”

***

A couple of hours later, Catra found herself in the void space of the ceiling of the throne room, squished between Bow and Adora. “When I said, ‘Let’s eavesdrop on the court’, this is not what I meant!” She hissed sharply.

"Oh can it, Soft-paws," Glimmer whispered back fiercely. Catra scowled at the nickname, a recent acquiring after Scorpia loudly announced that Catra's fur was the softest thing to ever grace Etheria. Since rarely anyone could touch her, and because Bow thought it was adorable, he and Glimmer took to calling her Soft-paws as a joke. She wanted to claw the princess' smug look off her face, but unfortunately Bow was in the way. "I couldn't get us in because we were banned for a month after *someone* thought setting off fire-crackers under Grand Master Norwyn's chair was a good idea."

"That wasn't me that was Adora!"

"I saw you light them!"

"Guys, stop arguing," Bow murmured. Always the peacekeeper in their ragtag group of friends. He had one of his homemade devices he had been tinkering with lately. It was a small object, shaped a bit like a chalice, though it was hollow with a small gap at the bottom and a larger one at the top, and it was made of thick hide. He placed the narrow end on the tile they were crouching on.

"What's the point of thi—?" Catra began, though she cut herself off as noise floated up from the device. Voices, Micah's and a man she didn't recognize.

"Can you—?" Bow began. She waved him quiet. Micah was speaking.

"… Brings you to our halls?" He was asking. His voice was polite, respectful and calm. He did not know whether the man in front of him could be trusted completely.

"Micah, I come to you as one king to another." The other voice was surprisingly youthful, with a boyish sort of over-confidence and bravado.

"What are they saying?" Adora whispered loudly in her ear, jolting Catra's concentration. She grabbed Adora's face and pushed her back.

"I can't hear when you shout in my ear," she hissed. "They're just introducing themselves. The other king kinda sounds like a prick."

"… Prince is all over my wife! I ask you to stand with me as I send a small patrol to the boy's family to let them know of the wrong their son is committing in their name."

"Pfft. Relax, Sea Hawk." This was a woman's voice, also surprisingly youthful, but melodious and sweet with an edge of iron to it. "I'm your wife, not your property. I've got this handled. He's just a boy, he means no harm. Not sure why you *insisted* we ring the war bells."

“It’s Mermista and her husband, Sea Hawk,”Catra breathed to her friends. “Some prince has been sniffing around Mermista. She doesn’t think he means anything, but her husband is out looking for war.”

“Men,” Glimmer, Adora and Bow all sighed. Catra nodded with them.

“Alright, Sea Hawk,” Micah’s voice drifted up. He sounded amused. “I’ll give you a few of my soldiers to go with you. But know that should war break out, you must fight your own battles. You may have been a good pirate, but now it’s time to be a king. And a king isn’t afraid to get his hands dirty for his men.”

“Now your dad is saying he will send some men with Sea Hawk to tell the prince’s family off, but that if war breaks out over Mermista, Bright Moon won’t fight Sea Hawk’s battles for him.” She listened more, but the conversation had drifted onto politics and the changing thrones of Etheria. “Come on, we should go before—”

Before she could finish her thought, a shudder and a groan rang out from all around them. They had time to exchange glances before the groan became the sound of shattering wood and rock, and their perch let out from under them.

If it wasn’t for Glimmer, they all would have died. Catra’s world tilted sideways, then her heart and stomach were in her throat as she was falling in a spiral through the air, her friends around her. None of them even had the breath to utter a scream. Suddenly, a

small hand yanked on the back of Catra's shirt, and the falling ceased.

She landed on the ground with a thud, though it was not through the ceiling. Glimmer had managed to grab all of them and teleport them to the ground without the fall killing them. Only Catra's kidneys and spleen gave protest as all three of her friends landed on top of her.

We are alive, she thought with a smile. A smile that disappeared as soon as she looked up and saw a very amused moustachioed man only a couple years older than them, and a not-at-all amused Micah looking down at them.

***

Catra, Adora, Bow and Glimmer sat in guilty silence for most of the day in the small council chamber, guarded round the clock like prisoners awaiting trial. They'd tried three times to escape, but each time they were caught within minutes and escorted back to wait for the king.

"I'll take the fall for this one," Catra found herself telling the others as she watched the sun approach the horizon out the window. Damn these princesses for making her want to be honest! "It was my idea after all."

"Don't you mean *my* idea?" Glimmer piped up. The eleven year old's childish petulance had blossomed into a dogged stubbornness that matched Catra's. It often left the two butting heads more often than cooperating. "I can teleport. We were in a sealed ceiling. There's no way they're gonna buy that it was your idea."

"Sure they will! Whose idea was it to raid the kitchen? Steal Kyle's clothes? Follow Juliet around in uniform all day? This totally sounds like one of my ideas."

"Good point. We all got caught on those adventures, too. Maybe we should *stop* listening to you and your ideas."

Catra was about to retort back, but just then, the door opened and both Micah and Angella walked in. Catra's ears flattened to her head. She found herself suddenly wishing a hole would appear at her feet and swallow her whole. The Queen only got involved when they were in severe trouble. Shame licked up her cheeks in red heat.

As soon as the doors shut behind them, Catra blurted out, "I'm sorry, I'm sorry, I'm sorry! It's all my fault, please don't get them in trouble! It was all me!"

Both monarchs regarded her for a moment. Then Micah shook his head and grinned. He ruffled the hair between her ears. "Oh, Scops, there's no need to be so dejected!"

“We know this was a group effort,” Angella said, staring sternly at her daughters. Glimmer scowled.

“Why isn’t Bow ever included in the Group Effort stare?” She muttered to Adora. Catra tried not to smile as Angella clearly overheard her words as well.

“Because I know Bow is just an innocent who gets roped into the mischief you three begin.”

Bow nodded along earnestly. “Yep! That’s right! Just a totally innocent bystander. Wrong place and wrong time, right?” Catra rolled her eyes. He was not entirely innocent. He had led several of their more daring adventures including but not limited to: breaking into and rearranging the books in Micah’s private library; leaving ominous messages in the astronomy tower, which left the astronomers fasting for a week to avoid the wrath of angry gods; and Catra’s favourite, hiding behind certain statues at the Temple of the Gods and telling worshippers’ fortunes without ever being seen.

Catra had hid behind the statue of Perfuma, the goddess of spring and love, Adora hid behind She-Ra’s statue, Glimmer ironically enough chose Selenae’s statue, and Bow hid behind Apollo himself. He used arrow jokes and a cracking, newly deepened voice that had the girls in silent stitches the whole time.

“That’s besides the point,” Micah said. “The events of today made us realize something.” He exchanged a glance with his wife, who nodded.

“We would like—” Angella began. She didn’t get further than that.

The doors behind the royals flew open in a burst of golden light. Catra shielded her eyes while Adora quickly sprang into action, placing herself between her family and friends and whatever this golden light was. It moved into the room and dimmed until Catra could see that she was an impossibly tall woman in full, gleaming white and gold battle armour.

“Stand down, Adora,” she boomed in a voice that was strangely familiar to Catra. She took in the stranger’s scent and nearly gagged at the cold frost-and-blood scent that reached her. It was like Adora’s, but ten times stronger. The light dimmed more until Catra could make out nearly white-blonde hair, Adora’s winter-sky eyes, and skin like molten bronze. As she stared, she made out more and more features that were familiar. There was Adora’s nose, her brows that made her appear so removed from humanity when she furrowed them, her tall, slim build. That was when she made the connection.

“Selenae,” She-Ra called again. Everyone except Micah and Catra looked confused. “Sister, shed your mortal disguise. It is time our daughters know the truth.”

“Our?” Glimmer wondered, her eyes darting between She-Ra and her mother.

“Daughters?” Adora echoed, incredulous. She turned to Catra with wide, shocked eyes. Catra shook her head, but saw Angella swell and change before she could say anything. In a heartbeat, the room felt too small crammed between two goddesses, one of whom now fluttered her translucent wings. “*Mom?*” Adora cried in shock.

“Yes, my daughter.” To everyone’s shock, it was She-Ra who spoke. “Come to me, Adora of the House of Micah. Let me give you my blessing as your mother.”

Chapter End Notes

No one:
Absolutely no one:
Mara: *busts down door*
Mara: ding-dong

Sorry for another short chapter, but the next one is longer, I promise!

Hope you enjoyed! As always, leave me a comment or a like if you did enjoy, I love seeing the interactions! Have a good week, everyone, see you next Sunday!

Chapter 9: Princess of Bright Moon

Chapter Notes

> Ha! It's 11:30 PM so it is still on time by half an hour! Hi friends! Hope you had a lovely week! The mid way lull is almost done now! One more chapter and then I will be out of it and more things will start happening faster! Enjoy this update!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

A shocked silence fell over everyone. Adora could feel everyone's eyes flickering between the goddess who had burst through the door and her. They were making the same connections she was. She could only stare. There had to be some mistake.

"That… that can't be right," she mumbled at last, her hands shaking. "Bright Moon is all I've ever known! This is my home, my family! You—you've got the wrong Adora. I am the eldest daughter of King Micah and Queen Angella."

She turned hopeful eyes to her parents, trying not to gawk at the wings protruding from her mother's back. Her hope crashed into the pit of her stomach when Angella—*Selenae*—wouldn't meet her eyes, and Micah's were soft with sympathy.

"Right?"

Angella opened her mouth, but She-Ra cut her off. "It's a nice dream," she said, her voice surprisingly soft. The goddess made

her way over to Adora, transforming as she moved into a young woman only a couple of years older than herself. She took in her long, nut-brown hair, her blue-grey eyes the colour of a winter storm, and realized just how much of herself she could see in the goddess' mortal face. "I am telling you the truth though. I swear it by the dark river. Ask your mother for the truth from her mouth, if you must. She will not lie to you."

Adora stared hard at the winged goddess she had called mother for thirteen years. "Angella?" She asked through gritted teeth. The smallest ripple, a flinch, sliced across her immortal face. She finally met Adora's glare with sorrowful eyes.

"I was going to tell you," she whispered. "When the time came."

Hot betrayal coursed through Adora. "I… I thought," she stammered. She looked around and the friends and family she had known her whole life, and she couldn't recognize any of them. It was like looking at them through the reflection of a river. Panic flared in her veins, and anger followed at the pity she saw on Bow's kind face. Catra reached out to her, but she reeled away.

She looked at She-Ra, her birth mother, and nausea coiled in her stomach. Stone cold, unfeeling She-Ra, the goddess who could raze a whole city for the slight of one mortal, was her mother. And Selenae, goddess of the moon, had raised her, hidden behind a mortal disguise. She knew how stories ended for the children of the gods. They never lived a long, successful life. Her childhood heroes were evidence enough. Bellerophon, who flew Pegasus until he fell, shattered to the ground. Heracles, cursed and chased by Hera until he died, taking several of his own family with him.

Theseus, who betrayed his wives and died in shame after his city no longer supported him. This couldn't be the fate for Adora.

Her world tilted on it's axis. She staggered back. And ran.

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Catra tried to chase her. She knew the feelings rushing through Adora right now. She'd had the same when Shadow Weaver, drunk and angry after a feast, taunted Catra for being alone in the world, with no one to care for her save the merciful Queen who had rescued her from being left to die as a sacrifice to some nameless, heathen gods.

Instead, as she went to race after her friend, she was stopped by a delicate, translucent wing.

"Leave her. I will follow," the queen said. Catra dipped her head and watched Angella follow Adora. It was a slow pace, a pace for one to watch from a distance first to see how the one being followed would take the company.

"So you're the one my daughter chose as her companion," She-Ra said, observing Catra through a critical eye. It was unnerving to see her this way, so *mortal* when she was truly unconquerable. She was the walled city no arrow could pierce, no siege tower could overcome. Only, someone *had* overcome her, or Adora wouldn't exist.

The feline snarled, “Just because you brought her into this world doesn’t make you her mother.”

“She’s right!” To Catra’s surprise, it was Glimmer who backed her up. “I don’t care if you told me her father was the king of Sparta! Adora is my sister and Bright Moon is her home!”

The goddess’s eyes shone with amusement. “Of course it is. I wouldn’t try to take that away from her.”

“Then why are you here?” Catra asked with a frown. “Why would you claim her now? Gods don’t care about their children. Not the way mortals do.”

Glimmer made a noise in her throat, and Catra flicked an ear. She wasn’t talking about Angella. She was talking about the other gods. Nyx, who Scorpia prayed to every night, longing to meet her just once to prove that she was real. The goddess who her friend fought beast after wretched beast for, trying to impress, trying to do her labours so she could become a goddess and finally, *finally*, meet the mother who entranced a mortal princess into lying with and gifted with a child who shouldn’t be possible. Zephyr, who blazed through a kitchen maid’s life and gifted a daughter who could control the wind but who he would never see. All the gods who sired or birthed children and left them for their mortal parents to care for whether they wanted to or not.

“Most gods,” She-Ra corrected, the amusement disappearing from her eyes. “But my sister, Selenae, and I are different from the rest of our brethren.”

“Then where have you been?” She couldn’t hide the hint of a snarl in her voice. She knew interrogating the goddess wasn’t wise, especially one infamous for her cold, unfeeling rage. Even now her blue-grey eyes sparkled with warning. “Adora won’t ever question these things because it’s in her nature to be kind, but I know enough about the gods to know there *must* be more to it than this. You came years ago to give her your sword, why not claim her then?”

“It was not time. She would not have understood. The Fates have draped her in prophecy. She’s to be a hero in a war that is coming. Only undone by the blood she shares in the mortal world. She’s the most powerful demigod of this age. Everything is happening now. Her path is leading her to a choice, and she can only make it knowing the truth. She is of the age to go to Light Hope and train. That is all I can say for now.”

Catra barely heard all that She-Ra said. Her mind caught on one sentence and she knew the meaning under it. *Undone by the blood she shares with the mortal world. In war. Oh gods, Adora will die. Adora will die. Adora will die.* The words repeated in her head like the Fates themselves were whispering them to her. She let out a humourless, bitter laugh.

“So you came here to give her false hope that her life will be glorious without telling her outright that she’s going to die.”

All eyes fell on Catra. For some reason, the tiniest hint of approval gleamed on Mara's face. "You are clever for a mortal. I understand why Adora chose you."

The goddess dipped her head and was gone in a flash of light, leaving a room of four stunned mortals behind.

"Adora's going to die?" Bow's voice was unusually small.

"Everyone dies, Arrow Boy," Catra snapped. She began to pace the room, running her hands through her hair and her tail lashing in her frustration. The goddess just dropped a bombshell on them and left, not even bothering to deal with the aftermath.

"But she didn't say when," Glimmer argued. For an eleven year old, she was very logical.

"Although I doubt she'd want Adora to train as a hero if her life was going to be one of happiness. I have a feeling this war she mentioned is going to be happening a lot sooner than we think."

"We can't let that happen."

"We won't, Sparkles. Me, you and Arrow Boy. We'll keep her alive." She glared fiercely at the spot where Mara had disappeared. "She *won't* have to die young for glory."

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Adora paced in her chamber, her fingers flexing and clenching as she tried to stop their shaking. Her whole life had been a lie. She had no father, a mother who didn't care to show herself until it mattered to her, and no sister. The thought that Glimmer wasn't actually her sister caused her to stagger down onto one knee. Her whole life, protecting Glimmer and being there for her had been her purpose. She had been proud to call the girl her sister. They were supposed to rule together. What would happen now?

Almost as though her thoughts summoned her, the telltale flutter of Glimmer materializing drifted around Adora. She turned her back on it. "Not now, Glimmer," she said, trying to keep her voice steady.

"It's not Glimmer," said Angella's voice. Adora whipped around and found her mother—Angella—still in goddess form. She stood just inside the doorway, her dark eyes unreadable. Her delicate fingers were wrapped around the shaft of a beautiful, broken spearhead so hard that her skin was white.

"Has my whole life been a lie?" The words left Adora's mouth before she could stop them. She resumed her agitated prowl, like a lion rallying her pride for the hunt. Her hands were almost vibrating with her need to do something with them. She swung them in wide arcs around her. "I mean if I am not truly the firstborn child of Micah then I can't be the heir to Bright Moon, so that was a lie. Glimmer isn't my sister, so that is a lie to." She

stopped her pacing and faced Angella again, her chest heaving as panic tried to drag her under it's icy grip. "Who even am I?"

"You are Adora," Angella murmured, holding out the spear in one hand. "And you are my child. Your birth mother may lay claim to you now, but I claimed you for my own the moment I picked you up from that mountain."

"Mountain?" She frowned. The spear shook in Angella's hands so Adora took it. As soon as she touched it, images raced across her vision. She dropped to her knees.

Mara fighting a burly man with kind eyes and hair the colour of flame. A year spent in his kingdom, Mara's belly swelling with life within. A warm, dark space with another's heartbeat next to her. The sounds of an infant crying and the warm sea air wafting over her. A long journey in the warm arms of the woman who brought her into the world. Sudden cold. Blurry shadows, wolves, sniffing around her arms and legs as she cried and cried on the mountain side. A bright glowing light, almost like that of her milk-mother. Angella. Angella picking her up. A fistful of hair the colour of the dawn. Warmth around her. Not quite like Mara's, less fiery, more like a warm summer's day. And over it all, a voice whispering, "Adora, daughter of Mara."

She blinked back into the present, letting go of the spear as she did. She was on the ground now, Angella over her, murmuring soft comforts and holding her tightly.

“This is your home, my daughter,” she whispered, folding her wings and shifting back into her mortal form. “It’s here the mountain brought you, and it’s here the mountains meant to be your home.”

Adora looked away, shameful tears pricking her eyes. Delicate, cool fingers touched her chin gently, drawing her eye’s up. Her mother’s—Angella’s—eyes were the softest she had ever seen them, with a fierce love emanating from them.

“You may not have come from my body, Adora,” her voice was the barest breath on the wind, but it reached Adora all the same. Emotion lay thick in the air between them, a rare feat for the usually calm, cool and collected Queen. “But you are, and have *always* been, my daughter. I will protect you and love you no matter what. And nothing can change that. Nothing.”

And with those words, Adora broke down into sobs, throwing herself into her mother’s arms and burying her face against her chest. Angella’s heartbeat, slow and reassuring, beat in her ears as the words she didn’t know were weighing on her ripped from her throat. “Why didn’t she want me?”

“She did, my love,” Angella crooned, holding Adora tightly. “Zeus wouldn’t allow it. You have a power in you that most of the gods fear. He forbade your mother from entering Olympus with you. She had no choice.”

“And my mortal father? Did he not want me, either?”

Angella hesitated, then shook her head. “He wanted you to have a better life than he could give you. You have his smile, though, and his kind heart. I knew him when he walked this earth—he has since passed into the Underworld. This was truly the best decision Mara could have made for you. Are you truly this unhappy with the life you were given?”

Angella’s words were soft, non judging, genuinely curious. Adora pondered her question seriously, then shook her head. “I love my life here. My sister, my friends.” She met the goddess’s dark eyes and gave her a watery smile. “You have been very good to me. I’ve wanted for nothing. I just wish I knew sooner.”

“Would that have changed anything?”

Again, Adora thought about the question before she shook her head. “The only thing it would have changed is how often I wondered why I look so different from the rest of the family.”

Angella smiled, and only those who knew her as intimately as her family would’ve seen the subtle easing of her shoulder muscles, the frown smoothening on her face that marked her relief. “Your mother only claims you now because you are a hero’s age, and you are blanketed with prophecy. She wishes for you to train with Light Hope at the Crystal Tower. I told her that decision was entirely your own.”

Before the words were even out of the queen's mouth, Adora was nodding her head eagerly. But then she frowned as her thoughts turned to Catra, Bow and Glimmer. "But what about Glimmer? And Catra?"

"Well that was what your father and I were going to talk to you four about. We feel as though you're all getting too big to be cramped up inside the castle. We were going to see if you were all interested in heading to the Crystal Tower and studying under Light Hope. I think it would do the four of you good to get a proper education. And the gods know your father and I need a break from cleaning up after you."

Adora was nodding again. "How soon can we leave?" Winter was beginning to settle into Etheria, and soon the mountain valleys would be blocked by snow. They'd have to leave sooner rather than later.

"Well, see how Glimmer and the others are feeling. If they are up for it, you can leave as early as tomorrow."

The blonde smiled and launched herself at her mother, wrapping her in a bear hug like she hadn't since she was little. Adora felt like she was a child again, dwarfed by the immortality in Angella's veins. Angella hugged her back, her skin cool and soft under Adora's touch. The light changed and Adora looked up to see her delicate wings back out and shielding the pair of them from the world. She fiddled with the hem of her tunic and looked up at her.

“Mom?” She asked softly. Angella looked down with dark, timeless eyes. “Are you really a goddess?”

“I am. My true name is Selenae, though I don’t prefer it. I help drive the moon across the sky with my Olympian cousin, Artemis.”

Adora frowned. “But gods are supposed to be cold and unfeeling. You’re not though.”

“I am an older goddess than the Olympians.” Angella looked out the window towards the ocean. “This was my home when the earth-mother Gaia was awake and the ocean was a river of fire. The first time mortals settled on my shores, I was angry. I fought them, I *was* a cold goddess. But they were persistent. They returned, generation after generation, until I suddenly found myself not mad anymore. Very few knew I lived here, until Micah’s father.”

“Micah knows who you are?”

“Yes. Our marriage was a gift from his father. Their people had built a prosperous kingdom, Bright Moon, in my honour. Though, only Micah’s father, Aeacus, knew that I still lived in the Whispering Woods nearby. He visited me in my home one day with his son and asked if I would honour his family by marrying Micah. Your father was as charming then as he was now, so I agreed. We tried for many years to have children. Bright Moon needed an heir. But then I found you, and it was as though our prayers were answered. And then two years after, Glimmer finally decided to show up.”

Angella trailed off, and Adora found herself looking up at her. "What… what does this change, being the child of a goddess?" She whispered. Her head was buzzing with her thoughts, the deaths of children of the gods, and she had never felt so lost.

Her mother caressed her cheek softly. "If you don't train with Light Hope, other gods will appear before you now that She-Ra has claimed you. Some may promise to be your friend, some may say they will help grant you immortality. But Adora, you must not listen to any of them. Your path has been carved into the stones of time. What Mara told you years ago is true—you will die young and famous, or live forever and never be remembered. But be warned, by your godly blood you are more powerful than your mortal father, but by his blood you can be undone. Now that you know the truth, the time is fast approaching for you to make a choice. Train with Light Hope, if you will, and learn all you can so you can make the choice that is best for you."

A kiss was placed on the crinkle on Adora's brow as she continued. "You will always have a home here, and should you wish it, Bright Moon will be your kingdom when your father passes. It is your birthright, as our eldest child."

The blonde nodded, and for a moment, mortal and immortal held each other in a tight embrace, the queen humming softly a lullaby to her daughter that she used when she was a baby. "If you… ever want to know more about the woman who became She-Ra, I can tell you. She is my sister, after all."

“Mara,” Adora tested the name on her lips. It felt weird that she suddenly had two mothers. “I… think I would like that in the future but not right now. There’s just too much. It’s all too much.”

Her panic was not gone, not completely. It lived underneath her skin like a beast ready to pounce. As she spoke, she felt it sway towards the surface, despite Angella’s arms wrapped around her. She shook slightly, and Angella’s face turned sympathetic. “Of course, I understand. Keep the spear though, it belongs to you.” Adora nodded numbly, and the goddess turned to the door. “Catra, you can come in now,” she called.

The door opened slowly and Catra walked in. She looked mildly cowed, but her only apology for eavesdropping was a twitch of her ear. She approached Adora with a look that could be perceived as indifferent. But Adora was able to read Catra like a book. Her tail was relaxed, her ears alert but one twisting around them, wary. Her eyes held a silent question.

Do you wanna talk about it?

Angella left the room to give them some privacy. As soon as the door closed behind her, Adora’s vision blurred. Tears filled her eyes and her breaths came in ragged breaths. Her shaking hands were held up to her face where she pressed them against her mouth to stop the scream that wanted to emerge. Arms flung around her shoulders and a face pressed into the crook of her shoulder.

“It’s okay,” Catra whispered, her claws digging in slightly to her skin beneath her tunic. “It’ll all be okay. I’ve got you. I’ve got you.”

Adora sobbed freely into her friend’s embrace, squeezing her tighter as she did so. They sunk to the ground. Catra held her all night while Adora came to grips with the fact that her life would never be the same again. All the while whispering, “I’ve got you.”

Chapter End Notes

> Hope you enjoy! As always, please leave a comment or a kudos if you are enjoying it! Do I still have your attention?
>
> This was heavily inspired by that one scene in Prince of Egypt where Moses goes running through the halls singing and then his mom tells him he is adopted. Also I am ABSOLUTELY adoring writing the relationship between Adora and Angella!
>
> I need to give myself more than a week for this next chapter. There’s something that needs to happen at the end of it and I can’t seem to make it happen just yet. Therefore, it will be two weeks from now unless inspiration strikes me and I get it all done on my days off later this week. I’ve got a girl on my mind which is taking up a lot of headroom 😅 also this is Prime Time for writer’s block to hit so I’m going to try my best! I almost pushed off this update for another week, but I really can’t do that to you guys or myself. So please enjoy this one and be patient while I try to write up the next chapter and the one after it as well so I can stay ahead of the post deadline.

Chapter 10: The Nature of Dreams

Chapter Summary

> Catra has a breakdown. Someone comforts her. Dreams occur.

Chapter Notes

> Holy sweet lord I am BACK! Sorry it took so long. My life got complicated, my mental health tanked, and I got a work promotion that took me away from writing for a bit. This chapter isn't as long, but every little bit helps! I'm working on the next chapter now! Enjoy!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

It took a couple of days for Adora to bounce back from the news. Catra and their friends were with her the whole time to make sure she was okay. She would smile at them, but it was a watery and fragile thing. Her serious frown marred her face for two days straight, making her appear more of a goddess than before.

They decided to put off the trip to the Crystal Tower until Adora had recovered. They didn't want her to become someone she wasn't. The young heir began to spend hours off by herself now. Catra wasn't sure what she was doing, but she was never invited, and that made her nervous.

She tried to distract herself with her other friends. Scorpia, when she was in Bright Moon (she now ruled the Scorpion Hills after the passing of her mortal mother), was always down to spar. And should she not be around, Netossa and Spinnerella had begun to teach her how to heal using plants. The two lovers had moved out of the Barracks and into the little garden cabin in the palace

grounds. Spinnerella now tended Queen Angella's gardens while Netossa took over as drill sergeant, and taught the wards sparring. Catra was proud of her friends; they had all grown up and done things with themselves.

"Is Adora gone again?" Netossa asked when Catra jumped up onto the fence that bordered their garden one day with feather-light feet. Catra nodded.

"All week she's been doing this," she sighed, brushing strands of her unruly mane out of her eyes. Her bangs were getting long and she had no desire to cut them, so she'd taken to wearing the red headpiece she had stolen from Shadow Weaver before she left the Fright Zone as a way of keeping her hair out of her face.

"Where does she say she goes?"

"For a walk."

"Have you tried following her?"

Catra sent Netossa a deadpan glare. "Of course I did! I always do. She goes to the Whispering Woods and I lose her scent every time. Those damned woods shift for everyone but demigods."

"Maybe you just need another demigod with you," Spinnerella suggested from where she was grinding up herbs in her pestle.

Catra almost agreed, but Netossa was looking doubtful. "Or maybe you just need to wait for her to tell you. I'm sure she will when she's ready."

Indeed, she did.

A couple of nights after the conversation with Netossa, Adora and Catra found themselves in Micah's study alongside the king. Catra was lounging in one of the comfy armchairs while Micah sat behind his desk and Adora sprawled out on the floor, a picture of sophisticated grace. Her brow was slightly creased and her hands twitched in jerky movements. To anyone else, it probably looked like Adora was possessed, but Catra knew she was just practicing battle moves. Then, one of her fingers curled in an interesting angle and Catra smothered a snort. *Or she's trying to learn the lute again.*

Adora heard the snort—she was always so in tune to Catra and the way that she was feeling—and glared playfully at her friend. Her heart thudded in her chest at the mischief she saw there. A foot pressed against her knee, a playful warning that if she continued to laugh, a wrestling match was in her near future. Catra tried to hide her giddy grin.

"Are you listening, Adora?" Micah asked, a stern look on his face. Catra's ears fanned to the side in unease. Even though she was mostly used to how things happened in Bright Moon now, disappointing adults was still one of the things she dreaded.

Adora flashed Catra a reassuring smile before her pale eyes turned to her father. “Yes, father, I’m listening,” she said with easy confidence. “You were explaining that the kingdom has harvested enough grain this year for a larger tax return.”

The king chuckled and sighed. “Yes, but it’s important to give your full attention to whoever is speaking. It shows that you truly care about what they have to say.”

Adora let out a breezy sigh and rolled languidly into an upright seated position. “Yes, father. You have my full attention,” she said smoothly. Catra almost chuckled. She was mimicking the way Micah sometimes spoke to them at dinner, when he was clearly preoccupied with ruling the kingdom and they had just said something silly. She was keenly aware of Adora’s pressed foot against Catra’s leg.

“Good. I wish to tell you of a dream I had recently.” Both girls stilled. Dreams were signs gifted to them by the gods. When they occurred, it was important to listen.

“In this dream, there were two ducks trying to cross a river. One was perfectly healthy, but the other was wounded. The wounded one asked it’s healthy brother to help it across the river, and the healthy one agreed. He was a prince, and it was in his nature to help those who cannot help themselves. But halfway across the river, the wounded duck panicked and tried to fly away. The prince duck took the injured one on his back and continued on his way across the river. By the time they reached the other shore, the sickly duck was riding the corpse of his brother.” The king paused and turned to the young girls in front of him. “What do you think it means?”

Catra loved the way he taught them. He'd always do this, sit them down and tell them a story, then ask them that question. It was always open-ended, there was never a right or wrong way to answer, and he always phrased it the same. What do *you* think? It made Catra feel very grown up. But now her heart dropped.

"That's easy," Adora answered smoothly. "That even after death, the prince still looks after his people."

"Catra, what do you think it means?"

She echoed Adora's thoughts half-heartedly. Her thoughts were racing and her heart was in her feet. Adora's death. It was a sign of Adora's death. She'd die helping a wounded friend, someone as close as siblings, but one who was not royalty. Adora was going to die trying to save Catra. And she couldn't let that happen.

Before she could dwell too much on her thoughts, the foot against her leg that she had forgotten about swiftly wrapped around her limb and yanked her off-guard. She squeaked in the most undignified manner as Adora pounced on her from the floor and pulled her down beside her, laughing.

Catra laughed along with her, and punched her arm as it snaked around her to hold her still. Micah watched their antics in amusement.

"I can see this lesson is over. Come now, Adora, don't torment our poor Scops! Off to bed with the both of you."

They both said goodnight to Micah, then raced out into the halls, slamming each other into walls and trying to trip the other the whole way back. It was only when they reached their chambers that Catra realized Adora was laughing and truly smiling for the first time since she'd found out she was adopted.

As she flopped down onto her bed, breathless and flushed, Catra pounced on her with a grin. "You're awfully cheerful today," she noted, positioning herself so Adora's head rested on her stomach. She kneaded her fingers through her friend's soft locks.

"I just had a good day today," Adora replied. She reached around Catra and took her tail gently, playing with it mindlessly. Catra didn't mind. This tradition of theirs started the first year of their companionship; Catra would knead Adora's hair for comfort, and Adora would twist her tail around her fingers for comfort. It made the young magicat feel protective of Adora. It was their thing, only theirs, and no one could take that from them. The thought made her purr softly.

"Oh yeah? Does this have anything to do with where you've been going these last few days?"

Adora's hands stilled. *Oh, I've got you,* Catra thought. "Maybe," the young heir to Bright Moon replied thoughtfully. "How did you know?"

"I tried to follow you." She had no remorse in her voice, and Adora barely batted an eye. She knew Catra was naturally curious. *Nosy*, Shadow Weaver would've called it. Thoughts of her old guardian prompted Catra to continue, "Kind of my job as your therapon, dummy."

The blonde chuckled and pushed her friend's leg playfully. They both fell silent as Catra waited for Adora to tell her what she would. It took a little while, but Catra had found that silence got answers faster than asking. It worked the other way too, that was part of the reason why the two girls got along so well. They understood each other. So, instead, she played with Adora's hair and wondered in her mind, *Where have you been going where no one can follow you?*

After a couple minutes, Adora sighed and rolled over into Catra's body. She wrapped her arms around her torso and buried her face in her shoulder. "I've been going to see She-Ra," she admitted in a mumble. Catra's hands stilled for a moment before she continued with the braid she was making.

"And how is she?" She asked evenly. She was not a fan of the goddess, especially not since she dropped an earth shattering revelation on her daughter and then left. She didn't want to see her friend get filled with false hope about a caring mother only for her to be let down when She-Ra inevitably left her.

"She's… a lot like me, actually." She moved a bit and met Catra's eyes briefly before looking away and continuing in a rush. "I haven't forgotten about the prophecy. I know there's a choice I

have to make. But maybe… that choice doesn't have to be made right now. Maybe I can have a chance to get to know my mother." Catra looked away. Adora's hopeful nature stung her heart like a slap. A warm hand cupped her cheek and drew her gaze back to her friend. Adora smiled lightly. "Just because there's a prophecy doesn't mean I can't be happy."

Catra stilled once more, more so Adora wouldn't feel the minute shaking of her body, or somehow sense the rapid hammering of her heart. The blonde dislodged herself from her embrace.

"What does this mean?" Catra asked breathlessly, resisting the urge to fan forward her ears and eavesdrop on Adora's heart.

"Well, it means that you need to pack up some things because we are going to Light Hope's Crystal Tower tomorrow."

"Adora…" her breath was taken away by pale winter eyes gazing patiently at her. Catra shook herself to get control of her wildly changing emotions. "Just… don't let yourself change. I like you the way you are."

The blonde frowned in confusion, but nodded. "Well, nothing can change me. I'll always just be me."

Catra leaned forward and hid her face against Adora's chest. It was her turn to hide. Adora let out a small laugh at her antics, but held her tightly. *I hope you're right*, Catra's thoughts whispered to

her friend. *I hope whatever it is that causes your death doesn't change you.*

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Catra couldn't sleep. Adora's thrashing was keeping her from getting comfortable, and Micah's dream's meaning looped through her head over and over. No longer able to just lay in the bed with Adora and watch as Angella and Artemis drove the moon through the sky, the magicat crept from the room silently.

She didn't know where to go. Her chest was tight and cramped, like her lungs were pinched. Air was hard to come by, and little dots of light were colouring her vision. She could no longer disguise her shaking, even her ears were trembling. She didn't know what was overcoming her. Normally, when she got this feeling, she would run and find Scorpia and hide with her friend, or distract herself with Adora's antics with Bow and Glimmer until the shaking in her hands had stopped. But with Scorpia being in the Scorpion Hills and everyone else sleeping, Catra let her feet guide her where they would.

"Catra?" A low voice called her name. In a sort of haze, she whipped her head around to see Micah sticking his head out of his study, which was still lit with the warm glow of the braziers. She had made her way all the way back to where they'd started what felt like hours ago. "What're you doing out of bed at this hour? It's late."

"I…" she trailed off into small pants as she realized she had no words to describe the feeling in her chest. Her vision became blurry and her tail lashed of its own accord.

"Hey now," Micah's voice was a lot softer, and much closer than before. He was now kneeling in front of her, wiping away the tears she didn't know were falling. "Let's go into my study to speak. You can tell me what's bothering you."

As soon as they were in the office and the door was shut, the words slipped out of her mouth before she could even realize what she was saying. "Adora's going to die!" She wailed, before breaking down into tears. They were the hardest tears she had ever cried. Shoulder-wracking, back bending sobs that doubled her over and made her curl her claws into the stone floor.

She'd known Adora was going to die for almost a week, and she had managed to keep herself contained. She focused on her friend, so bright and full of life, so much so that the promise of her death didn't loom quite as large. But Micah's dream was a wake up call that slapped her in the face harder than any blow Lonnie could land on her.

A strong, calloused hand rubbed comforting circles between her shoulder blades. "I know," Micah murmured. "I know. It's hard to take in. Believe me, I know. No one wants to lose their child. No one wants to lose their friend. But we haven't lost her yet, Catra. She still has a choice to make. The gods put her fate in her hands. And she still has *us*. We can keep her safe. Don't you think?"

“B-but you’re dream—”

“Ah,” Micah sighed and sat back on his heels. Now that the worst of her fear had been driven from her, Catra took in the king’s appearance. This late in the night, his hair was down. With his hair hanging around his face, looking messy and ragged as though he could not stop running his hands through it, the silver streaking that had begun recently was more prominent. Instead of the powerful king that Catra had grown to respect and was in awe of, this man was simply a father, old and tired. The shadows made his face appear more haggard. He ran a thoughtful hand through his beard, a gesture he did to give him time to think and process before he spoke. “You took my dream as a sign of Adora’s death, yes?”

The young magicat nodded, trying to compose herself in front of her king. “She’s going to die helping someone she thinks of as a sibling.”

There was a brief flicker of something in his eyes, but by the time Catra had finished her sentence, his face was unreadable again. Was he thinking of Glimmer? Or Catra? “Well, that’s one possible interpretation. Adora saw in her’s that it was a reminder of a Royal’s duty to their kingdom. But I can see it in a totally different way.”

“But… you never told us your interpretation.”

“That’s because you both need to hear something different from that story. The gods use dreams as a way of sending signs. One’s

interpretation of that dream is the message they're meant. I didn't want to influence you with what I saw from my dream. What I took from it was that Adora is always someone who gives herself wholly to her people. And one day that may be her demise." Micah fixed Catra with a steady look from obsidian-dark eyes. "Unless she had a friend with her."

The king stood back up and walked around his table in his study, the firelight from the braziers casting long dark shadows in the room around him. He held his hands behind his back and straightened his shoulders, once again in lesson mode. "If that duck had a friend in my dream, he wouldn't have drowned. What I believe my dream was showing me was that this test, this war that is coming that Adora will fight in, is not something she can do alone. She will need us. All of us—you especially, young Catra—to help her face this challenge. Without her family and friends, Adora will lose herself."

"We can't let that happen," Catra growled, her tail lashing and her ears flattening in defiance. "*I* won't let that happen. I swore an oath to protect her, and until my last breath, I will make sure that she doesn't lose herself."

Micah studied the young woman thoughtfully. "You have grown much since you came here, Catra. Both physically and emotionally. You are no longer the scrawny, aggressive kitten we took in from the Fright Zone. Adora made the right choice in her therapon." He dipped his head towards her, and Catra felt her skin heating up. Micah was rare to hand out compliments to those besides his wife and his daughters, and he did not say them lightly.

“Th-thank you, your majesty,” she stammered, dipping her head in return. As a force of habit from the Fright Zone days, she lifted one ear slightly, triggering the sensitive nerve at the base of her ear to pick up more sounds. She pinpointed Micah’s heartbeat and listened for a couple beats to see if he was lying. His heart was steady and calm. He was telling the truth. A small purr rumbled through her, unbidden, at the amount of trust the king of Bright Moon was putting in her. She cut off the extra sounds and met his eyes. “I won’t let you down.”

“You never could.” He smiled and then flicked his wrist. “Why don’t you head back to bed? I’m sure Adora will have tossed herself out of it by now, and if she’s awake she will be wondering where you are.”

Catra took his dismissal with another bow to the king. She made her way back to her chambers, feeling lighter than she did, and more determined than ever to keep Adora safe. She was a magicat from the Fright Zone. She was Catra. She could do this.

Chapter End Notes

What do YOU think the dream means? Put your interpretation down below!

I will not promise when the next chapter comes out. I started it last night, so as soon as it is done, I will post it! For now, enjoy this long awaited chapter!

Hope you’re still reading this story, I promise I will finish it!

Chapter 11: It's not a Fantasy Story Without Giant Spiders

Chapter Summary

Gay panic and giant spiders. CW for gore and giant spiders

Chapter Notes

What's this? Another update relatively soon after the last one? It's a miracle! Content warning for gore and giant spiders!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra awoke the next day to the sensation of being watched. She slowly slit one eye open, but relaxed when she realized it was Adora, sitting across the room on the lounge couch, studying her with a smile on her face.

"Did you know you talk in your sleep?" Adora asked.

The brunette sat up, yawned and shook her shaggy mane out of her face. "Yeah, and? Did you know you fight in your sleep?" She stretched languidly, collapsing amongst all of Adora's pillows. Her tail thumped playfully against the mattress. "Why are you up so early anyways? You normally don't climb out of bed until noon."

"We're going to find Light Hope today, remember?"

Catra blinked, all the sleep vanishing from her body in seconds. She didn't forget, but she didn't realize they were going to leave so early. Indeed, behind Adora, Catra could see Razz the elderly nursemaid packing Adora and Catra's things into packs they could put on their horses.

"Can I say goodbye to my friends first?" She asked in a low voice, eyes averted. She didn't want to leave Netossa and Spinnerella without saying goodbye, but she also didn't want to appear weak. She didn't need to worry about that with Adora. When she turned back, the royal's beautiful limpid eyes were soft with understanding.

"Of course! I wanted to stop at the Barracks to say goodbye to Lonnie, Rogelio and Kyle. Apparently there's a new move Lonnie's been teaching Kyle, and I want to see how he's shaping up!"

Catra snorted and grinned lazily at Adora. "You sound like your father. Already a battle strategist, checking on your troops."

Her words had the opposite effect on Adora. Instead of her laughing along, Adora's expression became guarded and she flinched a little. "They're my friends," she protested weakly. She grabbed her arm in an uncharacteristic display of vulnerability that had the smile dying instantly from Catra's face. She got up and sat on the lounge beside Adora, jostling her with her shoulder lightly.

"Hey, you know I meant nothing by it, right?"

The blonde looked away. Catra sat there in silence, just leaning her shoulder against her friend's as a show of solidarity. And as a way for her to secretly admire the muscles beginning to swell in her friend's biceps and shoulders. After a moment, the princess spoke again, facing Catra. "It's just that… She-Ra won't tell me who my father is."

With that, Catra pushed her head under Adora's and let out a small purr. The sudden movement forced the blonde to wrap her arms around Catra so she wouldn't topple over. "Who cares what She-Ra says? As far as you should be concerned, Micah is your father. What's wrong with that? He's noble, caring and kind. *And* a good diplomat and warrior, if his scars have anything to say for it. He's done more for you than your blood-father ever has."

Adora let out a watery laugh and rubbed her knuckles against Catra's head, between her ears, until she squealed and kicked the blonde soundly in the stomach, laughing. "You're starting to sound like he's *your* father!" She teased.

Catra's face heated up and she hissed half-heartedly. "He's a good leader is all."

"Uh-huh, *right*. So is Juliet but you don't moon over her!" Catra pounced on her with a battle cry, and the two rolled around the room play-fighting and laughing all the while. As per usual, Adora won, but this time as she pinned Catra on the ground, something was different.

Warmth stirred in Catra, the same warmth she had felt the night before as Adora entwined her foot around Catra's leg. As she stared up at Adora, lost for words, she could've sworn there was more to the blonde's flushed face, more to the fire in her eyes, than just the excitement of battle. She was acutely and painfully aware of Adora's body over hers. She knew that if the blonde shifted backwards just a fraction, then she would be sitting right on Catra's pelvis. She shifted her hips a bit as she watched the girl above her, and sure enough, she let out a small gasp as Catra's body moved up and pressed into Adora unexpectedly. If her hands hadn't been pinned above her head by an iron grip deceived by soft hands, Catra would've surged up and pressed every inch of her body against Adora's, just to see what the blonde would do.

As she watched, Adora's eyes drifted from Catra's, down to her lips where they stayed. Catra found her own eyes slipping to Adora's lips. She wondered what she tasted like, what her lips would feel like pressed against her own. Before she could sate her natural curiosity, a straw broom smacked Adora in the face. Razz stood over them, her eyes alight in exasperated amusement.

"Oi, you girls! Always fighting and rolling around on the ground like a pair of young boys! So unbecoming for ladies of your status! Up you get, the pair of you! Isn't there somewhere you're going today?"

The spell of the moment broken, Catra quickly looked away, her face hot. "Well, I would get up, but this dummy weighs more than she looks!"

Adora giggled and stood, reaching down and helping Catra stand. "Of course. Come on, Catra! We better get a move on. I'll meet

you out by the olive tree by the river at noon!”

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“… And then I came straight here,” Catra finished with her story. She was yet again perched on all fours on the fence that marked the boundary of Netossa and Spinnerella’s gardens. Both women were watching Catra from where they knelt in the dirt, pulling up carrots and other root-plants. “I don’t know what’s wrong with me. It’s like… my skin doesn’t fit. I’m all hot and itchy and I can’t stop thinking about her! What does it mean?”

Both women shared a knowing glance before Spinnerella leaned forward and said, “Have you ever been in love before, Catra?”

“Love? Ew, no.” She wrinkled her nose in distaste. “Love is for grownups. And it’s disgusting. People smell funny, and they go doe-eyed around one another and lose all common sense. No offence,” she added hastily, knowing the two women she was talking to were truly, madly deeply in love with one another.

“None taken,” Netossa chuckled. “But you definitely seem to be in love.”

Catra’s ears flattened and she let out a hiss of disgust. “What am I supposed to do, tell Adora? She’s the heir of Bright Moon!”

“And you’re her therapon!”

“So?”

“So, it’s happened before! No one would think any less of you or her if you did tell her how you feel.”

“But, she’ll have to marry some rich prince and have his babies.” Catra made a disgusted face and Spinnerella laughed gently.

“You think two women can’t have children? Did you see where your friend Scorpia came from? Two mothers.”

“But—”

“And what about Iphis and Ianthe? Or any of Apollo or Dionysus’ lovers? Do you think none of them ever had children?”

That stunned Catra into silence. She had no further excuse. Iphis and Ianthe were famous in their lands. Their story was one of the rare ones that showed the benevolence of their gods. Iphis was born a man and fell in love with a woman named Ianthe. The two were engaged to be married, but though they loved each other, Iphis did not feel comfortable in his own skin. He asked the gods for a gift, and they granted her the body of a woman, so she could love herself as much as she loved her wife. There was a whole kingdom descended from the two women, even.

“Now that you’re done being a gay disaster,” Netossa used the walking stick she was leaning on to throw some dirt from the garden at Catra. “How about a spar?”

They sparred for a good couple of hours while Spinnerella called out encouragement, or offered various healing herbs as remedies for the bruises that would surely be forming. Eventually, the telltale sound of Glimmer teleporting in had Catra dodging Netossa’s last strike and calling it quits. She had ended up with the walking stick herself, and her friend nodding approvingly. “Your form has really improved, Catra. You’d never know you once struggled with a spear. Well done!”

“Thank you,” she purred as Glimmer fully appeared and marched over to Catra.

“Aren’t you done packing yet? We are leaving in an hour!” The younger girl scowled fiercely at Catra, which had her rolling her eyes.

“Alright, alright, keep your clothes on,” she mumbled. She bid goodbye to Spinnerella and Netossa, who urged Catra to *make a move already!*, and made her way to the olive tree where she said she was going to meet Adora. She hopped up into the branches of the low, gnarled tree, basking in the late autumn sun with her eyes half-shut as she waited for her friend. The small leaves of the tree, dusty and faded after the long, warm summer, were still fragrant, and offered a small respite from the hundreds of scents that clogged her nose on a daily basis. She was so busy enjoying

a moment to herself, that she didn't sense Adora's presence until the blonde started talking.

"Did you know," she said, making Catra nearly leap out of her skin. "That there are no happy heroes?"

"Gods above, Adora, you nearly made me jump on you with my claws out! What are you on about now?"

"Think about it. Name one hero who was happy." There was a fire in Adora's eyes, a sharp kind of light that she hadn't seen on her friend's face before. Catra frowned and Adora continued, "You can't."

"I can't," she said slowly, after a pause. Heracles went mad and killed his family; Theseus lost his bride and father; Jason's children and new wife were murdered by his old; Bellerophon killed the Chimera but was crippled by the fall from Pegasus' back.

"I know. They never let you be famous *and* happy. But I'll tell you a secret." Catra leapt out of the tree at that and took her friend's arm. The fire in Adora's eyes was infectious, and soon Catra wore a toothy grin that matched Adora's.

"Tell me."

“I’m going to be the first.” For a moment, Catra’s enthusiasm sputtered, but Adora looked so happy, that she continued to smile. Adora grabbed her hand suddenly, soft, slender fingers interlacing with calloused ones. “You have to swear it to me.”

Catra shook her head, out of the daze that holding Adora’s hand left her in. Her ears flattened slightly in suspicion. “Why me?”

“Because you’re the reason.” The blonde’s eyes were soft, the fire dimming to a warm glow instead of a dangerous inferno. “Swear it.”

“I swear it.” Catra choked out, around the purr in her throat. She was the reason for Adora’s happiness? *Her?* Was it possible that Adora felt the same as she did? Her eyes locked on the heir’s beautiful smiling lips, and she gave in to her curiosity. She cupped Adora’s neck with her hand and pulled her close. The other girl did not protest or resist as Catra pressed her forehead to her friend’s, and then slotted her lips against Adora’s.

She tasted the way she smelled; frost and iron, flames and starlight, with a hint of tart sweetness from the late autumn berries that were still growing on the riverbed that she must’ve snacked on earlier. Her lips were soft and smooth and warm, everything Catra had dreamt they’d be. And to her immense surprise, *Adora kissed her back!* She smiled and pulled the blonde even closer, relishing in the moment to explore this part of her that no one ever had before. She wrapped her other arm around Adora’s shoulders and deepened the kiss.

She wasn’t sure what happened next. One moment she was lost in her bliss, and the next Adora was pulling away from her. Catra blinked open her eyes to see the look of pure horror on her friend’s face.

“Adora?” She said softly. The blonde didn’t answer. She took a couple steps back, her face white, her eyes glassy and stunned. Catra’s heart dropped. She stepped towards her friend and could only stare as she took off. The last she saw of Adora was her friend disappearing at a sprint towards the castle. She dropped to her knees.

***

In a land of gods and monsters, doing something against the gods’ will was daring, taboo even. And there were consequences. Catra waited, staring with trembling ears and tail up at the sun as it made it’s way across the sky. She waited for Zeus’ thunderbolt to strike her where she stood. A mere mortal like herself was no worthy of the blood of the gods. She was a fool to think Adora could be hers. But nothing be-felled her. No screaming goddesses or raging winds, no thunder or fire or ice. How odd.

“Are you okay, Catra?” Bow’s voice nearly made her jump out of her skin. She accidentally squeezed her horse with her clawed toes, and the sorrel coloured mare whinnied in discomfort and danced a couple of steps before Catra could rein her back in.

“I’m fine,” she snapped icily, glaring at the boy. The four of them were deep in the Whispering Woods, riding on horseback at a

steady pace further in. Already, Catra was turned around. She had no idea where she was anymore, any familiar landmarks from her brief ventures in with Scorpia were long behind her by now. Her only guiding lights were the demigod sisters who were riding several paces ahead of them. Catra's heart smarted. Since kissing Adora a couple of hours ago, the blonde hadn't said a word to her, dancing around her and avoiding her at all costs. Eventually, Catra stopped trying.

"Are you sure? Cuz it seems to me like you and Adora are avoiding each other."

"We are not!" Catra protested, her tail fluffing up in indignation. She glared at him before turning away to hide the blush on her cheeks. "Just… having a bad day is all. I told Adora to leave me alone."

"Y'know, you're a terrible liar." She whipped back to face him, a hiss already in her throat, but Bow pressed on. "Your ear twitches when you lie. It's subtle but it's a clear tell. You can tell me what happened, if you want. Or you don't have to. It's up to you."

Catra gazed at him suspiciously. Was this all a ruse? Was he going to make fun of her or tell Adora what she said? Eventually, she let out a sigh. "Okay, fine. I kissed her. Happy?"

"Whoa. You *kissed* her? Did she kiss you back?"

“Yes. But then, something happened and she pulled away.” She frowned as she remembered the horror etched on her friend’s face.

Bow hummed thoughtfully. “Well, it is Adora we are talking about. You know how she gets. So ready to give everything for everyone else, but totally unsure how to handle things given to her at all. Just give her a little time, I’m sure she will come around!” He pulled away from her and trotted his horse further up to talk to Glimmer and Adora. Catra hung back.

Something had shifted in the air. The birds and creatures flitting around them had gone quiet. It was the absence of noise that Catra’s sensitive ears picked up. She swivelled her ears around and closed her eyes to get an audible map of their surroundings. Ahead of her, passed the sounds of the sisters and Bow laughing and chatting, oblivious to the tension in the natural world around them—typical of humans—Catra could hear birdsong. There was nothing ahead of them. To the sides, she could hear the sounds of their horses hooves echoing off rock; they had entered a ravine though they could not see the walls of it through the thick brush. A perfect place for an ambush. And behind them, the sound of heavy footfalls, walking as close to step with the horses as possible. Catra almost didn’t catch onto the tail they had picked up, wouldn’t have noticed at all if one of the creatures hadn’t stepped on a branch, creating a large snapping sound.

Her eyes flew open and she glanced behind her. There was nothing there. She stopped her horse and fully turned to face the way they came, drawing her spear from it’s holder on the side of the saddle. As soon as she stopped, their followers stopped as well. This creature was intelligent, and hunting them. All the fur stood up on the back of Catra’s neck. She scanned the

surrounding brush with critical eyes, but she wasn't seeing anything.

"You okay, back there?" Bow called, having noticed that she had stopped moving.

"Yeah, what's the hold up?" Glimmer yelled back loudly. Catra hissed. She backed her horse up to the rest, not taking her eyes off the trail behind them.

"We are being followed," she murmured lowly, holding her spear tight in one hand. "And we are in the perfect place for an ambush. Weapons out, we might have to fight."

Bow was already stringing his bow before she had even finished her sentence. Adora and Glimmer were slower to draw their weapons, but eventually they both did. "Now what?" Glimmer asked, dropping her voice to a low whisper.

"You three continue on straight. Bow, see if you can find a way to the top of the ravine. Find a clear patch and try to get a good angle to shoot whatever is following us. Princesses, you keep going to Light Hope."

Both demigods began to protest, but Catra silenced them with a look. "We don't know what we are up against. At the end of the day, you are both more important than Bow or I. Get to the Crystal Tower, and bring back help. We will hold them off."

“Catra, no—” Adora began to protest. Catra looked over at her and found her blue eyes warm and soft.

“Don’t worry about me, Princess,” she averted her eyes, trying not to wince as Adora put a warm hand on her arm.

“You matter, too.” She bit back a purr at hearing those words.

“I know. So hurry back with help!” She pushed her friend away, not looking back at her as she heard the sisters take off. Bow was still by her side.

“Don’t be a hero,” he murmured to her. “I’ll be right up on the cliff. If you can’t take them, fall back to me and we will face them together.”

She nodded and heard rustling in the undergrowth. “You better go, Arrow Boy. Looks like we just lost the element of surprise.”

He took off without another word, leaving Catra alone in the centre of the ravine. She experimentally flipped around her spear, using her ears to clock how many enemies she faced. There were more than one, and she was fairly certain they weren’t human. She took in the air around her through her nose, trying to find the hostile scent, but with a muffled curse, she realized that she was upwind. She couldn’t smell them, though they could smell her.

She opened her mouth to better catch the air, and for a moment, caught the scent of something hot and furry.

"Show yourselves, you cowards!" She yelled into the woods. Her horse nickered in fright, and she patted the mare's neck to soothe her. *We need to be brave here,* she mentally channeled to the horse. *We can't show fear.*

She heard branches rustling on the ridge above her, and she hoped beyond hope that it was Bow getting into position. She didn't have long to wait to find out. A gleaming arrow was loosed from the ridge, and after a heartbeat, there was an inhuman shriek. Suddenly, out of the bushes, barrelled three creatures that Catra wished she would never see again.

Three massive, hairy spiders were charging her, all black and brown writhing balls of fury speeding towards her faster than any horse. Each were around the size of her horse, though one was larger. Arachnids, the children of Arachne.

"Come on then!" She bellowed. Brandishing her spear high, she charged the three, slashing at the biggest as she sped her horse past it. She flew by the second beast, which tried to turn and stumbled, tripping the wounded one with it's flailing legs. She aimed for the slowest Arachnid, the one that had Bow's arrow sticking out of one of it's many beady eyes, and she plunged her spear in deep. The massive beast clacked it's pincers once, and then fell still, spouting black blood from where her spear was lodged in it's head.

As she tried to yank it out, she realized she had stabbed too deeply. Her arm lit with liquid fire as her horse continued on but the deeply embedded spear pulled Catra in the opposite direction. She was forcibly ejected from her saddle with a screech as she held onto the shaft through the pain lancing up her arm. Thanking the gods for her feline balance, she managed to stay upright after the fall, which was the only thing that saved her from breaking her shoulder or becoming an Arachnid's next meal.

As she pivoted on her heel, never letting go of her spear, she watched in horror as the second Arachnid crawled its way over the body of it's friend. She finally ripped free the spear and jabbed at the creature, but she was too late. It swatted at the weapon, ripping it from Catra's hands with ease and sending it flying into the woods behind her. She reached for her sword, but her horse was long gone with the blade still sheathed and secured on her saddle. She cursed and faced the monster confidently, unsheathing her claws. Time to return to the basics, then.

She managed to duck and roll, favouring her hurt arm as she danced around the beast. She kept the third in her periphery, although that creature was more concerned about finding Bow, who was launching arrow after arrow into it's thorax. The Arachnid in front of her was irritated, but for the most part still intact. An arrow protruded from one of its legs, but it was clearly not being slowed down. It snapped it's mandibles at her, unnervingly close to her head, but she had so far managed to avoid it.

Ducking under it's legs, she used her tough and resilient claws to gouge deep grooves in the tough hide of its belly. The beast let out a mad shriek, but Catra had found it's blind spot. None of it's eight legs, nor it's clacking jaws could reach her where she was.

But she was not out of harms way just yet. As she slashed and kicked and bit at anything she could reach, she was caught suddenly by a rope that had entangled her feet.

Catra stumbled and fell as she discovered her legs were bound together. She hissed and rolled onto her stomach as the creature tried to smother her beneath it. The weight of it was crushing her ribs, but she managed a moan and reached behind her with her good arm. She scratched another gash into it's body, hot black blood coating her head and dripping into her eyes and mouth. The spider screamed and slammed down on her again, momentarily stunning her. Then, it's weight was lifted off her, and she tried to scrabble out from under the creature. There was a pinprick of pain as something sharp stabbed her between the shoulders.

She screamed and scrambled out from under the spider, but soon found her strength failing her. She couldn't get up, could barely move. Her body was a war zone. Hot and cold pulsed over her in waves, and her arms began to feel leaden. She pulled herself a few feet away from the creature, who was staggering around in pain. She felt a small smile tugging on her face as she observed the damage she did. A pool of blood was forming under it, and she could clearly see how much she hurt the being. She was mildly surprised it was still standing.

She could hear Bow calling her name, but she couldn't answer him, couldn't even lift her head. Fear coursed through her as she realized her whole body was frozen. She couldn't even lift her finger, or twitch an ear. Her eyes fixed on the spider as it started making its way over to her.

Oh gods, she thought balefully, unable to track the Arachnid's movements as it circled behind her. *This is how I die.* One of the eight furry, bloody legs appeared in Catra's limited field of view. It was right in front of her. It turned her over easily, nothing in her body responding to her valiant efforts to fight it. She was staring up at it's ugly face now. *This will be the last thing I see.* She couldn't even close her eyes to it. They were stuck open. She would watch as she was devoured, alive but in a prison of her own body.

Instead, she watched as an arrow, one not shot by Bow, went cleanly through the Arachnid's head. There was a dull *twang* as the arrow hit a tree so hard that it lodged itself firmly in the bark. The beast teetered over Catra for a moment, and then collapsed on top of her.

"*Catra!*" Adora cried from nearby. The sound of hoof beats sounded, getting closer and closer with every stride. There was two thumps as the riders dismounted. The beast's body shuddered as it was rolled off, and the magicat was staring at the sky, ringed by the concerned faced of Adora and Glimmer. A horse paced nearby, just out of her field of view. "What happened? Where's Bow?"

Catra could do nothing but stare at Adora's beautiful face as it ranged in and out of focus as she was examined. She couldn't even move her eyes to track her friend. She could see the concern growing when those blue eyes were close to hers, and a dreadful fear behind that. "Oh gods, is she even alive? Catra!"

The horse's hooves plodded forward, and there was the sound of something settling behind her. Larger hands than Adora's picked

up her shoulders and rolled her forward into the demigod's warmth as whoever was behind her examined her back. Catra relished it, even if she couldn't do anything to acknowledge it.

"She's been stung by the Arachnid," came a strange, androgynous voice behind her. "She is alive, but just barely. The toxins in the sting of an Arachnid could even paralyze a god. We need to get her back to the Crystal Tower immediately. When the paralyzing agent reaches her heart, it will stop."

"Bow, there you are!" The relief in Glimmer's voice from further away was evident to Catra. "What happened?"

"Catra fought them!" Bow panted, sounding like he had run all the way from the cliff. Where was his horse? "She was so brave. They came out of no where, and I was shooting them with my arrows, but it barely slowed them down. She killed one with her spear…"

His voice faded with the sound of two sets of footsteps disappearing as he must've been walking with Glimmer to tell her the story.

"You can heal her?" Adora's voice was worried, and her hands fidgeted at Catra's back.

"Yes," the stranger replied. "But we have to hurry. We don't have much time. Get on my back."

What? Catra was baffled, but unable to voice her protests. She was picked up as though she weighed next to nothing, and turned so she could face her rescuer.

If she could, she would've cried out in shock. The being who was carrying her was tall, with a willowy build. That was the most normal thing about her. Her skin was greyish. She wore a sleeveless leather vest with a hood on that covered most but not all of her shorn, white hair. Her eyes were piercing blue and emotionless. And her torso merged perfectly with the body of a giant, black horse. There must've been some kind of fear on Catra's face, because the centuar's stone face seemed to melt.

"Rest now," she said softly. Her hand glowed with magic as she used it to close Catra's eyes. Immediately sleep over took her and she thankfully slipped into unconsciousness.

Chapter End Notes

I literally just finished this chapter but I was too excited to wait to post it! So give me a little bit, and I'll have another chapter as soon as it's ready! Like, comment and share this story! I'm having a blast writing it!

What Adora says to Catra by the olive tree is almost a direct quote from The Song of Achilles.

Also we Stan trans Mtf Iphis in this house! In the original story, Iphis is born a girl and is changed into a man, but I was torn between having Iphis be trans or be a lesbian, so I did both!

See you next time! Let me know your thoughts below!

Chapter 12: I Can’t Feel My Legs When I’m With You (But I Love It)

Chapter Summary

Catra’s weak in the knees for Adora

CW for slight gore as well as brief mention of cleaning/gutting a carcass

Chapter Notes

I am. On a roll! CREATIVITY DON’T FAIL ME NOW!

Content warning for slight gore and mentions of cleaning/gutting a carcass

See the end of the chapter for more notes

When Catra opened her eyes next, she could not make sense of where she was or what she was seeing. Streaks of light danced across a ceiling of blue, violet and rose fractals. She blinked, trying to make those streaks of light add up to… *something* in her head, but she couldn’t.

“Am I dead?” She asked out loud. She was blinking, and moving her eyes and talking, which were all more than she could do the last time she had her eyes open. She held up her hands with minor degrees of difficulty, and examined them.

“Catra?” A familiar voice whispered at her side. She turned her head and found Adora peering at her. They were in a smooth-walled cavern, with Catra lying on a bed made of cypress and pine boughs and warm furs. Adora was curled up beside her, holding her around the waist, and beyond her, the smooth floor—which

was bare save for their packs that had been on their horses the last time Catra saw them—sloped upwards towards a gap in the wall with what smelled like another cavern beyond it. Light flickered on the walls around them, and Catra smelled woodsmoke. She realized she could see just fine even without that flickering fire in the other space. They must not have been too deep in the cave, as she could see the fading rays of daylight as well.

"I'm definitely dead," she whispered. She had never seen anything like this cave—it looked like they were inside of a crystal! And there was no way that *Adora* was wrapped tightly around her, not after her rejection that morning. Even without that detail, Catra was always the one initiating physical contact.

"You're not, though you tried your best," the blonde replied, a severe, ashen look on her face. She wrapped herself tighter around Catra, and her voice wavered a bit. "Light Hope says you're lucky you're alive. She said that Arachnid venom isn't something to be messed around with."

"Yeah, I can feel that." Now that Catra realized she wasn't dead, the pain was returning. Her arm was purple and mottled yellow with bruising from having nearly dislocated it falling off her horse. There was a piercing pain between her should blades, and when she reached back to touch it, the site was huge to her fingers, almost as large as her hand, but underneath her claws there was no sensation. Just like with her legs. Panic flared in her, and she struggled to gulp it down. "Hey Adora? I can't feel my legs."

"It's alright," she soothed, resting a hand on Catra's cheek. She met Catra's mismatched gaze steadily. "She explained that it takes

some time for the effects of the venom to disappear. It's only been a couple of hours. Your legs will come back to you, I promise."

She sat with Catra while the worst of the panic and pent-up adrenaline worked it's way out of her body, then smiled and sat back. "I guess for now, I'll have to carry you wherever we go."

"Oh, that won't be necess—!" She squeaked as Adora stood and scooped her up effortlessly. "Adora! Let me *go*! I'll be fine!" Adora laughed, but ignored her. Catra sunk her claws into the front of her tunic, she ears pinned back furiously. "I swear, if Bow or Glimmer tease me for this, I will kill every last one of you, starting with you! Got it?"

"No one is going to make fun of you," Adora soothed, though she was trying not to giggle at how furious Catra was. As though her claws digging into her chest meant nothing. Catra hissed with disgust, although her protests trailed off as they entered the main cave.

They stood in a hollowed out crystal. The roof of the cave was so high that it disappeared into darkness, but the cave did not feel lofty or airy at all. Instead, great stalactites and stalagmites of smaller—but still large—crystals gave the cavity a homey, comfortable feeling. Furs were dappled across the space to hush echoes, and everywhere were signs of inhabitants, though no one else was in the cave.

A fire hissed and crackled merrily in the centre of the room, in a shallow scoop of the translucent floor; there were more sleeping furs bundled into a corner near the entrance, a large mouth that opened into the mountainside; and furniture littered the space in no rhyme or reason. One corner had several bookshelves, one nook a little to Adora's left housed several weapons and shields, and over everything lay the heavy tang of horse.

The blonde carefully put Catra down on a fur beside the fire, and rearranged her legs and tail so that it looked like Catra had sat herself there. She even wrapped Catra's abnormally still tail and her crossed legs.

"Thank you," Catra murmured softly, but when she looked back up at Adora, the smile died from her face. Adora was unnaturally pale, clinging to herself as if trying to hold herself together. Her eyes were wide and glassy and she gulped a few times before she spoke to Catra.

"I thought you were…" she trailed off and tried again. "When we pulled the spider off you. You were just so still. I didn't even see you breathe and I thought you were dead!" Her voice broke on her last word and she let out a small sob. Catra reached out and squeezed her arm.

"I'm not, though. I'm right here, Adora." She ran her hand soothingly down the blonde's arm until Adora's defences came down and she launched herself at Catra, sobbing as she had never seen before.

“I can’t lose you, Catra. It will ruin me. I never want to see you like that, you were so small and still.”

“I’m not going anywhere.” She wrapped her arms more firmly around Adora and pulled her close so that her head rested comfortably in the crook of her shoulder. She was practically laying on top of Catra, but the magicat would have it no other way. “You will never lose me, I swear it on the River Styx.”

They sat there in peaceful silence for a bit, Catra purring gently in Adora’s ear, and the princess clinging to her like a drowning man to a raft. Eventually, Adora lifted her head. There was the dustings of a blush across her cheeks, and she didn’t meet Catra’s eye.

“Before everything happened today, you… kissed me.” It was spoken hesitantly, and had Catra had her legs, she would’ve shoved Adora away and stomped off somewhere to hide. Instead, she pinned back her ears and glared at the floor, her cheeks burning. Seeing her reaction, Adora took her hand. “I’m not going to lie, it caught me a bit off guard but… it’s not something I’ve never thought about.”

Catra’s eyes snapped back onto Adora’s, but now it was the blonde’s turn to go red-faced and shy. “I’ve thought about it quite a bit actually, but I was afraid to let myself feel.” Her words were coming out in a jumbled rush to the point where Catra barely understood. “There’s so much happening right now! What if I am not supposed to feel this way? What if the gods have me matched with someone? What if I have no say? I don’t know what I’m supposed to do, I only just met my mom and—”

Catra put a finger on her lips to stop her rambling before the princess worked herself up into a panic. "Adora. Breathe." She laughed a bit, giving the girl a fanged grin as she moved her finger from her mouth, and instead cupped her cheek in her palm. "I know you're going through a lot. I get it, trust me. You don't have to do anything you're not comfortable with. I'll be here for you when your thoughts are quieter. I won't do anything to confuse you further, not unless you want it."

The heir of Bright Moon let out a sigh, her shoulders slumping. She smiled and leaned into Catra's hand. "Thank you for understanding. I'm sorry I don't have a better answer."

The magicat purred softly. "Don't apologize, dummy. We have all the time in the world."

***

The other members of their group emerged shortly after dark, when the air outside smelled fresh and clean with the evening dew. Catra sat up immediately as she smelled blood, but before she could be alarmed, her friends walked into the cave. Both Bow and Glimmer were smiling wildly despite having blood on their clothes, and between them was the carcass of a small deer.

"Light Hope was teaching us to hunt!" Glimmer announced excitedly as she saw Adora and Catra's questioning looks. "Can you believe it? Us, *royals*, hunting! Bow caught the deer, but I helped gut it! Light Hope says it's important that we all carry our weight around here!"

Jealousy battled with awe in Catra's belly as she watched the two continue to carve up the animal, chatting about what else could go with it and what parts would be good for dinner tonight versus what would be smoked over the next few days. She had never really had the chance to hunt over the last few years, though she did catch the odd mouse or bird just for fun. The fact that Glimmer was learning to hunt, and had caught something before she did, rubbed her the wrong way. Although, with her legs still dead, she wouldn't have been much use.

"Make sure you hang the hide outside," came an oddly familiar voice from outside the cave. The sound of hoofbeats announced the arrival of their host, and to Catra's great surprise, she was face to face with the centaur who had saved her, her blue eyes flashing in the firelight. Nothing in their stories had ever mentioned that Light Hope was a centaur. She continued, "Hang it high enough so that the wolves won't get it, and far enough out from the trunk that the bears won't take it. Tomorrow, we will find some oak and I will teach you how to tan the hide. You'll need it for clothing and bedrolls while you stay here."

Finally, she turned to face Adora and Catra, who were tending the fire. Light Hope passed a critical eye over them. "So, this is Catra. I've heard much about you. I see that the venom is starting the wear off, how is your pain?"

"Bearable," she grunted, rolling her shoulders and trying not to wince as the pincer wound stretched. "Will I be able to walk again soon?"

The centaur plodded in a tight circle around Catra, examining her carefully. The magicat lifted a lip and fanned back her ears uneasily as those great white hooves stepped incredibly close to her still-limp tail. “Well seeing as you are talking, sitting up on your own and moving your arms, I’d say it shouldn’t take too long, perhaps only a day or so.” She turned back to where Bow and Glimmer were attempting to skin the deer. “Long, even strokes of the knife, Bow. You don’t want chunks of meat remaining on that pelt. Adora, why don’t you go help your friends? More hands make light work.”

Adora began to protest, but the teacher of heroes gave her a pointed look which had her closing her mouth and trotting over to join her sister and her friend. Catra glanced up nervously as Light Hope folded her legs and lay down beside her. She picked up the poker stick and began prodding the fire. “Adora tells me you are her therapon.”

“That’s right,” she jutted out her chin in defiance. “So?”

“Are you aware of who you travel with?”

“Two demigods, one of Angella, one of She-Ra. They’re my friends, I’ve known them since I was nine.”

There was an approving grunt. “Good. You know the truth then.” They both watched the other three working away at the deer for a moment in silence, before Light Hope continued. “I trained her mother, eons ago, when She-Ra was still Mara and war had yet to harden her eyes.”

Catra's eyes went round and she stared up at Light Hope's grey face in awe. "You trained the goddess of war?"

"Oh yes, I trained all the gods. Which is why they trust me with their offspring."

"Are you immortal?"

Light Hope didn't answer, but the grief and pain in her eyes spoke of ages and ages spent alone, watching her pupils die in various different ways. She wondered if the gods ever visited the lonely mountain.

"She looks just like her mother, when she was that age." The tone in her voice was wistful, and the woman was staring with eyes full of mournful longing at Adora. For a moment, Catra felt wickedly protective of the girl who meant everything to her, but then she realized what the look in her eyes meant.

"You… loved Mara, didn't you?"

The soft look hardened in an instant, until Light Hope was glaring at Catra with eyes of blue ice. The message was clear, *never speak of that again*, and the mortal ducked her head submissively. The next time she spoke, she was brisk and cool, a teacher once more. "Adora's whole life has been blanketed in prophecy, since

the moment she stirred in her mother's womb. That is why she is here. But the question is, why are you?"

"We are here with Adora."

Light Hope shook her head. "No, I understand that, but my question for you is what do *you* wish to learn from me? You cannot simply stay on this mountain. It was put here by the titans and shrouded in magic. If you have reached me safely it is because there is something I can teach you. So what do you wish to learn?"

Catra thought for a moment. "All my life I was raised by humans. My hybrid parents left me when I was a kitten, and I never learned the ways of my kind. That is what I wish to learn."

Approval gleamed in the otherwise unreadable mask of Light Hope's face. "I will be able to teach you."

Later, as the four friends and the centaur sat around the fire eating the venison that Bow and Glimmer had procured for them, Light Hope began to tell them stories.

"This mountain, Mount Angelion, is as old as the earth itself. It was already teaming with life when I stumbled upon it, in the time before the gods. This is where your parents were married." This was directed at Glimmer and Adora, whose eyes were huge and round. "Angella lived here for several centuries until your father

wooed her and brought her to his kingdom. All around you are creatures and plants that can help you in any situation. I will help teach you how to use the things our Mother Earth gives us to your advantage. There is more than just your typical wildlife here, however. You already experienced the first of many trials you will face in your time here."

"Do you mean the spiders that attacked us in the pass?" Glimmer asked, hugging her knees to her chest.

Light Hope nodded gravely. "Yes. The Arachnids were sent by one of the gods to test your courage and your skill. Suffice to say, you passed, largely unscathed." A sideways glance was shot to Catra, who scowled fiercely. "By now, all the gods will be paying attention to you closely. You will have to face challenges that they throw at you, as well as learn how to survive in the wilds. You are all nobility, for the most part. And what I want to tell you is the same thing I told your father when he trained here. A king is only as strong as his weakest man. He may only rule the kingdom fairly after he has lived a day as one of his poorest subjects. You will know pain, you will know hunger, and you will know suffering. If you do not fend for yourself here, then you will pay the price. You eat what you can catch, and you give thanks to the gods and the creatures who will give their lives for you. You are not in the castle now, children. And when I am through with your lessons, you will be some of the finest heroes Etheria has ever known."

Bow, Glimmer, Catra and Adora all exchanged excited glances, but Light Hope was not done yet. "Bow, your skill with archery is impressive to say the least, however an archer is only talented when they have quarry to track. I will help you hone in on the hidden trails and passage ways of everything that moves through

the forest. In time, there will be none more proficient in tracking than you."

Bow sat up straighter and nodded solemnly, though there was a proud twinkle in his dark eyes. Glimmer squeezed his arm with an excited smile, and even Catra approved of the choice. Out of all of them, Bow was the most attentive to detail, and could move nearly silent if he wanted. He would make a fantastic tracker, and Catra knew that she would be proud to work side-by-side with him.

Now, the trainer of heroes' eye landed on Glimmer. "Young Glimmer of Bright Moon, you have demonstrated your mother's ability to move unseen throughout the world at great speed. But like the moon, your powers come from light. There is more to your gifts than just disappearing and reappearing. In time, if you let me instruct you, I can show you how to make your gift into a weapon to defend your people with."

Glimmer looked at her hands and then a wicked grin spread across her face. Catra did not like the chaos she saw on the girl's features. Light Hope saw it too, and a small frown appeared on her stoic face. *She clearly doesn't know what she just signed up for.*

"Adora of Bright Moon, your parents asked me to train you specifically. They seem to think that you have it in you to be even mightier than Heracles. But tell me, is that what you want for yourself?"

Adora frowned seriously as she pondered the question posed to her. “I just want to be the best leader I can for my people.”

Light Hope dipped her head. “So be it. Your lessons begin at dawn. Take your rest now.”

She stood and made her way out of the cave, probably to sleep under the open skies. Catra couldn’t imagine someone being half-horse liked staying cooped up in a cave in the earth all night. Even she was barely alright with it, but she would rather stay near Adora then outside in a strange environment on the edge of winter.

“Can you believe it?” Glimmer giggled from where she sat beside Bow. In the half-light, her dark eyes seemed to glow with the fire’s light. “We are actually getting trained to be heroes! I can’t wait!”

“Relax, Sparkles,” Catra teased. “Things don’t just happen overnight. We have a lot of hard work to do before anyone will be calling us heroes.”

Glimmer opened her mouth to protest, but Adora cut in. “Catra’s right. Now, come on. Training begins in the morning, and I don’t know about you, but I am worn out from everything that’s happened today. Let’s go get some sleep.”

The younger princess rolled her eyes at Adora, but the blonde had already turned away and was scooping up Catra. When she was deposited on her bed, Catra turned to look at Adora. The serious and calm face she was wearing around her sister and Bow had disappeared. She could see that Adora was just as giddy and excited as Glimmer was, though she was better at hiding it. Catra let out a purr as Adora settled in beside her.

"Excited, princess?"

"Definitely!" She laughed and tucked her head against Catra's chest. "Gods, I am so happy we are here. We made it. You'll be okay, and Light Hope will teach us."

"Yes, she will! She told me she's going to help me learn the magicat ways."

Adora hummed happily, and the two just lay there in comfortable silence for a bit. Catra was just on the edge of sleep when she heard the blonde chuckle and murmur, "I feel like I can fly, like nothing will ever hold me back. I feel free."

Catra purred and pulled her friend close. Here in the mountains, they could be free. There were no rules, no parents or guards or tutors frowning down at them. It was just them against the world, and nothing was going to break that apart. She fell asleep dreaming of all the adventures the four of them would have together.

Chapter End Notes

We Stan Mara and Light Hope. Also writing Light Hope makes me really wish I had a teacher like her in college when I was doing a survival course!

Mount Angelion is a play on Mount Pelion. Pelion was named after Achilles' father, Peleus, so I thought I would make Light Hope's mountain be named after Angella!

This concludes Part Two of Three! The next chapter there will be an age jump again, which will be the last of the story! I will try to return to a regular, weekly schedule for updating but we know how reliable I can be. The next one I haven't even started yet, so it will be up when it's finished!

Like, comment and share this story if you are enjoying it!

Chapter 13: Prince of Thieves

Chapter Notes

HAPPY ONE YEAR ANNIVERSARY!

I mean it's in three days, but I probably won't post again, but this fic is officially a year old! AND STILL GOING! that makes me so proud because a lot of my projects are half-assed and never finished BUT THIS WILL NOT BE THE CASE WITH TBDITE!

So, I debated adding a training montage of types in this chapter, but then decided why not leave it up to you folks as to what the best friend squad got up to training with Light Hope? As much as I wanted to include more in this chapter, it is already nine pages long and there wasn't a good place to put it. SO, if you write, I'd love to see some one shots of things that happened on Mount Angelion in the three years that passed since the last chapter! I have a few I'm going to write when inspiration fails me, or when this story is over and I haven't had enough of this universe yet.

Anyways, just a general content warning for this chapter!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Catra hissed in disgust as she sank into the snow bank that she had thought solid enough to hold her weight. She pulled out her leg and glared fiercely at the fur which was now clumped with light snowballs above her hide boot. If she'd had time, she would've paused to groom the snow out of the tangle before it became a mat, but she did not have time. She turned to the trail she was following, a limping deer that she'd been after for days, and realized the sun was nearly at it's peak, making the track hard to see. She had to find the deer soon, the tracks were fresh and that meant the creature was close.

Once again, she wished desperately that she had had enough foresight to bring Bow along. True to Light Hope's word, the young man became the best tracker of the whole group, even better than Catra although she was a close second. She had been too furious when she left several days ago to bother asking anyone to come with her.

Her eyes pounded from the harsh glare, and she reluctantly pulled the mask of birchbark that Bow had fashioned her earlier in the winter out from the pocket of her fur-lined parka. She hated wearing it, but after she experienced snow blindness in her first winter and had lost her sight completely for almost three days, she put up with only seeing a fraction of her world. Not that she really needed her sight. Her ears and nose and the pads of her hands and feet could tell her all that she needed to know, and magnified substantially when her vision was obscured.

Winters on Mount Angelion were vastly different from the winters in tepid Bright Moon. On the mountain it actually snowed and got cold enough for Catra to grow a longer coat, much to her dismay in her first year of training. But after seeing two more winters, she got used to it. She remembered with a smirk how excited she had first been when it had started to snow the first time, how she used to squeal in delight and chase and pounce on the snowflakes. That was before the lessons in snow-survival that had her shivering, her run in with frostbite that had taught her what clothes were appropriate to wear in bad weather, and of course, before the mountain's foul temper reared it's head and dumped nearly three feet of snow on them overnight, with even more the closer to the summit they got.

And now, you're out here shivering while Bow, Glimmer and Adora are all resting comfortably at the tower, she griped to herself in

her head. *All because* someone *wounded an animal but didn't bother to take it out of it's misery.*

The deer she was tracking, she knew, was wounded severely. Even now, days after it had first been on the receiving end of one of Glimmer's random outbursts, the deer was still dragging its hind-end slightly. The one leg appeared to be completely lame, as it could apparently no longer lift it if the drag marks in the snow had anything to say about it, and it was beginning to stumble. Several hours earlier, she had passed a stream where the poor creature had stumbled into. The ice was broken in a near perfect deer outline.

The previous night, Catra had heard wolves on the mountain. She knew there was a pack that called this place home, but she had only ever seen their scat or their kill sites, she had never seen them in person. Light Hope had told her how, when they caught an animal in winter, sometimes they didn't kill it before they began to feast. This horrified the magicat, and she vowed that that fate would not befall this deer, who had been injured in a stray blast from Glimmer's new fireball magic.

Catra scowled fiercely as she traipsed further along the mountain valley. She was furious with the princess. They had been training with Light Hope for just over three years, but she still had yet to learn to respect animals, even prey. Glimmer was wildly impulsive and reckless, and unless it directly effected her, she didn't think about anyone else or how they would be effected. She had successfully figured out how to bend her natural abilities to create light in the last year, and just this past week, she had taught herself to make that light hurt. And now, something was suffering for it.

“And yet, I’m the one trudging through the snow after it!” Catra hissed out loud. Glimmer had been undisturbed by the shrieking of the deer as it charged away from her.

“You go get it then, if it bothers you so much!” Those had been her words. Catra spat angrily at the ground. She was so mad, she almost didn’t pick up the scent of something else after the deer. Almost. At the last minute, she froze and sniffed deeply. Above the wet, sharp scent of the snow was the familiar frost-and-iron smell of the gods. She’d almost missed it due to being surrounded by other demigods day in and day out, but there was something strange about this one.

She dropped to all fours to climb stealthily through the snow on the edge of the ridge line. She made out the deep track of a man plodding along just below the ridge which she traipsed across. She knew she could follow him as stealthily as a panther on all fours, that was one of the first lessons Light Hope had taught her, but instead she leapt nimbly into a tree, using her claws to dig in and hold her silently as her feet scrabbled for purchase. The hide boots were good to keep out frostbite and hypothermia, and while they were abnormally thin-soled for a winter garment so she could still feel the ground on which she stood, they were durable enough that her claws on her feet were useless. Still, what they lacked in grip they made up for in stealth as she crept her way along the branches of the tree on all fours. Trees were stealthier—and drier—than crunching through the snow, though she would have to make sure not to disturb too much snow as she went.

Leaping quietly from tree to tree, Catra followed the trail. She growled low in her throat as she saw that the man stepped

carefully, and that he followed the deer's path. He was clearly hunting it as well. The tracks were fresh, the scents still lingering in both, but she had yet to see or hear her quarry. She was hoping she would be able to get the advantage and shoot the deer with the bow that was strapped to her back, but just as she was debating climbing higher, there was an animal scream from further down the valley. The deer's death cry as the man got to it first.

Flattening her ears crossly, Catra continued to make her way down the side of the mountain, her tail flicking as she jumped from branch to branch like a squirrel. There goes any hope of food she would have for the return trip home. Her supply of dried berries and smoked boar meat from the tower had run out that morning, as she carelessly thought she would have procured the deer that day and did not need to save any food.

Idiot, she chastised herself. *What is Light Hope always telling you about over-preparing? Now you're three days from home, you have no food, and your only quarry was just killed. There's been no prey tracks for a day and a half, you don't know this area of the mountain well, a storm could roll in at any time, and there's a stranger below who could be an enemy.What are you going to do now?*

Catra could now hear the man as he dragged the deer through the woods to a more comfortable place to skin and butcher it. With the noise disguising her approach, she leapt more nimbly, pausing when the man paused, and staying light on her toes. Eventually, she found him. She was perched above him like an owl, occasionally lashing her tail to keep her balance as she peered down at him, where he was crouched over the deer.

He was a handsome man, young and rugged. He had a smattering of freckles across the bridge of his nose, and a face that could use a shave. His hair was long and slightly wavy, falling down past his shoulders. His back was to her, and his posture was relaxed.

Catra raised her bow—her most disliked weapon but admittedly more flexible to carry while hunting—and took aim, but to her surprise, the man started laughing.

"Put down the bow, Catra, and come down from the tree." She was so startled by him saying her name that she accidentally shot her arrow. Without even looking, the man reached out and grabbed the arrow from where it was flying just off to his right. Only then did he turn and face the girl in the tree with a mirthful grin on his face. She was struck by how much he looked like a younger version of Micah. But even so she nocked another arrow.

"That was your warning," she growled. "The next one will be between your eyes."

The mischievous glint hardened into something less patient and suddenly, Catra was out of the tree and in front of him, her bow being scrutinized by the man as he ran it through his hands. She glanced around in confusion, trying to figure out how she had gone from in the tree several feet away from him to right in front of him, unarmed and unharmed, in the space of less than a heartbeat.

“A nice bow,” the man observed, balancing it in his palm. “Although, something tells me you prefer my sister’s weapons over my brother’s.”

“Who are you?” Her temper was short, but something warned her not to attack this newcomer.

He sighed, almost disappointed. “You humans lack all creative thinking these days.” He leaned on her bow so hard that it creaked dangerously. “Even after I got you this gift.”

He motioned to the deer lying behind him and Catra’s eyes narrowed suspiciously. She clued in to what he said, you humans, and his sister’s weapons. She-Ra, the goddess of war, who preferred the sword and spear over the bow, was the sister of Apollo, the prophetic sun god who’s treasured weapon was his bow. She wracked her brain for all the children of Zeus and then realized she knew exactly who this god was.

“You stole that deer,” she murmured casually, removing her snow-mask so that the god could see her eyes—an appropriate gesture of respect. The man smiled again, and Catra thought that his face seemed made for either frowning or smiling—a neutral expression on his face would seem wrong. “But then again, you are a thief’s patron, aren’t you, Hermes?”

The grin broadened and approval gleamed in Hermes’ dark eyes. “My sister was right. You are a clever one!”

Catra's ear twitched, uncomfortable with the idea that She-Ra spoke of her. Instead of voicing her feelings, she studied the deer that lay in the snow, the warm blood from the wound on it's neck steaming as it met the cold air. "So, what brings you here? I'm sure it's no coincidence that the Messenger God just happened upon me out here."

"You would be correct in assuming so." He leaned against a snowy boulder and shouldered Catra's bow. "I was hoping you'd be able to take me to the Crystal Tower. I'd like to meet my niece. I hear it's her birthday." With a slight jolt, Catra counted the days and realized he was right. It was Adora's birthday! How had she forgotten? *Too bad I'll be out here all day,* she thought miserably. *Unable to celebrate.* Hermes motioned behind him with his thumb. "I even have gifts! For all of you." Indeed, appearing behind the god was a cart laden with different objects underneath blankets. The girl wasn't sure if she trusted Hermes, but she was alone with him, and unable to hold her own against a god.

"Fine. But first we clean the deer. I spent too long tracking him for all my efforts to be wasted now."

"Say no more!" With speed that was jarring to see, Hermes set to work on the deer. In a matter of minutes, he had drawn and quartered all the meat and useable organs, peeled back the skin and flesh off the long bones to make arrows, and had the cleanest hide Catra had ever seen rolled up in a bundle alongside the buck's small antlers. He loaded everything up into the cart and stared at Catra expectantly, remarkably clean for having just butchered something.

“It’s a couple days walk, so we better set out.” She readjusted her pack and turned back the way she came, but Hermes twisted his face.

“Oh no, that simply won’t do. Hop in the cart, we will be there in no time.”

Catra’s tail lashed and she flattened her ears slightly. “I hate teleporting.”

“Who said anything about teleporting? Just get in. If I wanted to hurt you, I wouldn’t have let you sneak up on me and find me.”

Shrugging, Catra leapt up onto the wagon, perching on the edge with her feet dangling over the tail. For a moment, nothing happened. Then, the world blurred like she hadn’t blinked for awhile, or was staring through tears. She blinked it away and realized with a jolt that she recognized these woods. They were back on the slopes of Angelion, close to where the Crystal Tower was, but still a good distance away.

“Why did we stop here?” She asked, hopping off of her perch and walking around to the front of the cart, where Hermes was setting down his load. “Couldn’t you take us all the way to the entrance?”

“This is as far as gods are allowed without spoken permission from Light Hope or one of her trainees. It is the one place on earth that we are blind to.”

Catra thought back to all the times She-Ra had visited throughout the years. She had never come to the Crystal Tower, had always met Adora further down the slope. Now she knew why. *Why did She-Ra never go see the one who loves her?* She wondered to herself.

"Do you give me permission to enter?" Hermes prompted her, his dark eyes bringing her back to the present.

"If I say yes, is it permanent or just this once?" There was absolutely no way she would give permanent permission to a god of any kind to invade their privacy or show up unannounced. She liked living in the blindspot, undisturbed.

"Just this once," Hermes answered, a knowing smirk on his face. "You humans and your privacy."

"Stop saying us humans, you sound weird." Her ear twitched uncomfortably. She was unnerved by how easily he could read her. "I give you, Hermes, Messenger of the Gods, permission to enter the Crystal Tower."

She waited for something to happen, some kind of magical tingle or something that would tell her it worked, but instead, all that happened was Hermes picked up the handles of his cart and took a couple steps forward. "You know, all you had to say was sure, but hey, bonus points for formality."

Catra growled as he made his way past her, and she begrudgingly trudged after him. She feared the gods, she respected them from afar, but up close they really riled her right up. She kept her mouth shut though. Hermes had brought her back home to celebrate Adora's birthday. That was enough to lighten her heart.

She took one of the handles of the cart and helped the immortal haul it up the hill. Light Hope greeted them at the plateau, where the hill flattened into a wide clearing ringed on three sides by woods, and tapering at the far end to the large crystalline structure that jutted from the forest floor. The Crystal Tower.

"Welcome Hermes, God of Thieves," Light Hope addressed the god first, as was proper custom. Was there an edge to her voice as she titled him? She turned her sharp eyes onto Catra and continued her formal greeting. "Welcome Catra, daughter of Shadow Weaver, back from your hunt. I take it you were successful?"

"I'd say!" Hermes chimed in as Catra opened her mouth to speak. She glared daggers as he walked to the back of the cart and slung the deer's carcass and several tied bundles of it's meat over his shoulder. "There's enough meat on this deer to last you through the winter!"

"Well met. You may bring the meat inside. Bow and Glimmer will prepare it." The centaur beckoned for the two to follow her and Catra was more than eager to. Her tail, feet and hands were freezing, and she was impatiently scuffing her feet as she waited for permission to enter. She practically ran in after Hermes and

Light Hope, sighing in delight. The cavern was naturally much warmer than the air outside, the crystal having formed in a vent made by a volcano that resided under the mountain. With the added layer of warmth from the hearty fire where Bow, Glimmer and Adora were sitting on mountain goat skins, it was plenty comfortable, just enough heat to forget that winter was just outside the door.

Catra let out a small purr as Adora and her friends turned and caught sight of her. She hurried over and dropped down beside Adora, shivering as she leaned against the blonde.

"Happy birthday," she whispered softly.

"Thank you. I'm glad you're home," the blonde said, wrapping her arms around Catra and pulling her closer to the fire. "Gods you're freezing!"

"It's good to be home," Catra sighed. "It is winter out there. Hard to believe it in here though, you three must've just been sitting around again!"

"Not sitting around," Bow corrected, smiling jovially at the magicat. "I've been fletching and making arrows for the last two days, and Glimmer and Adora have been trying to make spring clothes!"

“Trying being the keyword?” She guessed, chuckling a bit as she saw the ragged attempts at something that resembled a toga tucked in a cleft of the cave.

“It’s a *toga*!” Adora protested. “Honestly, they’re much more difficult than they look!”

“Right, okay.”

“Let’s see you try then, Catra,” Glimmer challenged. “See if you can do better!”

“I probably could! I listen when Light Hope is teaching, unlike you.” Her tone was teasing, but there was an edge to it. She met Glimmer’s eye, a challenge ringing silently in the air. Glimmer glared back, not missing Catra’s hidden meaning about the deer, and not feeling abashed at all.

“Alright, let’s not come to blows about clothes,” Hermes interrupted, appearing out of the shadows where he must have left his cart. “Honestly, clothes are highly overrated anyways. No one is unhappy when they’re naked!” He let out a laugh, but quieted himself when no one else joined in.

“Who are you?” Glimmer asked, a hostile tone in her voice and frown.

“I have many names, little lady, but you can call me Uncle. My name is Hermes, I’m your mother’s kin.”

Immediately, the attitude of the group shifted from suspicion to awe in a matter of seconds. Bow, Glimmer and Adora all bowed to Hermes while Catra just leaned back and rolled her eyes. The god only had eyes for Adora, which made Catra’s tail twitch.

“And you must be Adora, Mara’s daughter.”

“I am,” Adora stated proudly, head high as she straightened her posture.

“It is good to finally meet you, niece. My sisters have kept you under quite the tight lock and key for the past sixteen years.”

“It’s good to meet you as well. What brings you here today?”

“As you have turned sixteen years old today, the veil that your mother used to shield you from contacting the other gods has been lifted. Several of your kin have been keeping an eye on you and your friends, and wished to bestow you gifts. I am here to deliver them.”

“All of us?” Glimmer asked, with a sideways look over at Catra. Catra growled but Adora tugged on her, showing her the blonde was paying attention.

She leaned back and whispered in her therapon's ear, "I'm going to murder your sister."

Adora snorted and jostled Catra. "No. It's my birthday."

The magicat pouted playfully but before she could rebuke, Hermes cleared his throat and cast a pointed look in their direction.

"If you're quite done." He snapped his fingers and his cart moved on it's own, placing itself right before them in a heartbeat. He removed the cover off the back of the wagon, and took a beautiful golden bow and a leather quiver full of fine-crafted golden arrows off first. "For the archer of the group, Bow. Apollo has been watching your skill with the bow carefully, as has his sister, Artemis. He carved this bow for you from one of the rays of the sun. The arrows do not easily miss their targets."

Even though the boy was clearly about to pass out from excitement, Bow managed not to weep for joy and instead accepted the bow with a barely concealed whimper of delight. He bowed his head low to the god and stepped back, unable to take his eyes off the precious metal in his hands. Then, Hermes turned to Glimmer.

"To Glimmer of Bright Moon, daughter of my titan kin, I present to you this staff." He held out a beautiful sorcerer's tool—a long shaft of ironwood, with a tip that bore the Bright Moon crest, inlaid with

moonstone. “Your parents wished for me to bring this to you, to help you with your studies of magic. Use it well to hone in on your natural skill.”

Glimmer accepted the gift sombrely and went to join Bow, also unable to take her eyes off the staff. Hermes turned to Adora with a jovial smile as he reached behind him and pulled out a dazzling set of armour.

“Adora, heir of Bright Moon, your mother presents you with this mighty gift on the day of your birth.” He presented the armour in separate bits, first the amazingly white-and-gold cuirass—that was neither iron nor bronze but a metal that Catra had never seen before, edged and detailed with solid gold highlights and with a sapphire imbedded into the centre of it—then the solid gold spaulder over her sword arm, and the golden greaves and braces for her legs and arms. The final piece to her armour was a beautiful gold helm with a ruby set at the forehead and wings expanding off the sides. It was a fairly open design, as Adora never needed to wear a helm—she was that quick—and wore one only to identify herself. Catra realized with a jolt how similar to her red headpiece it was, and wondered if that was on purpose. “The cuirass is formed from a special metal, the same that makes Zeus’ thunderbolt. It was crafted by Entrapta, goddess of the forge, and will not fail you easily.”

He held it out to Adora, who eagerly slipped into the armour. The armour, of course, fit perfectly, and with every piece, Adora seemed to grow. She was always tall, but with the cuirass accentuating her muscles, it felt like she towered over everyone, a much higher height than what she normally was. And the glow! Somehow, that white metal that protected her torso and everything important inside of it made Adora glow. Had Catra not

known her, she would've thought she was in the presence of some goddess. Adora's pale blue eyes flickered over to Catra, who felt compelled to bow to her, dipping down onto one knee.

If you were a goddess, she thought to herself, feeling hunger awaken in her belly that had nothing to do with food, *I would worship you every day. You could tell me where to go and what to do, and I would listen. There would be nothing I wouldn't do for you.*

Out loud, she murmured, "I'll follow you anywhere dressed like that."

Hermes chuckled wickedly while Adora went a deep red and Bow and Glimmer stared.

"And last, but not least," continued the immortal.

Catra dragged her eyes off of Adora reluctantly, and back to the Messenger God. She was startled to find him staring right at her.

"Catra of Bright Moon and the Fright Zone, I present to you a special gift indeed." He turned and rummaged through the supplies on the wagon before he emerged with what he was looking for; a shield. It was a normal looking shield like the ones used in Bright Moon; wooden with a ring of bronze along the outside and a crescent shaped indent on the far side for her spear to go through as a kind of defence. But what was odd about this

shield was the logo on the front of it. Instead of the moon-and-diamond sigil of Bright Moon, there was the face of a lion-like cat etched into the wood with cyan dye. She knelt in front of it and ran her hands over the shield. She swore she could hear a rumbling like a big cat coming from the shield.

"This is the shield of Melog," Hermes continued, whirling around behind Catra and reaching over her to fit the shield onto her right arm. "Melog was created using clay from the River Phlegethon, where the Elder Cyclopses made Hades' helm of invisibility. They are a close cousin of the Nemean Lion, and when you wear their shield, you possess their ability of moving unnoticed across enemy lines."

As soon as the last clasp was done up around her wrist, there was a collective gasp from her friends. She looked up and found them casting around their eyes around her.

"What?" She asked warily.

"You've completely disappeared!" Adora gasped, peering into the shadows as if she was trying to see Catra. Only Hermes and Light Hope stared right where Catra was. Hermes continued, "This gift comes to you from Entrapta, who seems to have taken a shining to you. If you ever need an ally, the Tinkerer is in your corner."

Feeling mischievous,Catra turned and crept behind Glimmer, before removing the shield and whispering, "Boo!" in the younger girl's ear.

She shrieked and turned to Catra, aiming a surprised punch at the brunette's head that she was able to duck easily. The magicat laughed in joy and flashed Glimmer a sharp-toothed grin. "Now you know how it feels, Sparkles, for someone to creep up behind you!"

The younger princess glared with dark eyes, but there was grudging respect there. Before more could be said, Light Hope stood and rasped her front hoof over the hard crystalline floor.

"Now that gifts are done, let's prepare a meal for our guest. I'm sure he is hungry after travelling all this way." She flashed Hermes a glance that was cool and polite, but held no friendliness. Catra wondered what happened that made the centaur dislike the gods so much. Not that she blamed her, the majority of the gods seemed to just do whatever they wanted with no regard for who they hurt in the meantime.

She cast her eyes to Adora, who was still looking like a goddess in her sparkling new armour. As Bow and Glimmer approached the deer, she saw Adora looking towards the entrance with a faraway look in her pale eyes. Catra knew that look. She got that way whenever Mara was near. Catra debated following as Adora stood and made her way out into the night, but as she heard Glimmer mentioning something about berries that could be lethal when not prepared properly, she opted to stay put.

She watched Adora walk away, then turned and began to help prep their meal.

Chapter End Notes

Adora’s POV in the next chapter!

There MAY be some changes in the details of the story. I’m not sure yet, just an early idea, but I’m frustrated with how far in I am and how the war hasn’t even started yet. So, I’m thinking I might split it up into two stories, the more innocent childhood backstory, and then the actual war. Give me a few days to think about it, but if I do go through with that, then the title will change as well as some of the tags! But for now, thanks for reading!

Your support means a lot to me! Like, comment and be sure to follow it for updates!

Chapter 14: All the Secrets We Keep Inside

Chapter Notes

> Sorry it's been awhile again! This was done ages ago, I just forgot to post it (whoops!) Hope you're all doing well, and sticking with this story! I promise you it will get done, no matter how long it takes me to write. I am still loving the crap out of this story and I hope you are too!
>
> Little CW for this chapter as there's a bit of sexual content, but nothing graphic!

See the end of the chapter for more notes

Adora made her way down the slope of the hill, adjusting one of the braces as she went. The armour she wore was incredibly comfortable, and fit her perfectly. She didn't quite understand the look in Catra's eye when she wore it, but she felt invincible when she wore it, and that was enough. She had felt Mara's summons just as the gifting was wrapping up, so made her way to where her mother liked to meet her.

She was in her goddess form, all imposing eight feet of her. Her white hair streamed behind her in a gentle breeze tossed up from the valley floor below, and her steely grey eyes were unreadable. She wore a suit of armour that matched Adora's, though her winged headpiece was more of a diadem than a proper helm, and her cuirass had larger, more imposing spaulders on both shoulders. As Adora got close to her immortal mother, those grey eyes flickered and became laced with blue, looking softer.

"Hello, daughter," she greeted her. Adora dipped her head.

“Hello, Mara. I’ve come to thank you for the gift.” She touched the chest piece with reverence and Adora saw a brief shadow flicker over Mara’s face before her expression cleared.

“The day is coming where you’ll soon have to use it. It will protect you well. There is another gift that waits for you in your father’s stable. He has agreed to train it for you.”

“A horse?” She tried to keep the excitement from her voice but could not. A ghost of a smile passed over the goddess’ face. Adora bowed low. “Thank you! I promise they’ll be well cared for.” She straightened and beamed at her mother. “I promise that I will make you proud, and when the time comes for battle, my war cry will be yours. I won’t let you down.”

To her great surprise, this did not seem to please the goddess of war. Mara turned to look out over the valley again, and this time Adora could see that she appeared mournful. “It is the day of your birth today. That should be a joyful day without mentions of war or hardships to come.” Adora was quiet, her heart hammering at the thought that she had displeased her mother. The goddess turned and looked at her. “Did you know that I tried to take you into Olympus?”

The blonde’s head jerked up and she stared in awe at Mara. “You did?”

“Yes. I was bound to your father for a year, as a gift from the gods.” She curled her lip in disdain. “He was a good man, he tried to treat me as best as he could.” Mara cupped Adora’s face in her

surprisingly warm hands, and smiled tenderly, an expression that did not grace the cold goddess's face often. "You remind me of him. You have such a big heart, and you truly care about everyone you meet. That is from your father. You may have my looks, but you are all his. When the time came for me to return to Olympus, he gave you to me, so that you could make your own destiny as a goddess. But Zeus forbade me from entering our kingdom with you. Mortals are not allowed on the summit of the mountain, he said. I had to kill you, or leave you behind."

Adora gulped, feeling her emotions welling up as Mara's hands moved from her face and clasped her own hands. "Giving you up, Adora, was the hardest thing I have ever done. But I did it so that you would have a chance to live your own life and decide your own fate. You deserve to have a chance at happiness. You are worth more than what you can give to other people."

The younger girl studied the immortal's face in shock. It was as though she had read her mind and had seen the nagging thoughts that had haunted her for most of the last three years. "You… you know?"

"I know you well, daughter. I can feel your troubled heart. I know what you long to do but refuse to for the sake of everyone you know. But they are not you. Only you can make the decision that is best for you."

Adora nodded and Mara smiled, taking a step back and removing her hands from Adora's. "Go now. Return to the feast. And tell Light Hope thank you for doing such a good job with the four of you."

“Why don’t you come say so yourself? I give you permission. Come see your old friend!”

The goddess hesitated before she shook her head. “Light Hope would not want to see me. If she did, she would’ve reached out by now. No, I am better off at a distance. Goodbye, Adora. Enjoy your friends’ company.”

Adora murmured her goodbye as her mother disappeared in a flash of light. She took her time walking up the slope, pondering what her mother had said. Near the cavern entrance, Adora heard a voice from above her.

“Hey, Adora,” Catra purred, lounging in the V of a tree languidly, her tail flicking as she examined her claws. She glanced at Adora with a mischievous glint in her eyes. “Whatcha doing?”

“Catra,” Adora greeted her easily, smiling brightly as Catra leapt from the tree and walked over. Adora took her by the waist and brought their foreheads together. Her friend trilled and her eyes fluttered shut as a contented smile graced her face. The blonde couldn’t help but stare at her.

“You’re staring,” she laughed while not opening her eyes. Adora felt the same, unfamiliar twinge in her stomach whenever her friend spoke or showed off one of the magicat tricks she’d learned. “I can literally *feel* your stare.”

“You know me too well.”

“That’s kind of my job. There’s nothing you can do that I haven’t predicted yet.” She twirled lightly, grabbing Adora’s arm and bending it in a way it wasn’t supposed to bend, all while her eyes were closed. Adora knew if she was a regular human and not a demigod, she would’ve been on the ground whimpering in pain.

“Nothing, eh?” She challenged, getting a rush of courage, she swooped in and captured Catra’s lips in her own. As her eyes were fluttering closed, she saw Catra’s gold-and-blue ones shoot open immediately. But the confusion melted quickly, and in a matter of seconds, the magicat was soft like butter beneath her lips and her hands, giving in to the attraction that had grown between the two of them for years now. Catra was the first to break the kiss, surprisingly. Adora watched her shyly, her heart hammering.

For a moment, the two just stared at each other, panting. Eventually, a wicked smirk graced Catra’s lips. “Took you long enough, princess.”

Their lips found their way back together and for a couple moments, they were just lost in each other. When they needed to surface for air, Adora blurted out what was on her mind. “I’m going to abdicate the throne!”

Catra’s eyebrows shot up, the only sign of her surprise, but she simply nodded her head after a moment. “Okay,” she said,

watching Adora closely. Her eyes were unreadable, and anxiety pulsed through Adora before Catra took her hand. "Whatever makes you happy."

"Do you mean that?"

"Of course." Catra looked mildly surprised. "Wherever you go, I go, princess. I only want the best for you."

Adora smiled and pulled Catra close. She whispered brazenly in her ear, "*You're* what's best for me." The blonde was satisfied to see Catra's eyes dilate as she looked back at her with clear and hungry want in her eyes.

Before they could delve into that further, Glimmer stuck her head out of the entrance to the cave. "Hey, we are waiting in here!" She called. "Gods, it's freezing out!"

The two jumped apart in surprise, but Glimmer just rolled her eyes. "Oh, relax. Everyone knows you two have been in love for years. Glad you finally acted on it, Adora."

Catra and Adora exchanged an embarrassed look, and both blushed darkly as they followed Glimmer back inside. Adora held tight to Catra's hand. As they walked in, the smell of the cooking deer had Adora's stomach rumbling as she realized how little she had had to eat recently.

As Catra let go and sat down beside Glimmer, jostling the younger girl playfully as she loaded up a clay plate, Adora remained standing, frozen and numb with anxiety at what she had to say. Finally, she turned to Light Hope, who was watching her with a critical eye.

"How do I go about abdicating the throne?" She asked quietly. It didn't matter how quiet she asked though, everyone heard. Hermes carried on eating as normal, but Bow and Glimmer turned to face Adora with varying expressions of surprise and disbelief.

"I'm sorry, *what?*" Glimmer looked the most surprised out of all of them.

Adora sighed and frowned down at her feet as she gathered her words carefully. "I've been thinking about this since we came here, and I believe it is time for me to turn the throne over to you."

To her surprise, Glimmer rounded fiercely on Catra out of no where. "This is your fault!" She snarled. "You've been saying things to my sister behind our backs and having her question who she is!"

"Catra had nothing to do with this," Adora replied, stepping closer to the two and holding out her hand to Catra. There was steel in her voice as she added, "And she didn't even know until just now, so I suggest you leave her out of this."

“But Adora, where is this coming from? This isn’t you. Why now?”

“I spent the last hour or so talking to my mother, She-Ra. This is me, Glimmer. For the first time in my life, I am choosing happiness over duty. Besides, the last time Netossa came to visit, she told me there’s no one else who can fight like I can. Do we really need that kind of target on Bright Moon when Salineas has already declared war on the Horde, and tensions are already high enough as is?”

Glimmer averted her eyes. They both knew of the rising flood of problems occurring in their world, Scorpia and Netossa kept them up to date when they visited. Just last month, Scorpia had told them that the Horde forces had tried to make a move against the Fright Zone, and that the armies of the Northern Reach, Dryll and Plumeria were raised and marching south to aid the Fright Zone. As it stood, Bright Moon was the only kingdom of Etheria not in an active war.

“But… why me? Catra keeps saying I’m too immature to handle things like you do.” Glimmer shot Catra a glare as the magicat snorted.

“You definitely are,” Catra threw in unhelpfully. Adora glared and her therapon raised her hands in a ‘just stating the obvious’ gesture.

“It makes sense,” Bow added, voicing his opinion. The sisters both looked over at the boy, surprised. For the most part, Bow had always stayed out of the sisters many arguments. He was always

a mediator, always finding a way to compromise between the two. Adora was just as surprised as Glimmer to hear him actually agree with her. Bow looked sheepishly at Adora as he said, "Glimmer, you *are* the actual heir according to bloodline. Once people see Adora in her armour, they'll know. There's no way people won't see it, she's the spitting image of Mara in her war gear."

"But—"

"Arrow Boy has a point, Sparkles," Catra murmured, surprisingly more gentle than Adora expected. "Wars have been started over less."

The poor fourteen year old Glimmer was looking lost, her eyes widen and her breath coming in pants. She stared at Adora like her world was coming apart.

"Look, I love our home as much as you do. I don't want anything happening to it, or anyone in it. Especially my little sister." She swooped forward and wrapped Glimmer in a strong, secure hug. "But I need to do what is right for our kingdom. And what's right for it, Glim, is for you to lead."

"I just don't wanna lose you," Glimmer whispered, hiding her face against Adora. The blonde smiled and pulled back, cupping her sister's cheek.

“Who said anything about you losing me? I’ll be beside you the whole time to guide you. You’re not getting rid of me that easily!”

She let out a watery laugh, and the group waited with baited breath. Finally, Glimmer nodded. “Okay. We will send a message with Hermes to Father in the morning.”

Hermes looked up from his meal, and his eyes were surprisingly gentle as he nodded. “I’ll make sure your father knows,” he said. A kind smile was on his face as he observed Glimmer trying her best to look brave. “You will be a great ruler someday, little one.”

As the matter was settled, and everyone settled back into their meal, Adora sat down beside Light Hope, who was observing everything coolly. As she began gnawing on her plate of ribs, Light Hope murmured, “That was a wise decision, though I must admit I am surprised you made it on your own.”

“I… had a talk with Mara,” Adora admitted. The centaur’s whole body tensed, and she swished her tail in displeasure. She always was displeased whenever Mara was brought up. Adora pressed on. “I know it displeases you that I spoke with Mara, but she is kind to me and she told me to value myself. And she was right, my whole life has been decided by everyone else. Where I live, who I’m supposed to be, there’s even a prophecy about me! But I’ve made my decision. I am grown now, an adult by all standards. I will not leave the kingdom wanting, they’ll have a good ruler in Glimmer.”

The two watched Glimmer across the fire, animatedly telling a story to Bow, Catra and Hermes. "… And up comes Adora, sprinting faster than I've ever seen her, and she says to me, 'Put your cloak back on, you idiot, there's a bear chasing me!' And she ran headlong into the cavern! I've never seen my sister run so fast in her life. And then…"

All of the others were laughing along and enraptured with her tale, but Adora noticed one of Catra's ears flicked back towards her. She smiled to herself. Her dedicated therapon—no, her *lover*—was keeping one ear on her, ready to jump in if needed. Adora smiled to herself.

"Glimmer is… unrefined, but she does have potential. She has a natural charisma when it comes to people that you lack." Light Hope swished her tail and stood from the fire, motioning Adora to follow her. The two walked out of the cave and into the snow, no destination in mind, as Light Hope continued. "I may not personally agree with your choice, but I see the wisdom in it. Your father will as well."

"Light Hope? May I ask you a question?"

The trainer of heroes paused and looked back over her shoulder at the younger woman. "I know what you're going to ask, but if if you must, do so quickly."

Adora hesitated, trying to find a way to properly word her question. Finally, she simply sighed and asked, "Why does mentioning Mara upset you so much?"

Light Hope visibly flinched from the question, then slumped in defeat. She turned back to face Adora and her face was wide open for the first time. Adora could see every emotion on her face. And out of every single one of them, love was loudest. The centaur pulled down the corner of her tunic, revealing an ugly scar just below her collarbone. It was puckered as though it had been burnt once, and was as long as Adora's hand. She gasped softly. "She did this to you? But, I thought you were a friend to the gods!"

"Look closer, Adora." The blonde peered closer and found traces of a tattoo under the scar. The more she observed it, the clearer the story became. Not many people had tattoos in their culture. And those that did spent a fortune with the few highly coveted artists, and only got them when they were certain they had found their soulmate. And to cut it away? The grooved, tight edges and slashing, hacked at markings of the scar spoke of unbearable pain.

"She was your—?"

"She was my *everything*." The amount of love and pain in Light Hope's voice was like nothing Adora had heard before. "And I was hers. Or so I thought."

"What… happened?"

"You did." Those two words were spoken in the voice of a still lake right before a storm. Deadly calm and quiet. Adora took a half-step away from her mentor of three years, but she knew Light Hope would do nothing to hurt her. "Mara left one night before the dawn was even a thought to Artemis and Angella. She'd been summoned to Olympus and said she'd be back before the evening. But she didn't come home. She'd been backed into a deal with a mortal man. She was to be his wife for a year. Because he was so *noble*." The barest hint of a snarl entered her calm voice. "I begged her to come back, pleaded with her. Between the two of us, we could take on her Olympian kin, should they come after her for breaking her promise. We'd be safe, I would've protected her. But then, she told me she was with child. With you, and your brother."

Brother? I have a brother*?!* Adora was thunderstruck, but couldn't form any words. Light Hope looked up at her and continued in the barest of whispers, "I would've loved you as my own. I could've given you and Mara everything you ever dreamed of. But she'd grown to care for your father, and wouldn't deprive him of his children.

"She left me. She *left* me, didn't even give me a say, wouldn't give me a *choice*. We could've figured everything out, but she turned away without giving us a chance. So I lashed out. I called her a coward, told her to come face me if she could bare it. She stared right through me. Anytime I've seen her since then, she has stared through me as though I am a stranger. So, I cut her mark away."

Adora bowed her head, her heart in turmoil. She had no idea Light Hope had been in love with her mother! No wonder she turned sour at the mention of the Goddess of War.

"It is not that it is upsetting to speak of Mara," the immortal centaur continued after a moment or two of silence. "I've made my peace with it all. I suppose the emotion you would call what I feel is hurt. It is not an emotion my kind is meant to feel."

"I'm sorry," Adora whispered. "I had no idea."

Light Hope blinked a couple of times before she hid her tumultuous emotions were hidden behind her calm mask again. "It is in the past. I'd prefer it if you not told anyone this."

"Of course, but—"

"That's enough questions for now, Adora. Go rejoin your friends; your food is getting cold."

Her head still spinning, Adora dipped her head and returned to the cave where her friends were.

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Catra, as usual, was the first one to hear Adora's soft footfalls returning from wherever she had been with Light Hope. The clever centaur had discovered the extent of Catra's hearing, and had spoken to Adora out of range. She turned to the blonde

princess with a purr that faltered when she saw the turbulent expression on her face.

"All good, Adora?" Bow asked. Catra wasn't the only one who noticed. The other two had paused their debate on whether riding a centaur was considered wrong or not when they saw the faraway look in her eyes.

She focused her pale gaze on Catra long enough to nod. She went to lean her head against Catra's shoulder, something she did quite often when she wanted physical reassurance, then she paused and sunk lower until she was laid out in the magicat's lap. Normally, they only did that when they were alone, but Adora was no longer hiding her feelings for Catra, so there was no need to hide their closeness. Catra barely suppressed a trill of joy as she ran her hands through her lover's soft hair.

Bow and Glimmer were openly gawking, but a fierce glare and pinned back ears from Catra had the two dropping their eyes and going back to their debate.

"What happened?" Catra asked lowly, when the two were thoroughly absorbed in their arguments. She curled her tail protectively over Adora, who looked about as fragile as she did when she found out she was adopted.

"I have a brother." Her reply was barely audible, more vibration than actual words, as she mumbled into Catra's stomach. She paused in her stroking of Adora's hair for a moment before she started braiding.

“Do you want to talk about it?”

Adora shook her head. Catra could feel her trembling beneath her hands. She leaned close and pressed a kiss on her temple. “I’ll be here when you do, I promise.”

She was afraid that Adora was going to shatter like she had before, that the revelation of a brother was enough to knock her new supports out from under her and send her careening into another self-identity crisis, but after a few moments of silent comfort, the blonde sat up straight and began to eat her food. There was a distance in her eyes, but whenever she met Catra’s glance, they warmed a bit. The magicat knew Adora wasn’t going to fall apart again. And that was good enough for her.

The four of them sat around the fire with the Messenger God, laughing and joking with him as though he were one of them for hours. Catra found him more amicable as the night wore on and the wine he had brought as a gift for Light Hope was passed around. The sky had darkened into an inky black smudge just barely visible through the entrance to the cave, and Light Hope had already gone out to sleep in the glade nearby when several yawns from Bow and Glimmer had the conversations winding down.

“I suppose I best be off,” Hermes said, standing and stretching. “I’ve got messages to deliver, after all. I’m sure I’ll see you all soon enough.”

“I think we will turn in too,” Glimmer said, motioning to herself and Bow. “We’ve been given a lot to think about and I think we could all use a good rest.”

Catra and Adora murmured their good nights to the two as they retreated to their own alcove on the other side of the cave, then faced each other.

“Are you tired?” Catra asked. She could see heat reddening Adora’s cheeks, though her eyes were still bright and clear. The wine had the same effect on her, warming her up from the inside out, but it was not enough to feel intoxicated by it. It just took some of her reservations down.

“No,” Adora answered. She moved closer to Catra and frowned carefully at her face like she was debating something.

“Me neither. I—mmph!” Her sentence was cut off as Adora swooped in and crushed their lips together. It was just as soft and tantalizing as before, and sent Catra’s heart skittering through her chest in the same way. She grasped Adora’s face in her hands and kissed deeper, speaking to the passion and love she felt for her friend for years. There was no reason this time to pull away. When the two resurfaced for air, breathing hard, they stared into the depths of each other’s eyes.

I love you, I love you, sang in Catra’s mind. She wanted so desperately to tell her, but still she hesitated, afraid of what her feelings could do. Adora offered a small smile and cupped her cheek. “Adora—”

“I know,” she whispered. Her chest was still rising and falling rapidly as her eyes roved across Catra’s body. “I know.”

“Shall we move this back to our bed?” The magicat suggested with a sultry purr. She was rewarded for her flirtations with a dark and hungry look taking over Adora. A wicked smirk covered her face and she scooped Catra up in her arms, making her way to their chamber.

“I could’ve walked y’know.”

“But where’s the fun in that?” Adora laughed. As she set her down gently on the pelts, her armour clinked, and it was only then that an idea formed in Catra’s mind.

“May I?” She motioned to the armour hesitantly. The blonde froze in surprise, and for a moment Catra thought she would reject the unspoken plan. But then she nodded.

Catra scooted closer until she was on her knees mere inches away from Adora. Searching her eyes for any sign of discomfort the whole time, Catra gently loosened the clasps and ties on her breastplate. Adora helped her where her fingers skittered, but eventually, the breastplate came off, followed by the braces and headgear. With her golden armour laid out carefully at the foot of the bed, Adora was human once more, kneeling on the bed in only her tunic.

Her hands gently lifted the shirt, resting for a moment on Adora's taut abdomen. "Is this alright?" She breathed. Adora nodded again, not hesitating this time, and Catra pulled the garment over her head.

She took in the sight of Adora, bare in front of her as they had been many times growing up, but this time, she allowed herself to *look*. She took in her toned abs and arms, her pale, soft skin, the swell of her breasts rising from her chest. She never really noticed it as Adora always tried to hide her feminine features, but she was actually fuller in the chest than Catra, which surprised her. She didn't dare glance below her navel. Not yet anyway.

"Your turn," came a growly rasp from Adora's throat. Catra's eyes snapped back up to hers and the hunger in those winter depths was raw and painfully obvious. Catra laughed and went to remove her clothing, but Adora's calloused hands held her own, stopping her in her way. "Let me, please."

She nodded her consent, and Adora quickly but carefully stripped Catra, until they were both bare and taking each other in.

"Is this what you want?" Adora asked softly, always the caretaker, always making sure Catra was okay.

"I've wanted this since the moment I laid eyes on you," she purred. And that was it. There was no more discussion, the two charged each other like they were going into a dance or a battle,

and dissolved into one another for the first time, exploring and testing and just enjoying the chance to finally love and be loved. For this one moment, they shed everything except their fumbling but earnest passion for each other. There was no war threats looming, no gods, no kingdoms to manage or sisters to worry about. For this perfect, blissful moment, it was just Catra and Adora, unable to see where one started and the other began.Waves of pleasure bathed over Catra with every motion, every flick of Adora's adept fingers. For a long time, nothing else mattered.

When they eventually crashed to the bed in exhaustion, skin damp with sweat, the taste of the other on their lips, the scent of their love-making laying heavy in the air, Catra felt as though her life hadn't been whole until that moment. She clung to Adora, her body rumbling with the soft purrs that rippled through her, and lazily scent-marked her as she had often wanted to do growing up.

"You're mine," she whispered, half-possessive, half-awed.

"I'm yours," Adora returned. "Now and forever more."

Something in her voice made Catra pause, and she sat slowly up. "You didn't abdicate the throne for me… did you?"

"No." Adora grabbed her hand and pulled her back down so her head was resting on the blonde's chest. "No I didn't. I did that for me, I made the decision for me. You heard what I said to Glimmer. That was all true."

Catra couldn’t help herself and swivelled her ear against Adora’s chest. A rumbling chuckle jostled her a bit.

“Are you seeing if I am lying?” Adora guessed. Catra sheepishly flattened her ear back and looked up at Adora.

“Force of habit. I forgot you can’t lie or act to save your life!”

“You take that back!” The princess mock-gasped and began to tickle Catra behind the ears. She squealed, laughing and leapt up. They ran around the room laughing and trying to tickle each other for another couple of moments, in complete bliss. At some point, the two of them collapsed together, panting, in a tangle of limbs and laughter. Catra had never felt so close to Adora. There was something so natural and beautiful about spending the night with her. Skin to skin, without feeling afraid of it.

She fell asleep easier than she ever had before, tucked up against the love of her life. It was the best sleep she could remember, and she never wanted the feeling of complete love and bliss to disappear. But of course, the gods found teasing Catra to be the best sport.

“Catra, wake up,” Adora whispered in her ear. The magicat was immediately alert. She blinked open her eyes, surprised to find their cavern still in complete dark despite the fact that she could hear voices murmuring in the main cave. She instantly became aware of how rigid Adora was beneath her.

“What’s going on?” She asked lowly.

“I’m not sure. I heard Light Hope and she doesn’t sound thrilled. Let’s go check it out.” She silently slid out from under Catra, a hand already going to the sword she stowed nearby. Catra followed, stealthy as ever. She debated grabbing her shield, but decided against it. She had the advantage by knowing where all the good hiding spots in the cave were, anyway.

She slipped behind a pillar of crystal outside of their cavern, and pulled Adora with her. They were about to creep further in, when a strange, yet familiar, voice rose in a desperate plea.

“Please, Hope, you *must* let me see my daughter!”

“I already told you, Mara,” Light Hope said coolly. “This can wait until morning. Let her sleep. Besides, I’m not sure who gave you permission to be here, but—”

“Mara?” Adora called, stepping out into the open. Catra followed suit, seeing as they had nothing to fear if the intruder was Adora’s mother.

“Catra? Adora?” Glimmer called. Catra turned and found Adora’s sister peering out over the lip of her’s and Bow’s cavern.

“What’s going on?” Bow asked, appearing behind Glimmer. The two clambered into the cavern and peered nervously over at Mara. “We heard voices.”

“It’s just Mara,” Catra replied. She turned back to the goddess and gave a little start at the sight of the immortal. She was in her human disguise, but she was disheveled and dirty, and there was a near wild look in her steely grey eyes. She staggered over to Adora, and Catra realized the smudges of what looked like dirt on her cheeks was actually blood. And dappled over everything was ichor, the golden blood of the gods.

“Adora,” the goddess sighed, cupping her daughter’s cheek. “Good. You’re alright.”

“Why wouldn’t I be?” The blonde took a step back, alarm flickering across her face at her mother’s bedraggled appearance. “Are *you* alright?”

“Never mind about me, I came from Grey Skull. I come with a message and a warning. Shadow Weaver marches on Bright Moon wielding a flag of war. She has come to ask Micah to align with her or die. She demands Bright Moon join the war against Eternia, and King Micah is refusing. War, it would appear, comes to you.”

Chapter End Notes

Oooo why was Mara in Grey Skull do you think? 👀

Please feel free to interact, I love reading your comments! I’m still toying with the idea of doing two stories, this one as a lighter, fluffier “prequel” and then the actual war part of the

story, with a bit of darker themes. Let me know what you think, I would honestly love your feedback!

End Notes

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